

Bansuri Swaraj hails HC order in liquor policy case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BJP MP Bansuri Swaraj on Tuesday hailed Delhi High Court Justice Swarna Kanta Sharma's order not to recuse herself from hearing the liquor policy case involving former chief minister and AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal and others.

Addressing a press conference here, Swaraj said the court's decision reaffirms judicial independence and rejects attempts by the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) to run a coordinated campaign to build pressure on the court. "Kejriwal is a bully who tried to pressurise a female member of the judiciary. It was not about a judge change but a game change and narrative control by AAP, a drama company," Swaraj alleged. "What lends a deeper disquiet is the attempt to attach a media



narrative, including vilification without any accountability. This court has proceeded to decide the matter uninfluenced by any such pressure," she said, quoting from the High Court order. "A courtroom cannot be a theatre of perception. It is a space where doubt must yield to reason. The reputation of a judge cannot be so fragile that it would yield without proof to insinuations," Swaraj, who is still a

lawyer by profession, said. Kejriwal had raised several objections against Justice Sharma hearing the CBI's plea against his discharge in the liquor-policy case, including that she had earlier denied him relief on his petition challenging his arrest and refused to grant relief on the bail pleas of other accused, including Manish Sisodia and K Kavitha. In a sharp attack, the New Delhi MP said, "The kind of

attack and allegations they made against a woman judge — against her family, her children, against her as a mother — were clearly aimed at pressuring her to recuse herself from the case."

"But I want to remind and warn Kejriwal and the Aam Aadmi Party that whenever a woman has been insulted in this country's history, those responsible — along with their entire support system — have faced destruction," she said.

She further accused the party of being "anti-women", saying, "The Aam Aadmi Party is the same party that voted against the Women's Reservation Amendment (Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam), which would have ensured that 33 per cent reservation in state legislative assemblies and Parliament is implemented from 2029 itself."

Centre approves resumption of wheat procurement

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre has approved the resumption of wheat procurement in Delhi through the Food Corporation of India, following a request from Chief Minister Rekha Gupta. The move, which comes after a break since the 2021-22 season, is expected to ensure farmers receive the Minimum Support Price and reduce their dependence on markets outside the capital.

Procurement for the 2026-27 rabi marketing season will begin on April 24 at two locations, the FCI depot in Narela and the Najafgarh mandi. Officials said the decision will allow farmers to sell their produce closer to home and avoid additional transport costs. The Chief Minister welcomed the Centre's decision and said it reflects a strong commitment to farmer welfare and income security.

She said the absence of local procurement had forced farmers to sell their crops below the support price in recent years, affecting their



PROCUREMENT FOR THE 2026-27 RABI MARKETING SEASON WILL BEGIN ON APRIL 24 AT TWO LOCATIONS, THE FCI DEPOT IN NARELA AND THE NAJAFGARH MANDI

earnings. "The restart of procurement is a major step in protecting farmers' interests. It will ensure they get fair value for their produce and reduce financial pressure," she said. The Chief Minister had recently written to the Union Minister of Consumer Affairs,

Food and Public Distribution, Pralhad Joshi, seeking urgent intervention to restart wheat procurement in Delhi during the ongoing season. In her letter, she highlighted that farmers were being pushed to sell their produce outside Delhi or at lower rates due to the lack of procurement facilities within the city.

Following the request, the Centre directed the Food Corporation of India to resume operations in the capital. Officials said this will help stabilise local markets and improve supply chain efficiency. According to the Delhi government, local procurement will bring several benefits. It will reduce the

need for farmers to transport their produce to neighbouring states, cutting logistics and handling costs. It will also help integrate locally procured wheat into the public distribution system, thereby strengthening food security in the capital.

The Chief Minister said limiting the outward movement of grain will also help maintain balance in local supply and demand. She added that the initiative aligns with the broader national focus on ensuring stable and fair incomes for farmers.

Delhi has around 29,000 hectares under cultivation and produces nearly 80,000 metric tonnes of wheat annually. Officials said this production exceeds local consumption, creating a surplus that can be procured under the government system.

The resumption of procurement is expected to benefit around 21,000 farmers in the capital. Authorities said arrangements are being made to ensure smooth operations at procurement centres.

Global delegates visit Assembly

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A group of 43 delegates from 18 countries visited the Delhi Legislative Assembly on Tuesday as part of an international training programme, where Speaker Vijender Gupta highlighted the importance of precise legislative drafting in strengthening democratic governance.

Addressing participants of the 37th International Training Programme in Legislative Drafting, organised by the Parliamentary Research and Training Institute for Democracies, Gupta said the effectiveness of laws depends on how clearly they are framed. He said well-drafted legislation is essential to protect rights, ensure accountability and influence everyday governance.

The visiting delegation included representatives from countries such as Bangladesh, Bhutan, Oman, Kenya, Sri Lanka, the Philippines and Tanzania. Officials said the visit was aimed at sharing institutional practices and strengthening international cooperation in legislative processes.

Gupta placed the Delhi Assembly in its historical context during his address. He said the building, constructed in 1912, has served as a key site of legislative



activity since the colonial period. It earlier housed the Imperial Legislative Council and later the Central Legislative Assembly under the Government of India Act of 1919.

He also recalled the election of Vitthalbhai Patel as the first Indian President of the Assembly in 1925. He described it as an important moment in the assertion of legislative independence during colonial rule. Referring to the presence of Mahatma Gandhi during key deliberations, Gupta said the Assembly has historically been a space where democratic ideas evolved.

As part of the visit, delegates toured the Assembly premises and attended a screening of a documentary on Vitthalbhai Patel. They were also introduced to a publication detailing the institution's history, a copy of which was presented to programme officials for archival purposes.

Highlighting recent reforms, Gupta said the Assembly has adopted several measures to improve efficiency and transparency. He said the institution now operates fully on solar energy, reflecting a shift towards sustainable governance practices. He added that proceedings have become paperless through the use of a digital legislative platform.

The Speaker said work is underway to digitise the Assembly Library to preserve records and improve access to research material. He also informed delegates about plans to develop a museum within the premises to showcase the Assembly's institutional journey. A light and sound programme is also being planned to present its history to the public.

Gupta said such initiatives aim to combine institutional memory with modern governance practices.

Savitri Cinema flyover construction work to start soon: Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government will soon start construction of a second flyover at Savitri Cinema, PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said on Tuesday.

The Public Works Department (PWD) had approved the project, along with the Modi Mill flyover integration with the Kalkaji Temple road, in December last year.

"After administrative approvals the work has been awarded, we plan to lay the foundation stone for the Savitri Cinema project within a month and the work on the ground will commence a month later," Singh said.

According to the plan, the second flyover at Savitri Cinema will be constructed parallel to the existing structure. This is likely to provide hassle-free movement in areas between Greater Kailash and Nehru Place.

The need for a second flyover was identified by the authorities in 2016, and a basic plan was also prepared and approved by the Unified Traffic and Transportation Infrastructure (Planning & Engineering) Centre (UTTIPEC).



Further, to integrate Kalkaji Mandir with the Modi Mill flyover, a new three-lane carriageway will be constructed, and from Modi Mill to Kalkaji Temple, there will be a three-lane carriageway constructed at the cost of ₹312.94 crore, officials said.

"Once operational, the flyovers will provide signal-free movement, improve traffic speeds, and eliminate congestion at key junctions, particularly at Captain Gaur Marg-Outer Ring Road and Outer Ring Road-GK-II Road and nearby areas," the PWD minister said.

The Savitri Cinema flyover will be constructed at Rs 58 crore, and both the Modi Mill and Savitri flyover will take around two and a half years to complete from the beginning of construction.

Fake food manufacturing racket busted, 4 arrested

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has busted a major racket involved in manufacturing and selling fake ENO powder and counterfeit Nescafé coffee, arresting four people and seizing goods worth around ₹20 lakh from Madhu Vihar in east Delhi, officials said on Tuesday.

The operation was carried out by the Crime Branch, which uncovered two illegal units operating from rented flats. Police said the accused were producing and packaging spurious products for supply across different parts of the country, posing a serious risk to public health.

Deputy Commissioner of Police Rahool Alwal said the racket was part of an organised network involved in manufacturing and distributing fake consumer goods.

"The accused were engaged in large-scale production and supply of counterfeit products that could endanger consumers," he said. The arrested accused have been identified as Uttam Das (23) and Papai Das Baragya alias Pankaj (19), both residents of Shastri Nagar, Nitin Bhardwaj (38) from Geeta Colony, and Sanjay Bansal (50) from Tri Nagar.

Police said the raid was conducted after receiving specific inputs about illegal manufacturing activities. A police team from the Cyber Cell and Southern Range raided the premises and



found the units actively producing fake ENO sachets and coffee products.

During the search, police recovered nearly 1 lakh sachets of fake ENO and around 50,000 sachets of counterfeit coffee ready for distribution.

Large quantities of raw materials, including about 500 kg of coffee powder and acid drums used in making ENO, were also seized.

Officials also recovered machinery and packaging equipment, including filling machines, sealing tools, foil rolls, stickers, and cartons. More than 550 empty bottles and large stocks of branded packaging materials were found at the site.

During questioning, Uttam Das and Papai revealed that the operation had been running for about two months under the direction of Nitin Bhardwaj. He was later traced through technical surveillance and arrested in Dehradun, Uttarakhand. Further investigation led police to Sanjay Bansal, who was allegedly linked to the supply chain.

He was arrested near Kashmere Gate while trying to leave the city. Police said the accused were repackaging the fake products using branded labels to pass them off as genuine items. The

goods were then supplied through wholesale and retail channels. Representatives from the companies whose brands were misused confirmed that the seized products were counterfeit.

They told police that the items were not manufactured or authorised by them and that the accused had no legal permission to produce or sell such goods.

A case has been registered under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, including charges related to cheating, sale of harmful products, and criminal conspiracy. Police said the offences are serious, as they involve public health risks.

Officials added that the racket highlights how counterfeit goods are entering the market and misleading consumers. Such products may contain unsafe ingredients and can cause health problems. Police are now working to identify the entire network, including suppliers of raw materials and distribution channels. Efforts are also being made to trace other possible members involved in the operation.

Further investigation is underway to dismantle the complete supply chain and prevent the circulation of fake products in the market, officials said.

PUBLIC NOTICE
To be known to all, SHIVNESH KARA S/O SH. BALBIR SINGH KALRA allottee/owner of DDA HIG FLAT NO.604, SIXTH FLOOR, POCKET-D-6, BLOCK-K-3,VASANT KUNJ,NEW DELHI-110070 have applied for certified copy in DDA. The original document i.e. DEMAND-CUM-ALLOTMENT LETTER of the above said flat has been lost. An LR NO. 248282/2025 dated 21/04/2026 to this effect has been lodged in P.S. Crime Branch, Delhi. Any person(s) claiming any right, interest, having any objection, or found in possession of original document, may write with evidence with above named person at above Address/ Phone 9871783888 within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. The person claiming any right, interest, objection with respect to this property, can personally inform or write to Deputy Director (Housing or Direct) (Housing), Delhi Development Authority, Vikas Sadan, New Delhi-110023.

PUBLIC NOTICE
To be known to all, COBINAD SINGH RAWAT S/O SH. JULFA SINGH R/O DDA JANTA FLAT NO. 52-C SECOND FLOOR,GAZIPUR, DELHI-110096 Purchaser of DDA JANTA FLAT NO. 52-C, SECOND FLOOR, GAZIPUR, DELHI-110096. The original documents i.e. ALLOTTMENT-CUM-DEMAND LETTER of the above flat have been lost. An FIR to this effect has been lodged in P.S.GHAZIPUR/e-Police Station in vide S.O. No.430/2014 & LR No.248 378/2026 dated 21.04.2025. Any person(s) claiming any right, interest, having any objection or found in possession of original documents, may write with evidence with above named person at above address/phone:8595775905 within 15days from the date of publication of this notice. The person claiming any right, interest, objections with respect to this property can personally inform or write to Dy. Director (LAB) & or Director (H)-J, B Block, 3rd Floor, Vikas Sadan, INA, New Delhi.

**NOTICE OF LOSS OF SHARE CERTIFICATES
(FOR CLAIM FROM IEPF AUTHORITY)**
Pursuant to Rule 8 of the Investor Education and Protection Fund (Accounting, Audit, Transfer and Refund) Rules, 2025, Notice is hereby given that the following share certificates issued by the company, Shriram Finance Ltd. (Formerly known as Shriram Transport Finance Company Limited) Registered on my / our name, has / have been lost / misplaced :

Folio No.	Name of Shareholder(s)	Shares	Share Certificate No(s)	Distinctive Nos. From	To
16126	1. Mamta Mund	50	123071	5318011	5318150
	2. Rajendra Prasad Mund	50	42722	2075991	2076040
		50	87272	3800991	3801040

Any person who has a claim in respect of the said securities should lodge such claim with evidence to the Company, at its Registered Office, Shriram Finance Ltd (formerly known as Shriram Transport Finance Company Limited, 14A, South Phase, Industrial Estate, Guindy, Chennai - 600 032 or to its Share Transfer Agents, Integrated Registry Management Services Private Limited, "Kences Towers", 2nd Floor, No.1 Ramakrishna Street, North Usman Road, T Nagar, Chennai-600 017, within 15 days publication of this notice, else the Company will proceed to settle the claim in favour of the registered holder(s). The Company shall not entertain any claim thereafter. Any person dealing with the above said shares will be doing so at their own risk.

Place : Greater Noida Date : 20.04.2026 Applicants : Mamta Mund & Rajendra Prasad Mund

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement System

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

S. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01	19251697C	PANTO FOT INSULATOR	324 NOS	11.05.2026
02	07250349A	OVER HAULING KIT FOR KES TYPE	658 SET	11.05.2026
03	12265005	HEAVY DUTY PASSENGER ESCALATOR	16 NOS	11.05.2026
04	10260022	SUPERIOR QUALITY PILLOW	114966 NOS	14.05.2026
05	08260001A	SPARE PART OF AC ELECTRIC LIFTING BARRIER	984 SET	15.05.2026
06	10265051	MODERN BAG PACK	7876 NOS	20.05.2026

Note:- 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No manual offer will be entertained.

Tender Notice No.: 05/2026-2027 Dated: 21.04.2026 1327/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Shri JITTENDRA KUMAR to inform to the public at large that Shri JITTENDRA KUMAR is purchasing the BUILT-UP FLAT NO.201, ON FIRST FLOOR, (PROJECT NO. X), MEASURING 720 SQ. FT.S SUPERAREA, ON PROPERTY BEARING PLOT NO.358, TOTAL AREA MEASURING 266 SQ. YDS., OUT OF KHASRA NO.1217/1, SITUATED IN THE REVENUE ESTATE OF VILLAGE KAKROLA, DELHI STATE DELHI, AREA ABADI KNOWN AS COLONY TARA NAGAR, BLOCK-B-2, KAKROLA, NEW DELHI-110078, from M/s. MAA DURGAS ASSOCIATES through its proprietor Shri Ram Abhishek who became owner through General Power of Attorney, Agreement to Sell & Will dated 17.07.2025, duly attested with the Notary Public, Delhi dated 17/07/2025 which was executed by Mrs. Jyoti Rani and same to be financed & mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd., So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/interest/creating mortgage over the said property may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucern Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform the general public that Mr. Kartar Singh Rana & Kuldeep Singh Rana are the GPA Holders of the Plot no. 6, area measuring 85 sq. yds., out of khata no. 2218/1, situated in the area of village Razapur Khurd colony known as Mohan Garden, in block-Q, New Delhi- 110058. They are in Possession through Notarized GPA, AT&S & WILL dated 17/05/2012 executed by Mr. Shiv Ram Kashyap in favour of Mr. Kartar Singh Rana & Kuldeep Singh Rana in respect of Plot no. 6, area measuring 85 sq. yds., out of khata no. 2218/1. Mr. Kartar Singh Rana & Kuldeep Singh Rana intend to transfer the ownership of above said plot by way of Sale Deed to Mrs. Nitu Ray. Subsequently, Mrs. Nitu Ray is in the process of mortgaging the said plot with SIFMS India Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property. If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-day period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Vectors-in, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline:- +91012-04489971, e-mail: accounts@vsnorth.in

CENTRAL ORGANISATION FOR RAILWAY ELECTRIFICATION
1, NAWAB YUSUF ROAD, CIVIL LINES, PRAYAGRAJ-211004
FAX NO. 0532-2407892, www.core.indianrailways.gov.in

No. RE/Tender/Civil E-TENDER NOTICE Dated: 20.04.2026

Dy. Chief Engineer/CORE/Prayagraj acting on behalf of President of India invites e-tender for following works.

Tender No.	Name of Work	Estimated cost of work (Rs.)	Earnest money (Rs.)	Completion period
RE/Tender/Civil/546	Zonal repair and maintenance of 16750327.76	335000.00	12 months	
RE/Tender/Civil/547	Zonal repair and maintenance of 7150622.55	143000.00	12 months	
RE/Tender/Civil/548	Zonal repair and maintenance of 3359420.62	67200.00	12 months	

Note:- 1. Submission/Opening of tenders: 11.05.2026 Up to 15.30 Hours, for submission of tender's through www.ireps.gov.in and the Tender shall be opened online using IREPS portal any time after closing of tender. 2. Website particulars: For further details/queries of above e-tenders please visit www.ireps.gov.in. 3. Office address: Office of PCE/CORE, 1 Nawab Yusuf Road, Civil Lines, Prayagraj-211001. 4. Indian Railway reserves the right to postpone, modify or cancel any e-tender without assigning any reasons thereoff. **NOTE: Only e-Bid shall be accepted against above tender.**

DR. CHIEF ENGINEER CORE/PRAYAGRAJ

No.: PR-04/2026 (Kaka) FOR & ON BEHALF OF PRESIDENT OF INDIA

Serving Customers with a Smile

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform the general public that Mr. Rajuddin has acquired Residential Plot of area measuring 120 sq. yds. i.e. 100.32 sq. mtrs, Part of Kharsa no. 123, situated at village Thaphera, Pargana, and Tehsil Dadri, Dist. Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P., vide by way of Sale Deed dated 13.03.2026 registered as Document No. 12387. Document related to the above said property has been misplaced i.e. Title Documents executed in favour of Mohd. Usman in respect of the said (said property) vide Mutation letter dt. 06.10.2025, in the record of GDA, after demise of Late Mr. Gopi Kant Jha who acquired the said property vide Lease deed dt. 02.09.2003. All Persons are hereby informed that above owner want to sale the said Property to Mr. Chetan Arora or his nominee who is taking a loan facility from our client against the said property has any objections upon the ownership of above owner its said mortgage, & any other kind of objection/litigation, Charge etc. Kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 07 days of the present. **Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)** 200, IInd Flr, 23, Shivaji Marg, Moti Nagar, N.Delhi-110015 kagall@rediffmail.com Ph: 011-41112327-28

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of RAHANUMA RAYEEN to inform to the public at large that RAHANUMA RAYEEN is purchasing the Flat No. F-2, on First Floor, without roof rights of Plot No. A-59, area measuring 69.67 sq.yards, situated in Hadbast Gram Pasonda, Pargana Loni, Tehsil and District Ghaziabad, UP from of Jabbar Ahmed who became owner through General Power of Attorney, Agreement to Sell & Will dated 03.05.2017, duly attested with the Notary Public Delhi dated 03/05/2017 which was executed by Mrs. Rihana and Mr. Akram Saifi and same to be financed & mortgaged by Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Ltd. So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/interest/creating mortgage over the said property may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucern Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

PUBLIC NOTICE
Public at large is hereby informed that my client named Sh. Vinod Kumar Dhall, S/o- Sh. Mukesh Raj Dhall, and Smt. Usha Rani Dhall, W/o- Sh. Vinod Kumar Dhall, R/o- House No. - 376, Outer Ring Road, Bhera Enclave, Paschim Vihar, West Delhi, Delhi-110087, has collectively debarred, disowned, and disinherited their son named Sh. Nikhil Dhall and daughter-in-law Smt. Shreya, W/o- Nikhil Dhall from all their moveable and immovable properties, being disobedient, disrespectful, out of control and of quarrelsome nature. My client has also severed and disconnected all their relations with both of them. If anyone deals with them, he/she they may do so at their own risk, cost and consequences. My client shall not be responsible to anybody for their acts and deeds.

SH. NAVEEN SHARMA (Advocate) EN NO. D/406/1996R CH.NO. C-76, CL. JOSEPH BLOCK, TIS HAZARI COURT, DELHI - 110054

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER: PWD:: BUILDING::ASSAM, GUWAHATI-3
No. CE/TB-II(Bldg.)/06/2026/3

CANCELLATION NOTICE

It is for information to all concerned that the tenders invited vide this office Press Notice No. CE/TB-II(Bldg.)/06/2026/2, Dated.13th March, 2026, No. CE/TB-II(Bldg.)/37/2025/3, Dated.13th March, 2026, No. CE/TB-II(Bldg.)/109/2024/6, Dated.13th March, 2026, No. CE/TB-II(Bldg.)/26/2025/5, Dated.13th March, 2026, No. CE/TB-II(Bldg.)/05/2026/3, Dated.13th March, 2026, and No. CE/TB-II(Bldg.)/07/2026/1, Dated.21st January, 2026 are hereby cancelled due to the declaration of Model Code of Conduct (MCC) until further notice.

(Signature)

Chief Engineer, PWD (Bldg.) Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3.

DIPR/C/PIO/1/21-Apr-26

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, Mr. K. B. Kapoor, have lost the allotment letter dated 07-01-1993 issued by M/s Ansal Housing & Construction Ltd. for property B-304, Neelpadam-1, Vaishali, Ghaziabad. If found or any objection, please contact : 9811599724.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the General Public that Mr. Jayvir, Mr. Tarasam & Mr. Surendra are the Owners and registry will be executed by Mr. Jayvir & Mr. Tarasam, the Said Mr. Tarasam stating that he has no objection to the payment being made solely in the name of Mr. Jayvir and that he has willingly executed the Sale Deed in respect of Plot area admeasuring 190 Sq. Yrds. Part of Khata No.174 Gata No-47 situated in the Village-Tilbegumpur, Tehsil-Sikandrabad, District-Bulandshahr, UP, by virtue of Sale Deed dated 19/05/2014 duly registered in SRO-Sikandrabad, vide the Book No-1, Vol No-5934 Serial No-4037, executed by Mrs. Jaggo, Mr. Kamal Singh, Mr. Ramesh, Mr. Vedpal, Mrs. Chhajiya, Mr. Harswaroop, Mr. Chhidda Singh, Mr. Atar Singh, Mr. Nauvat, Mr. Knpal, Mr. Atwar, Mr. Baldev, Mr. Vijaypal, Mr. Shadi, Mr. Shyampal, Mr. Suresh, Mrs. Draupadi, Mr. Shyamial, Mr. Than Singh, Mr. Bhagwan Singh, Mr. Dalchand, Mr. Lakshmi, Mr.Rampal, Mr. Harpal, Mr. Chatar Singh, Mr. Lakshram, and who is taking home loan from Motilal Oswal Home Finance Ltd. All persons are hereby informed that if anybody have objection kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 14 days of the present. **Rahul Raj, Advocate, S-G1, Plot no. 20, Koushambhi near HDFC Bank, U.P. E-MAIL:sgassociates-pl@gmail.com, Ph: 813039204**

PUBLIC NOTICE
Transfer of ownership in respect of constructed Plot number 5, on road number-D-7 and measuring 420sq metres situated in DLF city Phase 1, Gurugram, Haryana, consequent upon the intestate death of Shri Virendra Lal Sood, who was the owner of subject cited on 22-10-2024, and leaving behind following legal heirs. 1. Kavita Sood (wife) 2. Bhanu Sood (Daughter) 3. Nupur Sood (Daughter) 4. Shalini Sood Bhaduri (Daughter)

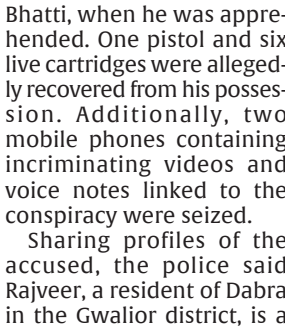
Smt. Kavita Sood wife of late Shri Virendra Lal Sood resident of flat number one, Ground floor, 1 Link Road, Jangpura extension near Anya Sam Mandir, Jangpura, South Delhi, Delhi-110014 intends to apply for the transfer of the said property in her favour, being the legal heirs and request for re-allotment.

If any person is having any objection against the transfer of said plot, he/she can submit objections in writing to the M/S DLF Ltd., along with supporting documents within 21 days from the date of this notice otherwise the estate officer may sanction mutation of the property as per policy and may not entertain subsequent claim if any.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

“Their arrest foiled planned attacks in the national capital and adjoining areas. The arrests exposed a larger conspiracy orchestrated by Bhatti, who, along with other ISI-linked handlers, was recruiting

The police said Rajveer was allegedly preparing to target a prominent hotel in Delhi-NCR on the directions of his handler, Shahzad



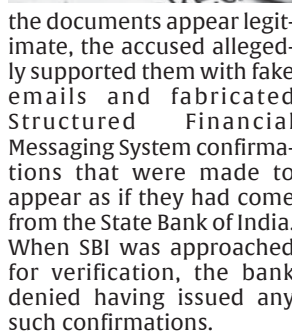
"He was directly handled by an associate of Bhatti identified as 'Rana Bai' and was assigned key operational responsibilities. He allegedly played a central role in coordinating movements, collecting weapons and executing planned attacks," the officer said.

Subsequently, on April 9 the duo travelled to

"After spending a few days in Delhi-NCR, he travelled to Punjab again, where he collected another pistol and ammunition before returning to the capital. Further investigation is underway to identify other members," the officer said.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

The guarantees were purportedly issued by two foreign banks: ACD Investment Bank, Malaysia and FirstRand Bank Ltd, Manila, Philippines. To make

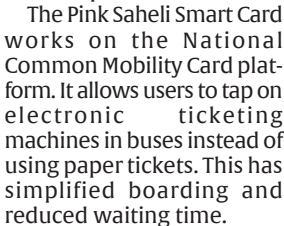


The case has been registered under Sections 318(4), 338, 336(3), 340(2), and 61(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and Section 66D of the Information Technology Act at EOW police station, New Delhi, vide FIR No. 79/25 dated June 24, 2025.

Among the accused, Biswal is described as a businessman who runs an Odisha-based trading company and was used as the channel through which the forged guarantees were procured. Dutta, who holds a BCA degree and a diploma in import-export, served as the middleman facilitating the arrangement.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

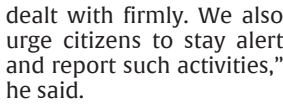
Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the growing number of users reflects rising trust in public transport and greater participation of women in daily commuting. She described the card as more than a travel facility, calling it a tool for empowerment and inclusion. "Our aim is to make public transport safe,



Officials said all issued cards are currently active, indicating regular usage. The digital system also allows users to recharge the card online and track their travel records.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

“Ensuring safe and regulated sale of medicines is our priority. Any violation will be



The person was able to purchase medicines without a prescription and without receiving a bill, confirming illegal practices at the shop. During the inspection, one



दिल्ली सरकार

EC bans bike rallies, curbs movement in West Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata/New Delhi

In a sweeping pre-poll move, the Election Commission of India has imposed strict restrictions on two-wheelers, which include banning bike rallies, restricting night-time movement and limiting pillion riding across West Bengal, aiming to ensure peaceful and intimidation-free voting ahead of the Assembly elections. The curbs, which came into force on Tuesday-just two days before the first phase of polling on April 23-apply to all 152 constituencies going to the polls in this phase.

Under the order, bikes and scooters will not be allowed on roads between 6



pm and 6 am during this period, except in emergencies such as medical needs or family functions. The Commission has also imposed a blanket ban on bike rallies, citing concerns over intimidation and disruption of the electoral process. During the day, between 6 am and 6 pm, pillion riding will be prohibited, except for

essential purposes such as medical emergencies, family functions, or activities like dropping and picking up schoolchildren. On polling day, limited relaxation has been granted. Family members will be allowed to travel as pillion riders between 6 am and 6 pm for voting and other essential requirements.

"In order to ensure free, fair, peaceful and violence-free elections... in the State and to prevent any form of intimidation and source jamming... restrictions on the use of motorcycles are hereby imposed with immediate effect from polling day minus two onward," the directive stated.

At Jorasanko in north

Kolkata, where Mamata Banerjee addressed another public meeting, she criticised the Election Commission for imposing restrictions on riding motorcycles before polling days. "How will people commute, go home from work if they are not allowed to take their motorbikes out?" she said.

The Commission said the restrictions are aimed at preventing "any form of intimidation and source jamming" and ensuring a calm and conducive atmosphere for voters. Individuals seeking exemptions must obtain prior written permission from their local police station. Explaining the rationale, officials said the measures are designed to

prevent "any form of intimidation and source jamming" and to create an environment for voters.

An EC official noted that motorcycles are often used by political operatives to transport cash or liquor through narrow lanes, bypassing checkpoints focused on larger vehicles. Groups of bikes, the official added, can also be deployed to influence or intimidate voters in sensitive areas, as per reports. Earlier addressing an election rally in Purba Medinipur district's Chandipur, which borders Suendu Adhikari's stronghold Nandigram, Union Home Minister Amit Shah claimed that goons enjoying Trinamool Congress patronage would

have no place to hide after the West Bengal polls and urged the electorate to vote without fear since Central forces would be keeping a close watch on such miscreants.

A record 2,450 companies of Central paramilitary forces that comprise nearly 2.5 lakh personnel have been deployed by the Election Commission for the West Bengal Assembly polls. He warned the "TMC's goons who tortured BJP workers" to find a place to hide. "After May 5, when results are declared, they will have no place to run," he said. "Bhaipo (nephew) will not be Bengal's future CM."

He has already purchased his ticket to leave the state after May 4," Shah said.

Delhi honours 35 officials with Chief Minister's Awards

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Thirty-five Government officials were honoured with the Chief Minister's Awards for Excellence and Innovation in Governance and Public Service Delivery 2026 on Civil Services Day, marking the first time such recognition has been introduced in Delhi.

The awards were presented by Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta at an official event held in the Capital. The initiative aims to recognise innovation, efficiency, and commitment in public service.

Speaking at the event, LG Sandhu said public trust is the strongest pillar of governance. He stressed that civil servants must focus on transparency, accountability, and delivering services effectively to the last person. "The real test of governance lies in how efficiently services reach citizens," he said.



LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta described civil services as the backbone of administration and said the Government is committed to ensuring that services reach every section of society. "Reaching the last mile remains our priority. Officers play a key role in achieving this goal," she said.

The Delhi Government also announced that the awards will now become an annual feature. Winners will be declared every year in April on Civil Services Day. Officials said the move is aimed at encouraging innovation and improving work culture across departments.

The event was organised by the Department of

Administrative Reforms. Awardees were given medals and commendation certificates for their contribution to strengthening governance and improving service delivery.

LG said civil servants must adapt to changing administrative challenges and adopt new approaches. He highlighted the role of technology, coordination, and innovation in improving public services. Even small improvements can have a large impact on citizens, he added.

The Chief Minister added that the awards draw inspiration from national-level initiatives aimed at recognising administrative excellence. She said the programme will help create a competitive and performance-driven environment in Government departments.

The selection process for the awards was conducted through a high-level committee headed by the Chief Secretary. Senior officials from multiple departments were part of the panel. Nominations were evaluated on parameters such as innovation, digital governance, and emergency response.

Awards were given across multiple categories, covering officials from different levels and sectors.

Gujarat nears landmark move with cheetah breeding centre in Kutch

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Gujarat is on the verge of a major wildlife milestone as the process to establish a captive breeding centre for cheetahs in the Banni grasslands of Kutch has reached its final stage. A team is likely to visit Africa later this year to bring six pairs of cheetahs to the State.

Once the cheetahs are introduced, Gujarat will become the only State in India to host all four major big cat species — lion, leopard, tiger, and cheetah — marking a significant achievement in wildlife conservation. Sources revealed that the State Government is also working on a long-term



plan to increase the tiger population to 10 within the next five years.

Currently, a lone male tiger has been roaming parts of Gujarat for over 14 months, with sightings reported in Chhoti Udepur, Dahod district's Ratanmahal, and Devgadh Baria regions. There are no female tigers in the state at present, but author-

ities plan to introduce them in the coming months to support population growth.

The Forest Department aims to bring up to 50 cheetahs to the Banni grasslands over the next three years. A 660-hectare enclosure has already been prepared in the region, with long-term plans to release the animals into the wild.

Gujarat ATS arrests 2 youths over suspected ISIS links

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

In a significant anti-terror operation, the Gujarat Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) has arrested two young suspected of having links with the terrorist organisation ISIS, officials said on Tuesday. The arrests were made as part of an ongoing anti-radicalisation drive conducted by the ATS. Addressing a press conference, ATS SP K Siddharth confirmed that the accused - Murshid Sheikh from Mumbai and Irfan Pathan from Siddhpur - were taken into custody following intelligence inputs.

According to the officials, both individuals were influenced by radical ideology and had been active on multiple social media platforms, including WhatsApp and Telegram, where they were allegedly in contact with extremist elements linked to ISIS. Investigators revealed that the duo had been active for the past five to six months.

Preliminary findings suggest that the accused were involved in a larger conspira-



cy against India, with alleged plans targeting RSS members and political leaders. Authorities also indicated that their radicalisation was largely driven through online content and group interactions.

Irfan Pathan, who holds an MSc degree in Chemistry, was initially called in for questioning, which eventually led to further revelations. Murshid Sheikh, who studied up to Class 9, reportedly worked at a biryani shop in Mumbai.

FROM PAGE - 1

PM's address sparks privilege notice in LS

Speaker Om Birla to refer the matter to the Committee on Privileges of the Lok Sabha for a detailed inquiry.

The Congress general secretary and MP from Alappuzha Lok Sabha constituency in Kerala said it is well established that casting reflections, aspersions and imputing motives to members of Parliament in regard to speeches made by them in Parliament tantamount to "gross breach of privilege and contempt of the House".

"I therefore submit this notice of breach of privilege to your good office, Hon'ble Speaker, to take cognisance of this grave incident as a clear and deliberate breach of privilege and contempt of the House, and to refer the matter to the Committee on Privileges of the Lok Sabha for a detailed inquiry so that privilege proceedings can be initiated against the Prime Minister," Venugopal said in his notice.

The Congress leader said this matter deserves to be treated with the utmost seriousness, as questioning an elected representative performing his duty "is not merely a personal assault but a direct affront to the authority of Parliament and to the democratic rights of the people of India".

The Congress leader said that the PM addressing the nation, after the government is not able to muster the requisite majority in Parliament, for criticising the Opposition parties is "unprecedented, unethical and blatant abuse of power". "Such statements by the highest executive functionary of the country constitute a serious breach of privilege and contempt of the House," Venugopal alleged.

Venugopal said in his notice that the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill 2026, "in the guise of implementing" Women's reservation in Lok Sabha and Legislative Assemblies "surreptitiously sought to amend Article 82 of the Constitution in as much as by doing away with constitutional protection/guardrail vis a vis Delimitation and leave it to the whims and fancies and mala intents of the ruling party", and this is what the opposition members were protesting.

He also claimed that under parliamentary convention and fundamental privilege of every Member (protected under Article 105 of the Constitution), no person, including the Prime Minister, shall reflect upon the conduct or voting of any Member in the House or attribute motives to such conduct.

Trump warns of strikes as Iran deal deadline...

The President said he thinks the US is "going to end up with a great deal" with Iran to end the weeks-long war.

"I think they have no choice," Trump said when asked about his expectations from the second round of negotiations with Iran.

"We've taken out their navy, we've taken out their air force, we've taken out their leaders," he said. "We've taken out their leaders, frankly, which does complicate things in one way, but these leaders are much more rational," Trump said. "It is regime change, no matter what you want to call it, which is not something I said I was going to do, but I've done it indirectly."

The first round of the US-Iran talks held on 11 and 12 April failed to produce the desired results for the parties, leading to a flurry of activities by host Pakistan to cool tempers and raise hopes for another round of dialogue.

Amidst uncertainty over the US-Iran talks, Pakistan's Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar on Tuesday urged the two sides to extend the two-

week ceasefire and give diplomacy a chance.

Dar, who is also the Foreign Minister, met US Charge d'Affaires Natalie A Baker in Islamabad and discussed recent regional developments.

Dar underscored Pakistan's consistent emphasis on dialogue and diplomacy as the only viable means to address challenges and achieve lasting regional peace and stability, the foreign office said in a statement.

"He stressed the need for engagement between the United States and Iran, urged both sides to consider extending the ceasefire, and to give dialogue and diplomacy a chance," it said.

Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi also met the envoys of the US and Iran on Tuesday and discussed matters related to the peace talks.

Separately, Chinese Ambassador to Pakistan Jiang Zaidong called on Dar and discussed the latest regional developments, the FO said.

Jiang conveyed China's full support for and appreciation of Pakistan's continued efforts to facilitate engagement between the US and Iran for sustained peace and stability in the region and beyond. Dar reaffirmed the Pakistan-China All-Weather Strategic Cooperative Partnership, underscored the strength of bilateral ties, and emphasised the importance of sustained high-level exchanges between the two countries.

He also held a telephonic conversation with Egyptian Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty and Saudi Foreign Minister Prince Faisal bin Farhan to discuss the latest regional developments.

They emphasised the importance of dialogue and engagement for peace and stability, and agreed to remain in close contact, according to FO. Despite ambiguity, Trump expressed confidence that peace talks with Iran would go ahead, and he wished for an agreement to prevent further oil price rises and stock market shocks, but insisted Iran cannot have the means to develop a nuclear weapon. (PTI)

Blast at Kerala fireworks unit kills 13

"Parts of bodies were lying scattered. We helped gather them and send them to hospitals," said a local man, his voice trembling.

Officials said around 40 workers were believed to have been present at the unit at the time of the explosion, many of whom suffered burn injuries, several of them critical.

The injured were rushed to hospitals, mainly the Government Medical College, Thrissur, as ambulances shuttled between the remote site and medical facilities. Wilson, one of the surviving workers, recalled the terrifying moment.

"There was a sudden flash beside me and then fire... after that, I don't remember anything," he said. He maintained that all workers at the unit were Malayalees and that no migrant labourers were employed. According to him, the unit had been operating in compliance with safety norms. "There was nothing illegal. Maybe the extreme heat or direct sunlight on the gunpowder triggered the fire," he said.

Residents said the fireworks unit had functioned in the area for years without incident, making the scale of Tuesday's tragedy even more shocking. The sound of the explosion was heard kilometres away, and some nearby houses reportedly suffered damage.

Even hours after the initial blast, occasional explosions and the risk of igniting stored firecrackers continued to hamper rescue operations, with fire and police personnel proceeding cautiously through the debris.

As smoke slowly cleared over the once tranquil fields, festive anticipation surrounding the Pooram gave way to grief, with families anxiously awaiting news of their loved ones and author-

ities struggling to ascertain the exact toll in what is among the worst such accidents in the region in recent times.

India-Bangladesh visa thaw on cards

"Visa processing never stopped, but it was curtailed due to diplomatic tensions. Now, there is a clear pathway toward full restoration after the Bengal elections," a senior diplomat shared.

Visa issuance — once a cornerstone of India-Bangladesh engagement — slowed sharply amid tensions during the tenure of Muhammad Yunus. Dhaka has since pushed for normalization, urging New Delhi to resume visas across all categories. As per report, the slowdown has had visible consequences. India's High Commission in Dhaka, which previously processed up to 8,000 visas daily, is now issuing only limited emergency medical and student visas.

The broader economic impact has been significant. Between April 2023 and March 2024, over 2.1 million Bangladeshis visited India — about 22 per cent of all foreign arrivals. These travellers supported sectors ranging from healthcare and hospitality to retail and transport. India issued more than two million visas annually to Bangladeshi nationals, most of them for medical purposes. The sharp decline in cross-border travel has hit India's medical tourism sector particularly hard. Bangladesh accounted for nearly 69 per cent of India's medical tourists, exposing a heavy dependence now disrupted by diplomatic friction. Data indicates a steep fall — 43 per cent in November 2024 and 59 per cent in December. While around 4,82,000 Bangladeshis still accessed treatment in India in 2024, these were largely emergency cases, a sharp drop from previous years. Hospitals in key hubs such as Kolkata, Chennai, Mumbai, and Bengaluru have felt the impact, with reduced patient inflows affecting revenues and capacity utilisation.

Adding to the strain, key cross-border train services — Maitree Express, Bandhan Express, and Mitahi Express — have remained suspended since August 2024. These routes once provided affordable and accessible travel for patients and traders alike. With a new BJP-led government in Dhaka signalling stronger engagement and New Delhi indicating readiness to reciprocate, the restoration of visas is expected to mark a significant reset in bilateral ties. For millions on both sides of the border — especially those dependent on medical access — the outcome of the Bengal elections may carry implications far beyond domestic politics.

Beyond the serene meadows: The...

Similar inhospitable spots such as; Aru, Betaab Valley and upper reaches used for the Amarnath Yatra, share these features, creating natural hide-outs for infiltrators from across the Line of Control or local over ground workers.

During peak season, thousands converge on these open meadows for pony rides, picnics and photography. Unlike urban or fortified sites, these areas lack layered perimeter security, CCTV networks, or rapid-response teams.

The 2025 attack occurred in an area with no armed personnel present, underscoring how seasonal tourism outpaces static security deployments. To make matters worse, local authorities had opened Baisaran to tourists two months ahead of the traditional Amarnath Yatra schedule without coordinating with security agencies, leaving the site unprotected.

In a region with a history of cross-border terrorism, tracking small, highly mobile teams armed

with AK-47s and M4 carbines remains difficult. Terrorists often rely on local facilitators for logistics, shelter and reconnaissance networks that are hard to dismantle without alienating the civilian population.

Pahalgam's economy depends heavily on tourism-related services: ponywallahs, guides and vendors. Terrorists could blend in or use insiders for intelligence. Post-2025, authorities introduced QR-code-based identification systems for all registered pony operators and vendors, along with antecedent verification.

The broader Kashmir Valley context adds layers, residual radicalization, cross-border funding, the challenge of distinguishing between genuine tourists and potential threats. Following the massacre, security has been significantly enhanced: additional deployments, drone surveillance, heightened checkpoints, and special measures ahead of the Amarnath Yatra and the attack's anniversary. Tourist spots now see stricter protocols, including QR verification and real-time monitoring.

Seasonal events like Amarnath Yatra require massive security mobilization, diverting resources from year-round protection. Climate and terrain also limit technology; dense forests hinder drone effectiveness in bad weather.

Pahalgam's security challenges are not insurmountable but require constant vigilance. The 2025 attack served as a stark reminder that in a sensitive border region, even popular tourist havens remain high-value targets. While recent measures show proactive adaptation, the interplay of geography, terrorism and economic imperatives means Pahalgam and Kashmir's tourism will continue to test India's counter-terror strategy for years to come.

High-pitch poll campaign ends in TN, West Bengal

Nearly 3.60 crore electors are eligible to vote in this phase, including 1.84 crore men, 1.75 crore women and 465 third-gender voters, according to Election Commission data.

Key candidates in this phase include leader of the opposition Suvenu Adhikari (BJP, Nandigram), former Union minister Nisithi Pramanik (BJP, Mathabhanga), state minister Udayan Guha (TMC, Dinhabata), Goutam Deb (TMC, Silihuri), and Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury (Congress, Baharampur).

Addressing his final rally on Tuesday, Shah predicted that the state was in for a change of leadership on May 4. "Her time at the helm of the state has come to an end," he said, referring to Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee.

While Mamata asserted her party would return to power comfortably in the state and claimed that the BJP-led government at the Centre would not last beyond 2026.

The campaign for the April 23 Assembly election to Tamil Nadu also ended on Tuesday. Police security arrangements have been tightened in sensitive places in Tamil Nadu.

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M K Stalin signed off the campaign by interacting with voters of Kolathur constituency from where he is contesting. With two days left for the Assembly election, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami, who heads the NDA in the state wound up his campaign in the western TN.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu, his Maharashtra counterpart Devendra Fadnavis, Bhajanlal Sharma (Rajasthan) and Revanth Reddy (Telangana), former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal besides Stalin, Palaniswami and Deputy CM Udhayanidhi crisscrossed the state holding roadshows and cam-

paigning for candidates in their respective alliance.

Two powerful alliances - the Secular Progressive Alliance led by DMK chief M K Stalin, and the National Democratic Alliance led by AIADMK chief K Palaniswami are pitted against each other, promising a tough contest.

What makes the election more interesting this time is the presence of actor Vijay-led fledgling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam in the fray from all the constituencies while DMK had roped in actor-politician Kamal Haasan, who heads the Makkal Needhi Maiam, to campaign against Vijay.

India marks a year since Operation Sindoor

In his first public reaction to the massacre, Modi on April 24, last year, had said, "India will identify, track and punish every terrorist and their backers". Addressing a public rally in Madhubani district, Bihar, he then switched over to English from Hindi and said "Today from the soil of Bihar I say to the whole world, India will identify, track and punish every terrorist and their backers. We will pursue them to the ends of the Earth."

He then went on to say "India's spirit will never be broken by terrorism. Terrorism will not go unpunished. Every effort will be made to ensure that justice is done. The entire nation is firm in this resolve."

"Everyone who believes in humanity is with us. I thank people and leaders of countries who have stood with us," the Prime Minister said as he acknowledged the reaction of world leaders after the attack. The military action, lasting four days, saw the armed forces destroying several strategic airfields and installations across the border, besides killing nearly 100 terrorists hiding in camps there.

After launching the decisive military operation, the Indian Army in a post on X at 1:51 am on May 7 had said, #PahalgamTerrorAttack Justice is Served. Jai Hind!" along with a digital poster that carried the name 'OPERATION SINDOOR'. One of the Os in 'SINDOOR' was portrayed as a bowl carrying a dash of 'sindoor'. Pakistan later also launched offensives against India, and all subsequent counter-offensives by India were also carried out under Operation Sindoor.

The military conflict between the two nuclear-armed neighbours, lasting nearly 88 hours, halted after they reached an understanding on the evening of May 10.

Kharge's PM jibe triggers BJP backlash

BJP IT chief Amit Malviya also took to social media and posted a series of comments to attack the Congress, while BJP national spokesperson Sambit Patra said the words Kharge chose for the Prime Minister are not only condemnable but also reflect the mindset of the Congress party. Kharge called him a terrorist."

In his reactions, Home Minister Amit Shah said every day Congress is hitting new lows in its demeanour, breaking its own record in lowering the standard of public discourse. "Today, Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge breached every standard of public conduct and brought shame to the nation by calling the elected Prime Minister of India Narendra Modi, a terrorist. This insult to the foremost leader of the nation is an insult to the millions of people who love and support PM Modi. Calling a leader like PM Modi terrorist, who has completely curbed terrorism in the last 12 years is highly condemnable. Every time the Congress hurls abuses at Modi Ji, it is the people of India who answer them. This time too, the people will respond," Shah said on social media.

VP hails rising number of women in civil services

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Tuesday appreciated the growing participation of women in the civil services and hoped that this trend would soon be witnessed in Parliament and State assemblies.

Addressing a gathering of bureaucrats during the Civil Services Day celebrations, the vice president highlighted that the participation of women in the civil services has risen from around 21 per cent in 2016 to almost 31 per cent in 2025.

“Civil services toppers are increasingly women. We have indeed come a long way. Even during my visit to various districts, I am pleased to see women officers serving as the police commissioners, collectors and SPs (Superintendents of Police). This progress stands as a powerful testament to ‘narishakti’ where talent rises above stereotypes and determination wins over every obstacle,” he said.

Radhakrishnan emphasised that the progress is not merely statistical but repre-

sents a fundamental shift in the mindset.

“That is the most welcoming trend. It reminds us that when women are given equal opportunities, they do not just succeed, they redefine the meaning of success itself. I am hopeful that we will see a similar transformation in the composition of the Parliament and the State legislatures too in the future,” he said.

In his address to the civil servants, the vice president said that a few decades ago, very few women were appointed as district magistrates or police commissioners.

“Even when they were there, their presence was limited to just a handful. But today, the reality has changed significantly,” he said.

Radhakrishnan said that the past decade has seen a remarkable shift as the share of women in civil services has risen from around 21 per cent in 2016 to nearly 31 per cent in 2025, and termed it “an encouraging and meaningful transformation”.

“I really appreciate the interest of the women, and they are going to contribute



equally with the men, maybe more,” he asserted.

The vice president said that the poorest among the poor and their needs have to be taken care of.

Referring to “freebies”, Radhakrishnan said, “We have to grow, we have to create wealth, and we have to serve the people who are in need. (But) We should not include everybody. If you include everybody, then everybody will become a beneficiary. Then the money will go out just like that. The real needy people should be

helped....” Radhakrishnan said. The vice president said that by focusing on last-mile delivery and staying responsive to ground realities, the civil servants “make governance more inclusive, more effective and more impactful”.

Radhakrishnan said that planning an initiative or welfare programme can be done in Delhi, but its results can only be seen in a remote village when it is implemented in the real sense.

The country has achieved several milestones in the last

decade, and Bharat now occupies a place of pride at the global level, he said.

“From nowhere, we become the fifth largest economy, and from the fifth, we have moved towards the fourth largest economy, and I’m sure soon we are going to be the third largest economy in the world,” the VP added.

On recent technological changes, he said that they are game changers and they will serve as a useful tool for all of us in our own line of work.

Radhakrishnan remembered going to a typewriting institute one hour a day in his younger days to learn type-writing, but over time, “we shifted to computers and tablets reflecting the steady march of technology”.

“Now, we have entered the age of artificial intelligence (AI) and other new emerging technologies. Today, as the chairman of the Rajya Sabha, I am leveraging digital platforms to conduct the house proceedings more effectively. We cannot keep away from modern technological changes,” he said.

The vice president asked the civil servants to embrace newer technologies such as

AI, machine learning and blockchain, among others, as they offer opportunities for improving efficiency, transparency and citizen service delivery.

He also suggested changes in the recruitment system. He said that some States have not changed their recruitment systems, as any degree holder is allowed to apply for the post of a technician.

“Any degree is good for the colonial mindset because they want only clerks,” Radhakrishnan said, and mentioned that selection of technocrats and those with medical degrees are joining civil services.

Character and integrity are the very foundations of public service, the VP said, adding that those who are straightforward will always be under pressure.

“Obeying the boss is different. Obeying the pressure is different. I am not against obeying the boss. But I am always against obeying the pressure. Pressure is always for doing something we should not. Obeying the boss is always taking the right guidelines from the boss,” he added.

Nation Focus



PM MODI PAYS TRIBUTE TO ADI SHANKARACHARYA

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday paid homage to Adi Guru Shankaracharya on his birth anniversary and said his profound teachings, thoughts and philosophy of ‘Advaita Vedanta’ continue to guide innumerable people globally. Modi said Adi Guru Shankaracharya emphasised harmony, discipline, and the oneness of all existence, and his efforts to revitalise spiritual thought and establish spiritual centres across the nation remain a lasting inspiration. “On the sacred occasion of Adi Shankaracharya Jayanti, paying homage to one of India’s greatest spiritual luminaries. His profound teachings, thoughts and philosophy of ‘Advaita Vedanta’ continue to guide innumerable people globally... May his wisdom continue to illuminate our path and strengthen our commitment to truth, compassion and collective well-being,” he said in a social media post.



CHIEFS OF PARLIAMENT PANELS REAPPOINTED

Rajya Sabha Chairman CP Radhakrishnan has reappointed AIADMK member M Thambi Durai as Chairman of the Committee on Government Assurances and DMK member Tiruchi Siva as the Chairman of the Department-related Parliamentary Standing Committee on Industry.

“The Chairman, Rajya Sabha, has nominated M Thambi Durai, Member, Rajya Sabha, to be a member of the Committee on Government Assurances and also re-appointed him to be the Chairman of the said Committee w.e.f. the April 18, 2026,” an official notification from the Rajya Sabha Secretariat said.



Kushan Mitra, Printer and Publisher of *The Pioneer*, met his HE M Riaz Hamidullah, High Commissioner of Bangladesh to apprise him of the activities of *The Pioneer Group* and efforts being made by the newspaper to continuously improve people-to-people connections between the two nations

PIONEER PHOTO

Defence Ministry inks ₹975 cr deal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The defence ministry on Tuesday signed contracts worth nearly ₹975 crore for the procurement of critical equipment for T-72 and T-90 tanks of the Army, which will enhance the minefield breaching capability of the force. The contracts were inked in the presence of Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh in Delhi.

The ministry, in a statement, said it has signed contracts with Bharat Earth Movers Limited (BEML) and Electro Pneumatics and Hydraulics (India) Private



Limited for the “procurement of TRAWL Assembly for T-72/T-90 tanks, at an approximate cost of ₹975 crore”.

The ‘TRAWL Assembly’ for T-72/T-90 tanks is a critical equipment developed by the DRDO that will enhance the minefield breaching capabil-

ity of the Indian Army.

“It would generate additional capability of creating vehicle safe lanes through minefields with anti-tank mines with proximity magnetic fuses, thus enhancing the operational effectiveness of the Indian Army,” the statement said.

Being a ‘Buy (Indian-Indigenously Designed, Developed and Manufactured)’ case, the procurement marks a pivotal step towards modernising India’s defence infrastructure and empowering indigenous industries, which will be a proud flag-bearer of Aatmanirbhar Bharat, it said.

President launches ₹158 crore projects in Odisha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Rourkela

Launching projects worth ₹158 crore at Rourkela in Odisha’s Sundergarh, President Droupadi Murmu on Tuesday said overall development of the country is possible only through the progress of every section of society, including women and tribals.

Murmu, who was in the steel city on a day-long visit, inaugurated the Planetarium and Science Centre, Nirmal Munda Parivesh Path, the Tribal Museum and the Integrated Command and Control Centre.

Addressing a function here on the occasion of ‘Adi



President Droupadi Murmu inaugurating the Nirmal Munda Parivesh Path in Rourkela

PTI

Paraba-2026’ in the tribal hinterland of Odisha, the President said that women comprise half of the country’s population and they need to be empowered in order to achieve the goal of ‘Viksit Bharat’ by 2047 and

‘Sambrudh Odisha’ by 2036.

She also stressed the development of tribals, who constitute around one-fourth of Odisha’s population.

“With this in mind, the Central and State Governments are actively

working on various schemes for tribal welfare and women’s empowerment. This is accelerating the development process in tribal-dominated districts like Sundergarh, while prioritising the economic upliftment of the members of tribal communities,” Murmu said.

“Become good human beings and strive to uplift those who have been left behind,” she told the gathering. A ‘Viksit Bharat’ will be possible only through the collective efforts and dedication of the nation’s farmers, labourers, tribal communities, marginalised sections, intellectuals, youth and students, as well as the urban and rural populace, the President said.

CPI slams Govt over UN report on arms exports to Israel

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Communist Party of India (CPI) on Tuesday expressed deep concern over the observations made by UN Special Rapporteur Francesca Albanese regarding India’s alleged role in the ongoing humanitarian crisis in Gaza.

Citing the report “Torture and Genocide” presented at the 61st session of the UN Human Rights Council, the CPI National Secretariat noted that India has been named among countries enabling Israel’s military actions through the provision of weapons and support. “It is

a fact that Indian companies continue to export drones and other military components to Israel even during the ongoing war in Gaza,” the party said in a statement.

The CPI asserted that India’s military and strategic engagement with Israel, amidst allegations of war crimes, violates legal and moral responsibilities under international law. The party claimed this represents a “complete departure” from India’s traditional foreign policy tenets of anti-imperialism, non-alignment, and peaceful coexistence.

“Israel is accused of genocide in the International Court of Justice. It



CPI General Secretary Doraisamy Raja

is in the background of these facts that the UN Rapporteur has indicted India. This is a serious indictment,”

the statement read.

Demanding transparency, the CPI called upon the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) to issue a “clear and categorical statement” clarifying India’s current military and technological engagements with Israel. The party further demanded an immediate review and suspension of any cooperation that might contribute to violations of civilian rights in Gaza.

The party warned that silence or ambiguity on the matter would erode India’s moral standing in the Global South and urged the Government of India to respond urgently to the UN observations.

AIKS accuses Government of favouring private seed giants

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The All India Kisan Sabha (AIKS) has launched a scathing attack on the Union Government, accusing it of undermining public agricultural research to favour private seed giants in the cotton sector. The farmers’ body alleged that current policies have not only imposed a staggering financial burden of Rs 35,000



AIKS president Ashok Dhawale

crore on growers since 2002 but have also deliberately

delayed access to affordable, publicly developed Bt cotton varieties.

In a memorandum submitted to Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, the AIKS described the cotton sector as being in the throes of an “unprecedented crisis.”

The organisation flagged a recurring “seed tax” paid by farmers who are forced to purchase expensive private hybrids every season.

Special trains announced to ease passenger rush

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a major relief for passengers ahead of the peak summer travel season, Indian Railways has announced the operation of 908 summer special trains across the country between April 15 and July 15, 2026.

The decision comes in the wake of rising travel demand during summer vacations and recent incidents of overcrowding, including chaos reported at Udhna station in Surat. The

special trains are expected to improve passenger convenience and reduce congestion on key routes. In total, these services will complete over 18,600 trips during the period.

Railway authorities stated that out of the approved trains, announcements for a large number of services have already been made, while others will be notified in phases. Zone-wise, South Central Railway has been allocated 124 trains (1,184 trips), while Western Railway will operate 106 trains (2,078 trips).

Tourists pay homage to Pahalgam terror attack victims

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

A large number of tourists from different parts of India have arrived in Pahalgam to pay homage to all the victims of terror mercilessly killed by Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) terrorists on April 22 in the Baisaran valley of the picturesque hill resort.

Tourists are expected to assemble in front of a memorial erected in Pahalgam to send a stern message to the perpetrators behind the horrific attack in which 25 tourists and a local ponywallah lost their lives.

A memorial built of black marble, bearing the names of the 26 victims, was constructed along the banks of

the Lidder River is standing as a solemn reminder of the terror attack that took place in the meadows of Baisaran valley.

Meanwhile, authorities have beefed up security across Kashmir ahead of the first anniversary, especially across famous tourist hotspots. The administration has deployed additional police and paramilitary personnel in and around Pahalgam, with intensified checking at multiple points and heightened surveillance to ensure a peaceful commemoration.

Senior officials said all necessary arrangements have been put in place for the event, which is expected to be attended by several politicians, civil society members, fam-



ilies of the victims, and local representatives.

After the Pahalgam terror attack, the tourism industry suffered badly across the valley. The popular Government headed by Omar Abdullah took various initiatives and toured several States across

India to boost the tourist traffic. His efforts bore fruit, and the tourist footfall showed signs of improvement. The Union Territory administration also took several confidence-building measures before extending an invitation to the tourists.

Paying homage to the victims of terror, a tourist from Assam N Sarkar said, “What had to happen has already happened. But if we choose not to visit this place now, that would be wrong. In India, almost every household nurtures a dream...I hail from Assam — we too share that dream of visiting Kashmir”. Tomorrow we will pay our homage at the memorial.

Dropadi Rawat, a middle-aged

visitor from Lucknow, said she and her companions had a positive experience, noting that they were not afraid and felt confident travelling as Indians.

She remarked that they were deeply impressed by the overall atmosphere and would gladly visit the place repeatedly.

“We would like to tell other travellers to definitely visit this place and experience it for themselves — it is truly wonderful and reassuring. We felt very comfortable throughout our stay, with strong security arrangements and a very pleasant environment, which made our experience thoroughly enjoyable in every respect,” Rawat said.

States Focus



PIYUSH GOYAL CRITICISES DMK GOVERNMENT

Union Minister Piyush Goyal on Tuesday alleged that the Tamil Nadu Government has failed to provide adequate development funding and is grappling with rising crimes against women and a growing drug menace.

Alleging internal conflicts and disagreements over seat-sharing within the DMK-led alliance, he said their Secular Progressive Alliance is a failure, calling it neither secular nor progressive and claiming it benefits only the Stalin family, while contrasting it with the NDA.

Speaking to reporters, Goyal alleged that the DMK is involved in corruption related to TASMAL, sand mining, land allocation, and job appointments.



POLL COMPLAINTS: BENGAL LOK BHAVAN LAUNCHES HELPLINE

The West Bengal Lok Bhavan on Tuesday launched a 24-hour helpline through which people can register their complaints regarding the Assembly elections, a statement said. Several delegations had met Governor RN Ravi in recent weeks and voiced concerns over possible violence in the run-up to the elections, and after the results, it said.

"Quite a few of them also shared their past personal experience of having suffered brutal violence in previous elections, including the killing of family members and kin," it said.

Taking note of those concerns, the Lok Bhavan launched the helpline to receive complaints from citizens, push for quick intervention where needed and connect people with the appropriate authorities, it added.

TMC goons will have no place to hide after May 4: Amit Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Tuesday said goons enjoying Trinamool Congress patronage would have no place to hide after the West Bengal polls and urged the electorate to vote without fear since Central forces would be keeping a close watch on such miscreants.

A record 2,450 companies of Central paramilitary forces that comprise nearly 2.5 lakh personnel have been deployed by the Election Commission for the West Bengal Assembly polls.

Addressing his final poll rally in Purba Medinipur district's Chandipur, which borders Suwendu Adhikari's stronghold Nandigram, before the first phase of polling on April 23, Shah bid "ta ta, goodbye" to TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee.



Union Home Minister Amit Shah during a public meeting ahead of the West Bengal Assembly elections in Salboni, Paschim Medinipur district PTI

"Her time at the helm of the State has come to an end," the former BJP chief said and exuded confidence that she would be replaced by a saffron dispensation post May 4, when the election results would be declared.

Urging people to vote without fear, he said, "No one can threaten our voters. The Election Commission has deployed central forces in

sufficient numbers who are spread at every nook and corner of the State."

Flanked by BJP's Nandigram candidate Suwendu Adhikari on the dais, the Union home minister claimed that "Mamata Banerjee's aspiration to see her nephew, Abhishek, as the State CM will never bear fruit". "Bhaipo (nephew) will not be Bengal's future CM. He

has already purchased his ticket to leave the State after May 4," Shah said.

He warned the "TMC's goons who tortured BJP workers" to find a place to hide. "After May 5, when results are declared, they will have no place to run," he said.

Addressing the electorate of this agrarian belt, where paddy and betel leaf cultivation are the mainstays, the Union home minister promised that the BJP will set up a research facility in Chandipur to study the medicinal values of betel leaf, once it comes to power in Bengal.

Shah also promised that infiltrators would be identified and deported to Bangladesh. Sealing of Bengal's border with Bangladesh would be done within 45 days of the BJP forming Government in the State, he added.

Youth, women voters to dismantle power structure: Vijay

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

TVK chief Vijay on Tuesday asserted that traditional political calculations and alliance strategies have been rendered obsolete by a generational shift in the electorate.

Addressing his final campaign rally in Chennai, the actor-turned-politician dismissed conventional polling and "scaremongering" tactics, claiming that a massive wave of youth and women voters would dismantle the established power structure of the State's veteran parties.

"Alliance mathematics and arithmetic will be shattered. Don't believe the lies and false oaths of those who give money for votes. The scare-



TVK chief Vijay addressing a public meeting ahead of the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections in Chennai on Tuesday PTI

mongering that the BJP will come won't work anymore," Vijay told a massive gathering. Targeting the ruling DMK and its leadership, the TVK chief framed the

election as a direct battle to "save democracy" from what he termed a people-hostile Government.

"This is the final campaign of the election that is going to

send the DMK Government home. It is the final campaign to send Stalin sir home. It is the final campaign to send home a leader who completely ignores the people," he said. Vijay also hit back at critics who have dismissed his political entry, including leaders from the BJP and AIADMK.

"A BJP minister says Vijay is an actor. Yes, I am an actor. But I haven't come to politics to act. You guys, however, are performing drama after drama while being in politics. Can we call you all stage actors? Using the power of the Union Government, you play one drama with DMK and another with others. You are a dangerous drama company," he alleged.

Welfare schemes will continue in West Bengal, says Abhishek



TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee during a public meeting in support of party candidate Goutam Mishra at Gangajalghati in Bankura district PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee on Tuesday hit out at the BJP for "failing" to deliver on its promises, and asserted that the ruling party's welfare schemes like 'Lakshmi Bhandar' would continue uninterrupted in West Bengal.

Addressing a poll rally at Barjora in Bankura district, Banerjee said women "will continue to receive benefits under the scheme for life". Under the popular 'Lakshmi Bhandar' scheme, women from the general category receive ₹1,000 per month, while those belonging to the Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe communities get ₹1,200 per month.

"No one can stop Lakshmi Bhandar," the TMC MP asserted. Alleging that the BJP had a track record of making "false promises", Banerjee said the saffron party did not fulfill its pledge of "₹15 lakh

in every bank account and two crore jobs annually".

"Those who could not deliver on basic promises cannot be trusted to provide welfare benefits," Banerjee said. He also challenged BJP-ruled States to replicate West Bengal's direct benefit schemes. "There are 16 States ruled by the BJP. If even one of them can implement a scheme like 'Lakshmi Bhandar' for all women without discrimination, I will never come to ask for votes again," the senior TMC leader asserted.

"The BJP's 'Modi guarantee' is zero warranty, while (CM) Mamata Banerjee's guarantee is a lifetime assurance," he said.

Highlighting development work in the constituency, Banerjee claimed that rural roads worth ₹80 crore had been constructed in the last three years "without any contribution from the Centre", and promised to double the investment to ₹160 crore over the next five years.

TMC will return to power for 4th term: Mamata

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Haldia (WB)

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Tuesday asserted that the TMC will return to power in the State for the fourth consecutive term, claiming that "no one wants the BJP to form Government".

Addressing a poll rally at Haldia in Purba Medinipur district, Banerjee also urged opposition parties to come together to oust the BJP-led NDA Government from the Centre. "The BJP will not win the elections in West Bengal this time. The Trinamool Congress will again form the Government. We will also throw out the BJP from Delhi in 2026 itself," Banerjee asserted.

The TMC chief said she has been extensively touring West Bengal for the last month, and during this period, "I have understood what people want; it is clear



West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee during an election campaign in Kolkata on Tuesday PTI

that no one wants the BJP."

Slamming the BJP for its 'chargesheet' against the TMC dispensation over alleged financial irregularities and other issues, the CM said she was also issuing a chargesheet against the saffron party for "taking cut-money (commission)" in the Haldia dock complex and adjoining industrial area.

"You gave a chargesheet

against the TMC; I am also issuing one against the BJP," Banerjee said.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah had on March 28 unveiled a chargesheet against the TMC dispensation, accusing it of corruption, deterioration in law and order and facilitation of infiltration. The CM, without naming anyone, said, "There is one traitor who takes cut

money (commission) from truck drivers, workers' wages and companies in the Haldia port and industrial area."

She claimed that the "traitor" takes 50 per cent of the money and sends the rest "to one of his leaders".

Banerjee also criticised PM Narendra Modi for stating in a recent rally that he was the BJP candidate in all 294 seats going to polls in West Bengal. "You have to quit the post of the prime minister first for that to happen," she said.

The assembly elections will be held in two phases - on April 23 and April 29. Votes will be counted on May 4.

Alleging malpractice during vote counting in the 2021 election in Nandigram, where BJP's Suwendu Adhikari defeated her, Banerjee asked TMC workers to come up with the name and address of anyone who may indulge in irregularities.

Naidu plays Dravidian card for NDA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Tuesday invoked Dravidian roots to seek votes for the NDA candidates in the run-up to the Tamil Nadu Assembly polls.

Invoking Tamil pride, the TDP chief said he came here to remind the people of the southern State about their future and appealed to them to vote for the National Democratic Alliance candidates. Addressing a press conference, he said Tamil Nadu is the cradle of Dravidian (South Indian) culture and observed that Tamil and Telugu people were together under the



Madras Presidency during the British colonial time before independence.

"You are all aware that Tamil Nadu is the cradle of Dravidian culture. We are all Dravidians. Historically, if you can go through it, we are (were) all in a combined province during the British period.

DMK's plan to split AIADMK successfully shattered: Palaniswami

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Salem

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami on Tuesday claimed that the DMK hatched a plan to split his party, but it was successfully negated. Addressing a poll campaign in his native Salem district on the concluding day of campaigning for the Assembly polls scheduled on Thursday, he also questioned the ruling DMK on the investment scenario. The AIADMK chief charged

DMK president MK Stalin with trying to "break" the AIADMK earlier. "When I was chief minister (2016-21), I faced many issues. Stalin hatched a plan to break our party, but we shattered that plan into pieces", he said.

Reiterating that this Assembly election is a contest between a "single family" that survives by "exploiting" Tamil Nadu and the people of the State, the Leader of the Opposition said, "people would put an end to this dynastic rule and hereditary



politics". Pointing out that Stalin's repeated assertion of the DMK-led alliance having all 39 MPs the State has, Palaniswami said the

MPs did not put pressure on the Centre for executing several projects, including the AIADMK proposed defence equipment facility here, which would have generated jobs for more than 3,000 persons.

Recalling Chief Minister Stalin's claim that under the DMK regime, 1,179 Memoranda of Understanding (MoUs) were signed and industrial investments totalling ₹15 lakh crore were attracted, creating 35 lakh jobs, Palaniswami said, "If that was truly the case, then 35

lakh people should have secured jobs. This (claim) is a complete fabrication". The former chief minister asserted that it will take four years to complete the construction of large-scale factories.

"Once an MoU has been signed, land acquisition must take place. After the factory acquires the land, the State Government must obtain clearance from the Central Government", he said, adding "the financial resources must be mobilised".

PM's *jhalhuri* purchase will impact Bengal polls: Anurag



Anurag Thakur speaks during a press conference ahead of the West Bengal Assembly elections in Kolkata on Tuesday PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

BJP MP Anurag Thakur on Tuesday said Prime Minister Narendra Modi buying *jhalhuri* in Jhargram would have an impact in the West Bengal Assembly polls and asked if Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee attempted any such outreach to small traders in 15 years.

Addressing a press conference in Kolkata, the senior BJP leader said that Narendra Modi was "not just a name but a brand who lives in the hearts of people". The PM on Sunday posted a video on his official social media account in which he was seen buying 'jhalhuri', a popular Bengali street food made of puffed rice, green chillies, and spices, from a non-descript shop in Jhargram.

The PM, who was accompanied by his security personnel, paid the shopkeeper for the snack. When the man denied taking the money, the prime minister insisted that he accept it.

Referring to the incident, Thakur said, "In the past 15 years, did the chief minister ever visit a small shop and buy something to eat? The prime minister did so.

"Even a small vendor selling goods worth ₹10 feels encouraged that the prime minister can eat at his shop. This is not a small incident. Its impact will be seen in the elections," he said.

He also accused the Trinamool Congress Government of blocking the implementation of several Central welfare schemes in the State and

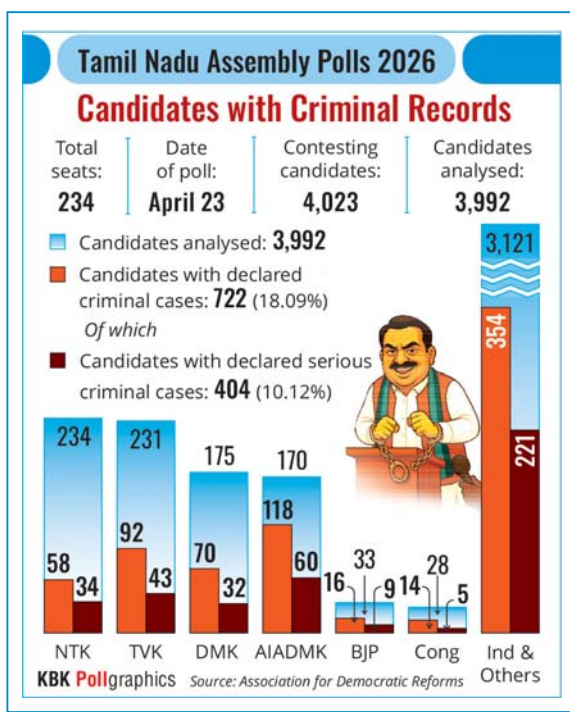
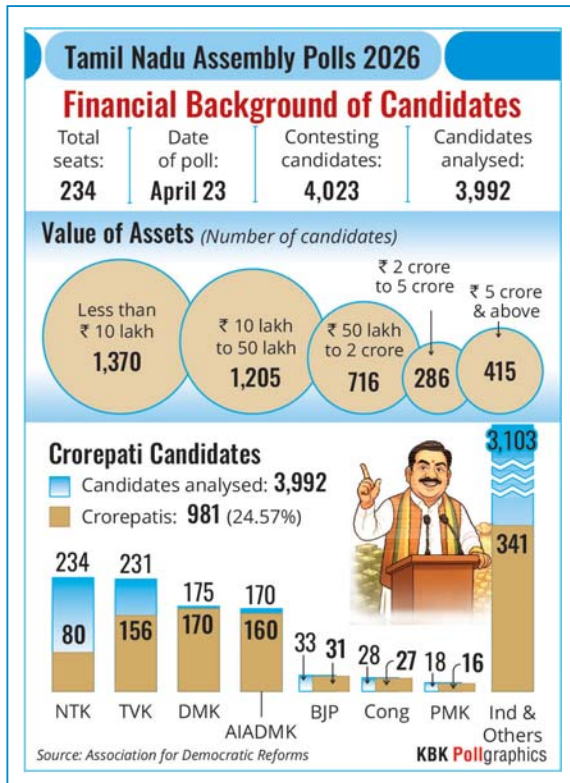
accused it of indulging in corruption.

About the BJP-led Union Government's failed bid to pass bills for the implementation of women's quota in legislatures from 2029, Thakur said, "Reservation for women is not a favour, it is their right. The BJP has ensured the passage of the law, but parties like the Congress and TMC delayed it for years."

Another BJP leader, Harsh Vardhan Shringla, claimed the TMC Government has failed to ensure the safety of women in the State.

Once the BJP wins the West Bengal Assembly polls, it would ensure "zero tolerance" towards crimes against women and provide reservation and financial support to them as outlined in its poll manifesto, he said. On the employment issue, Thakur alleged that unemployment in West Bengal was significantly higher than the national average and blamed the Mamata Banerjee Government for the lack of job opportunities in the State.

He further alleged that job losses in the informal sector and migration of youth to other States reflected a "governance failure" and accused the TMC dispensation of "fostering a hostile environment for businesses". "The people of Bengal are looking for a change. The BJP is committed to development, employment generation and transparent governance," Anurag Thakur added.



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Order Order

Delhi HC directs expeditious decision on visa plea by Moin Qureshi's daughter



The Delhi High Court has asked the authorities to expeditiously process the visa application of meat exporter Moin Akhtar Qureshi's daughter Pernia Qureshi. Justice Sachin Datta observed that Pernia Qureshi would submit the application for the grant of visa and asked the Foreigners Regional Registration Office (FRRO) to endeavour to issue her the visa according to the applicable guidelines.

The court passed the order on a 2019 petition by Pernia Qureshi, a US citizen, against the Centre's decision to revoke her Person of Indian Origin (PIO) status. She also challenged a 2018 communication informing her that a person whose parents, grandparents, or great-grandparents were citizens of Pakistan was not eligible for an Overseas Citizens of India (OCI) card.

"The petitioner in the present case would also prefer an application for grant of visa which shall be duly processed and considered by the respondent," said the court in the order passed on April 20.

"The Foreigners Regional Registration Office (FRRO) shall act expeditiously to process the application and make an endeavour to issue visa to the petitioner as per the applicable guidelines," it directed.

PIL in High Court alleges cruelty against bovines in cattle markets in Kerala



A PIL has been filed in the Kerala High Court alleging cruelty to animals at the cattle market in Perumbavoor, where domesticated bovines are reportedly kept tightly tethered without access to water and exposed to the scorching sun throughout the day.

The public interest litigation, filed by animal rights activist Angels Nair, claims that municipal and other local body cattle markets, including the one at Perumbavoor, are operating without proper shelter or adequate water facilities for the animals.

"The cattle will be slaughtered in a couple of days, which is not an excuse for inflicting unfathomable agony," the plea states.

The petition further alleges that cattle markets in the state are operating in violation of the advisory on "Livestock in the Event of Heat Wave Situation" issued by the Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying, as well as the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (Regulation of Livestock Markets) Rules, 2017.

It has sought directions from the High Court to put a stop to the illegal functioning of cattle markets in Kerala.

HC raps Centre over delay in responding to plea by mother of agniveer killed in Op Sindoor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court on Tuesday slammed the Centre for failing to respond to a petition filed by the mother of an agniveer who died during Operation Sindoor seeking posthumous benefits on par with regular soldiers killed in action, and warned of imposing high costs on it.

A bench of Justices Ravindra Ghuge and Hiten Venegaonkar granted the Centre time till May 6 to file its affidavit in response to the plea filed by the mother of Agniveer Murali Naik, who was killed in cross-border shelling in Jammu & Kashmir during Operation Sindoor in May last year.

The court noted that notices were issued to the Centre in December last year and then again in January, but to date, the response has not been filed.

"The petition has been pending since last year. Issues raised in the plea have also been addressed by the petitioner in a letter to the Government in July last year. There is some urgency. If a reply affidavit is not filed by the next date, we will impose heavy cost," Justice Ghuge warned.

The court stated that no further adjournments will be given.



It directed the Maharashtra Government to file its affidavit and posted the matter for further hearing on June 18.

Jyotibai Naik, the mother of Murali Naik, in her plea, stated that the Centre's Agnipath scheme creates an "arbitrary" distinction between Agniveers and regular soldiers, and questioned the "discriminatory" denial of full death benefits to the family.

Murali Naik was killed on May 9 last year in Poonch, J&K, when the Pakistan Army resorted to heavy cross-border artillery and mortar attacks, as India launched Operation Sindoor, a military action in retaliation against the Pahalgam terror strike that killed 26 people, mostly tourists, in April last

year. The petition, filed through advocates Sandesh More, Hemant Ghadigaonkar and Hitendra Gandhi, argued that Agniveers perform the same duties and face the same risks as regular soldiers, yet the families of those recruited under the short-term induction programme are denied long-term pension and other welfare benefits.

"The Agnipath scheme introduced by the Government expressly excludes Agniveers from post-service pension benefits and other long-term welfare entitlements normally available to regular soldiers," the petition pointed out.

As per the plea, the Naik family received an ex-gratia amount of around ₹1 crore, but not a regular family pension or any other benefits.

The petition sought directions to the Government to ensure equal posthumous benefits, including pensions, institutional recognition, and welfare measures for families of Agniveers who die in service. It also sought a direction to the authorities concerned to consider the petitioner's request for these benefits to be extended to her family. The plea stated that Naik was recruited into the Indian Army in June 2023 under the Agnipath scheme.



Plea in SC seeks contempt, NBW against businessman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A plea has been filed in the Supreme Court seeking contempt proceedings and issuance of non-bailable warrants (NBW) against businessman Satinder Singh Bhasin for not surrendering in connection with the alleged Grand Venice Mall scam despite the apex court's order.

The top court had on April 2 set aside the bail granted to Bhasin, the director of Bhasin Infotech and Infrastructure Private Limited (BIPL), and directed him to surrender before the jail authorities within a week.

Investors in the upscale projects in Greater Noida had claimed that they were duped

by the developer BIPL. Alleging "wilful defiance" of the authority of this court, the plea filed by Louleen Kaur Bhalla and Jagvinder Singh, allottees in the projects, sought directions to give effect to and secure compliance with the judgment dated April 2, 2026.

"It is respectfully submitted that, in spite of the clear directions issued by this court in the aforesaid judgment, the petitioner has failed to surrender to date, in disregard and wilful disobedience of the orders passed by this court."

"The petitioner has thus consciously and deliberately chosen not to comply with the said directions, thereby demonstrating wilful defiance of the authority of this



Satinder Singh Bhasin

court," the plea said. The petition stated that instead of complying with the judgment, Bhasin has resorted to "dilatatory tactics with a view to evade surrender."

The top court had on April 8 refused to entertain Bhasin's plea seeking the extension of

time to surrender. The petition contended that Bhasin has filed another application seeking recall of the judgment dated April 2, 2026, "which is nothing but a calculated attempt to delay and frustrate" the implementation of the directions.

Pawan Khera not flight risk, counsel tells Gauhati HC hearing Congress leader's anticipatory bail plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Pawan Khera is not a flight risk and there is no need for his arrest, his counsel argued in the Gauhati High Court, which on Tuesday heard the Congress leader's anticipatory bail plea over an FIR lodged by the Assam CM's wife for alleging she held multiple passports.

A single bench of Justice Parthiv Jyoti Saikia reserved the final order after hearing both sides for over three hours.

Senior advocate Abhishek Manu Singhvi, who appeared for Khera via video conferencing, argued that the remarks made by Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma in response to the Congress leader's allegations point to political vendetta, especially in the context of the Assembly elections in the State.

Assam Advocate General Devajit Lon Saikia opposed granting any relief to Khera, submitting that this is not a simple defamation case, as the matter



Pawan Khera

involves the forgery of documents and title deeds. Saikia pointed out that the dominant offences are cheating and forgery. He argued that Khera is not entitled to interim protection as he is a "flight risk".

The Congress spokesperson had moved the Gauhati High Court on Monday seeking anticipatory bail in connection with the case registered against him by the CM's wife Riniki Bhuyan Sharma for alleging that she possessed multiple passports and undisclosed properties abroad.

She filed criminal cases against Khera and others at the Guwahati Crime Branch police station under sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, including 175 (false statement in connection with an election), 35, 36, 318 (cheating), 338, (forgery of valuable will, security etc.), 337 (forgery of record of court or of public register, etc), 340 (forged document or electronic record and using it as genuine), 352 (intentional insult with intent to provoke breach of peace), and 356 (defamation).

The Telangana High Court had earlier granted Khera a seven-day transit anticipatory bail, but the Supreme Court stayed the order.

Delhi High Court impleads Centre in Shivakumar plea in money laundering case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Tuesday sought the Centre's stand on a petition by Karnataka Deputy Chief Minister DK Shivakumar against certain provisions of the anti-money laundering law and a probe by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) against him, while directing that the interim protection to him from coercive action will continue.

A bench of Justices Navin Chawla and Ravinder Dubeja made the central Government a party to the petition, filed in 2022, on a request by the Congress leader's senior counsel, Kapil Sibal, after the additional solicitor general (ASG) contended that a petition challenging a central enactment was not maintainable in the absence of the Union of India.

ASG SV Raju, appearing for the ED, said either Shivakumar should withdraw his petition or the court should dismiss it as not maintainable.



DK Shivakumar

The bench, however, allowed the Centre's impleadment and granted it four weeks to file a reply, observing that the petition had been pending since 2022 and this objection was being raised for the first time.

Further, the issues for determination were flagged in 2022 and the matter was listed for final hearing after the filing of written submissions, it added.

"Let the amended memo of parties be filed. Notice be issued to the Union of India. Counter affidavit, if any, be filed in four weeks of receipt of notice," the court ordered. As the court directed that

the interim order granting protection from coercive action to Shivakumar would continue, ASG Raju said he was withdrawing his earlier assurance on not taking any steps against the senior politician.

The bench, however, remarked that as per the earlier order, the ED was bound not to take coercive steps in the matter.

"Look at the manner in which the order has been passed. It does not say your statement. (It says) till further orders, the respondent will be bound. Not that you are saying," the bench clarified and listed it for hearing on July 23.

Will Constitution not come to rescue of believer who is not allowed to touch deity: SC



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday asked the chief priest of the Sabarimala Ayyappa Temple if the Constitution will not come to the rescue of a believer who is not allowed to touch the deity.

The remark by the top court came after the chief priest said that when a devotee goes to a temple for worship, it can't be in antagonism to the characteristics of a deity.

The nine-judge Constitution bench is hearing petitions related to discrimination against women at religious places, including the Sabarimala Temple in Kerala, and on the ambit and scope of the religious freedom practised by multiple faiths.

The bench comprises Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices BV Nagarathna, MM Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B Varale, R Mahadevan, and Joyimalya Bagchi.

Appearing for the 'thantri', senior advocate V Giri submitted that the nature of ceremonies and rituals followed in any temple forms the integral part of the religion and therefore is a religious practice.

He said continuance of such practice, which is an essential religious practice, would be a part of the right to worship that is for every member who believes in the religion or religious denomination.

"When a devotee goes to a temple for worship, it can't be

of petitions filed by allottees of the Grand Venice project, seeking cancellation of bail granted to Bhasin due to violations of certain bail conditions.

The top court had directed that Bhasin may apply for regular bail afresh after a period of 12 months, subject to fully complying with the orders passed in the insolvency proceedings.

The top court had, in November 2019, granted Bhasin bail in these cases subject to various conditions.

Around 46 FIRs were registered against several people in connection with the alleged scam in which investors claimed that they were duped by the accused when handing over the plot of land.

in antagonism to the characteristics of a deity because its for the purpose of worshipping the deity.

The devotee surrenders to the divine spirit contained in the deity. He/she has to accept the essential characteristics of the deity," Giri said.

Posing a question, Justice Amanullah asked, "When I go to a temple, my fundamental belief is that he is the Lord, he is my creator, he has created me, right?"

"I go there with one hundred percent belief. I am totally devoted, absolutely nothing impure in my heart. And there, I am told that because of a birth, a lineage, a certain situation, permanently you are not allowed to touch the deity. Now, will the Constitution not come to the rescue? Justice Amanullah remarked, adding that there cannot be a difference between the creator and creation.

Giri replied that if there is a complete ban on anybody becoming a priest, then that will be taken care of either by a Article 25(2)(b) legislation or it will be taken care of by the State itself.

"If priest means the person who is instructed in the 'Shastras' as to how to conduct worship and how to worship the deity, if there is a complete ban on any person becoming a priest and then doing the 'seva', as we call it, only by reason of birth, that will be taken care of either by a Article 25(2)(b) legislation or it will be taken care of by the State itself," he said.

Hate crime: Why is investigating officer playing hide and seek with court, SC asks UP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Why is your investigating officer playing "hide and seek" with this court, the Supreme Court on Tuesday asked the Uttar Pradesh Government while expressing displeasure over the compliance affidavit filed by the police in a case of alleged hate crime in Noida in 2021.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta asked Additional Solicitor General KM Nataraj, who was appearing for Uttar Pradesh, as to why the police has not added section 153-B of the Indian Penal Code in the case.

Section 153-B of the erstwhile IPC deals with the offence of imputations, assertions prejudicial to national integration.

The top court said the law officer had on February 16 stated before it that from the allegations as set out in the complaint, the necessary ingredients of offences punishable under sections 153-B



and 295-A of the IPC were made out and the FIR ought to have been registered for the said offences.

Section 295-A pertains to deliberate and malicious acts intended to outrage religious feelings of any class by insulting its religion or religious beliefs.

The top court was hearing a plea seeking a fair investigation and trial on a complaint by a senior citizen, who claimed that he was abused and tortured in an alleged hate crime in Noida in July 2021. During the hearing on Tuesday, Nataraj

informed the bench that the trial court has allowed the police to conduct further investigation in the case and the police would add the necessary provisions.

The counsel appearing for the petitioner said the apex court had earlier said that offences under sections 153-B and 295-A of the IPC should have been added in the FIR. "Section 153-B has been dropped again," the counsel said.

"Why your IO (investigating officer) is playing hide and seek with this court?" the bench asked the state, while

questioning why section 153-B was not added.

Nataraj assured the bench that the police would add section 153-B.

"We are not satisfied with the compliance affidavit filed by the respondent," the bench said.

The top court said it was inclined to summon the IO but on Nataraj's request, it was granting two weeks to ensure full compliance.

It posted the matter for hearing on May 19.

"Please advise your officers otherwise they will be in trouble. We have no fun in calling them and giving them a dressing down," the bench told the law officer.

On February 16, the Uttar Pradesh Government told the top court that FIR in the case should have been registered for the offences, including under section 153-B.

The apex court on February 3 questioned the state as to why appropriate provisions of the IPC were not invoked in the FIR lodged in the alleged hate crime in 2021.



Editor's
TAKE

India-South Korea ties: From trade to trust

South Korean President Lee Jae-myung's visit offers a chance to reset bilateral ties, positioning the partnership as a stabilising force in an uncertain world

The visit of South Korean President Lee Jae Myung to India is being seen in New Delhi as an important state visit that could catapult relations between the two countries to the next level. It is both timely and strategic, coming at a moment when South Korea is exploring partnerships beyond the United States in a changing world order. While South Korea is a relatively recent diplomatic partner for India, their historical connections run much deeper. Buddhism reached Korea between the 4th and 8th centuries, laying an early cultural foundation.

However, it took long time for the two nations to formalise diplomatic ties after South Korea and India became independent in 1945 and 1947 respectively. Consular relations were established in 1962, followed by ambassador-level diplomatic relations in 1973. These ties were elevated to a "Strategic Partnership" in 2010 and further to a "Special Strategic Partnership" in 2015. Yet, despite these historical and institutional links, the relationship has remained largely economic rather than cultural or strategic. It is high time to elevate it, and both countries appear to recognise this need.

Efforts to upgrade the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) signals an intent to transform an economic partnership into a future-oriented alliance. Bilateral trade has indeed expanded, but it remains imbalanced. India's exports to South Korea stood at USD 5.81 billion in 2024-25, while imports were around USD 21 billion. There is a great scope to improve market access for Indian goods such as steel, rice, and shrimp, while ensuring fairer trade policies from the Korean Government. However, reducing the relationship to trade figures alone would be short-sighted. Discussions between PM Modi and President Lee reflect a broader strategic vision.

India and South Korea possess complementary strengths. South Korea's advanced manufacturing, electronics industry, and robust R&D base align well with India's expanding market and growing talent pool. This synergy has the potential to create resilient supply chains that are less vulnerable to global disruptions and can sustain on its own. Equally significant is the convergence of both nations in the Indo-Pacific region. Both nations share a commitment to maintaining a rules-based order, where economic prosperity is closely linked with strategic stability. However, the real challenge lies in implementation. Previous rounds of CEPA review negotiations have often stalled due to variance in expectations on both sides. This time, both sides must demonstrate flexibility and political will. For India, this means continuing reforms to improve the ease of doing business and attract Korean investment.

For South Korea, it involves addressing India's concerns over non-tariff barriers and ensuring greater reciprocity in trade. Although government-level engagement has its limitations, people-to-people connections and cultural exchanges are growing steadily. From K-pop to Indian cinema, younger generations are finding common ground. This soft power potential must be nurtured and expanded to further strengthen bilateral ties.

Trump vs Pope Leo XIV: A clash of power and faith

For millions of Catholics, the clash is not merely political theatre; it is a test of allegiance between temporal power and spiritual authority, unfolding at a moment when both seek to shape the moral language of global conflict



KALYANI SHANKAR

The conflict between President Donald Trump and Pope Leo XIV is unprecedented. While popes have commented on politics before, Trump's personal insults towards the Pope are unusual. Although reports suggest his tone has softened, his discomfort is still clear.

In 250 years of US history, no president has personally attacked a pope. Such public disagreements create only confusion.

Trump publicly condemned Pope Leo XIV after the Pope criticised the actions of the US and Israel regarding Iran. This marked a significant confrontation.

The conflict between President Trump and Pope Leo XIV is unprecedented in modern history, highlighting a rare clash that blends political power with religious symbolism, which can deeply influence public opinion and faith communities.

Trump said, "I have a right to disagree with the Pope." He claimed, "The Pope made a statement saying 'Iran can have a nuclear weapon.' I say 'Iran cannot have a nuclear weapon,'" although a reporter noted that Pope Leo has not made such remarks publicly.

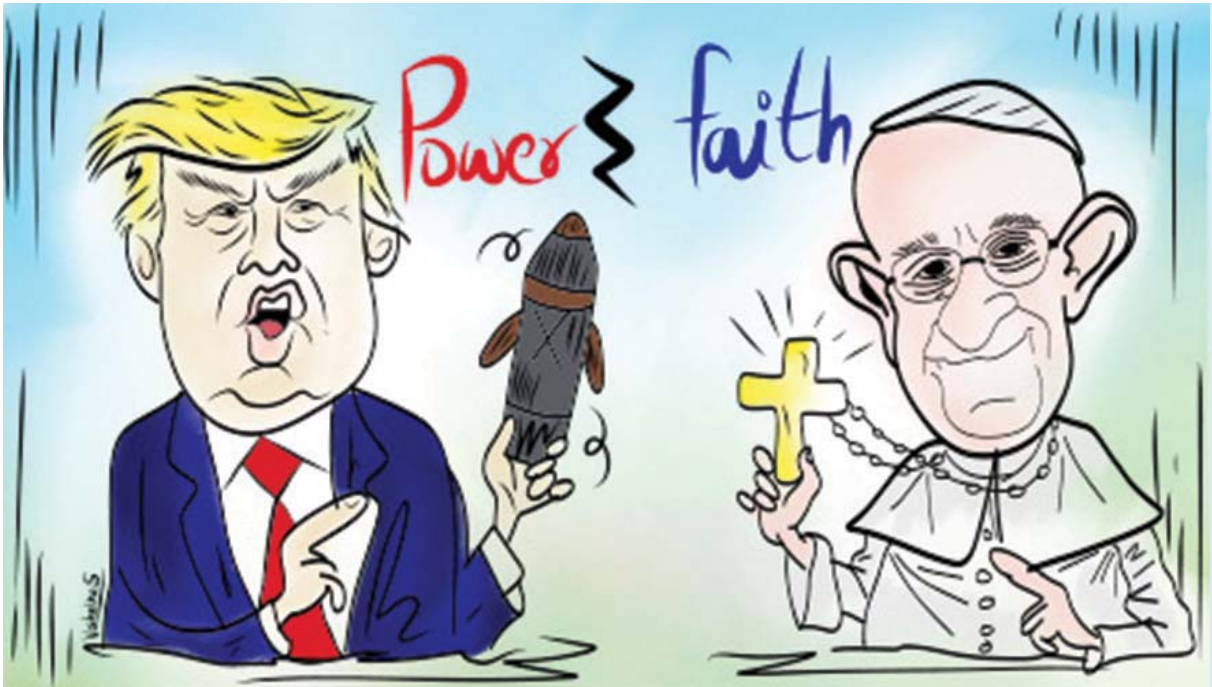
Pope Leo expressed that he had "no fear of the Trump administration" and would continue to speak out about God's message.

Catholics, as the largest swing voting group, are affected by this dispute, which could influence their voting decisions and shape future election outcomes. Tensions peaked during Holy Week, further shaping public opinion and underscoring their stake in the conflict.

Trump also criticised the conclave, arguing that Leo was "selected" by the Church to "match Trump's presence." Shortly after, Trump shared an AI-generated image of himself as Christ healing the sick, but later deleted it, saying it was to show him "as a doctor."

All the major cardinals and bishops who made statements are supporting the Pope and criticising Trump. The President's approval rating among white Catholics dropped from 59% in February 2025 to 36% in January 2026, and among Hispanic Catholics, it fell from 31% to 23%.

Tensions rose when Trump accused Pope Leo of being "weak on crime and ineffective in foreign policy," likely in response to calls from Catholic leaders for more compassion in his immigration policies. Trump claimed



Leo supported Iran's nuclear ambitions and intensified his attacks on social media, stating, "Will someone please tell Pope Leo that Iran has killed at least 42,000 innocent, unarmed protesters in the last two months?"

Earlier, many popes have criticised political leaders, though this is rare. Pope Leo has called for peace and has publicly opposed the ongoing US-led war against Iran. It is unclear why Trump claims that Leo supports nuclear weapons in Iran.

Pope John Paul II called for solutions to conflicts in the Middle East and Lebanon in 1979 while addressing the United Nations on human rights. In 2013, Pope Francis led a peace vigil for Syria and wrote to President Putin to oppose military actions. After a chemical attack in 2017 that killed about 70 people, he expressed his outrage and urged leaders to stop the violence, stating that he does not hear the prayers of those who wage war.

Pope Leo criticised leaders who waste billions on war, stating that the world is "being ravaged by a handful of tyrants." These strong remarks were made during his visit to Cameroon, where he condemned those who misuse "the very name of God" for their own gain.

Pope Leo has been a strong critic of warfare in general, particularly condemning the combat operations launched by the US and Israel during their surprise attack against Iran on February 28. He also labelled Trump's threat to destroy Iran's "whole civilisation" as "truly unacceptable."

This time, the discomfort is stronger. For devoted voters and religious community members, the matter is not just political; it also involves religious symbolism, which holds great importance. "I do not fear Trump," said Pope Leo after the President called him "weak," emphasising the resilience of faith amid political disputes.

On April 12, the President criticised Leo, saying he is "weak on crime" and "weak on nuclear weapons." He also suggested that the Pope thinks it is acceptable for Iran to have a nuclear weapon.

On April 16, Trump spoke with the press about his disagreement with the Pope. He stated that he needs to do what is right. What does he have against the Pope? "It's very simple, I have nothing against the Pope," Trump claimed. "The Pope made a statement. He says, 'Iran can have a nuclear weapon,' I say, 'Iran cannot have a nuclear weapon.'"

Leo told reporters on April 13, at the start of his Africa trip, "I will speak out against war and promote peace, dialogue, and multilateral solutions to conflicts."

The Washington Post reports that the war in Iran is unpopular among Americans. This week, Democrats attempted to limit the President's engagement, passing war powers resolutions in the House and Senate along mostly partisan lines, while Republicans opposed these efforts. Pope Leo XIV seeks to ease tensions with President Trump, stating on X that a "disciple of Christ is never on the side of those who once wielded the sword and today drop bombs."

ON APRIL 12, THE PRESIDENT CRITICISED LEO, SAYING HE IS "WEAK ON CRIME" AND "WEAK ON NUCLEAR WEAPONS." HE ALSO SUGGESTED THAT THE POPE THINKS IT IS ACCEPTABLE FOR IRAN TO HAVE A NUCLEAR WEAPON

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The real pollution: When the mind poisons the earth



RAYOGI BRAHMA KUMAR NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

Today, globally, every country is facing the consequences of pollution, contamination, or abuse of air, water, food, and even space on a very large scale, yet they are unable to find a foolproof solution to this dangerous threat to humanity. Environmental pollution, having been the focus of public attention during the last couple of years, is now increasingly being recognised as the result of humanity's wanton and often cruel treatment of planet Earth, leading to the ravaging and ruin of the atmosphere. The denudation of forests, the poisoning of lakes and rivers with pesticides and industrial waste, the pollution of the atmosphere with smoke from automobiles and factory chimneys, and the overuse of chlorofluorocarbons-resulting in ozone depletion-have brought the world to the brink of environmental disaster.

Environmental scientists now warn that the accumulation of CO₂ in the atmosphere will not only lead to the greenhouse effect but also increase the planet's average temperature by 3°F to 9°F. This, in turn, could cause sea levels to rise by several feet, flooding coastal areas, destroying vast tracts of farmland, and triggering further calamities. It is therefore being suggested that industries must re-examine their production processes so that industrial waste and emissions are reduced, waste products are recycled, and mass transport systems are encouraged in place of private automobiles.

If we look up the dictionary meaning of the word "pollution", we may find something like "to destroy the purity of; to contaminate". However, we as humans are largely aware only of material pollution-the branches of the polluted tree-while disregarding the root cause: thought pollution. Without addressing this root, the source can never truly be purified. It would not be an exaggeration to say that environmental pollution is, in essence, a reflection of the pollution of the human mind, which is often filled with selfishness, jealousy, greed, and anger. The problem of ecological imbalance stems from mental imbalance, and the disequilibrium in nature mirrors the disequilibrium within human consciousness.

Secondly, the problem of pollution is closely linked to rapid population growth. To meet the demands of an

expanding population, there is an increasing need for electricity, fuel, energy, automobiles, wood, water, paper, and industrial output-all of which exert significant pressure on the environment. Additionally, modern lifestyles have intensified the demand for energy and consumer goods. As a result, forests are cleared, farmlands are replaced by expanding urban spaces, and industrial waste and emissions of CO₂, SO₂, and other pollutants continue to rise. Without addressing population growth and transforming lifestyles and attitudes, the problem of environmental pollution cannot be effectively resolved. In this context, spiritual thought plays a crucial role. The solution lies not only in technology or policy but also in self-realisation and understanding our relationship with others and nature. Without moral and spiritual values, no problem can be resolved sustainably.

It is therefore essential to recognise our true nature beyond the physical self. Without this shift, scientific progress without spirituality could lead to serious global crises. Thus, we must combine scientific advancement with spiritual wisdom to cleanse thought pollution and live in harmony with nature.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a popular columnist

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INDIA MUST PREPARE FOR IMPACT OF POOR MONSOON

Apropos "India braces for a below-average monsoon" (April 21, 2026), the warning of El Niño's shadow over rainfall is more than a meteorological forecast; it is a reminder of how fragile our agrarian backbone remains. With nearly 61 per cent of farmers dependent on rain-fed cultivation, even a modest deficit in rainfall can trigger a chain reaction-crop failures, rising input costs, and eventual food inflation. Such conditions not only strain farm incomes but also ripple through the broader economy, affecting consumption and rural demand.

The resilience of rural India will once again be tested, particularly in regions already vulnerable to water stress and erratic weather patterns. In this context, policy preparedness must move beyond rhetoric and

translate into concrete, time-bound action. Relief measures announced after distress has already set in often prove inadequate; what is required is anticipatory governance that mitigates risks before they escalate. This moment calls for pragmatic foresight. Strengthening water management systems, promoting crop diversification, expanding irrigation coverage, and ensuring timely access to credit and insurance are no longer optional-they are essential safeguards.

A below-average monsoon must not lead to below-average governance. The true test of the state lies in its ability to protect livelihoods, stabilise markets, and ensure food security for all.

K CHIDANAND KUMAR | BENGALURU

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Strengthening women's role in democracy

Trump proves a postulate in the quality of leadership: the enduring thread in history is not ideology or institution, but temperament, wherein impulse rivals intention. From Alcibiades of Greece, who shifted loyalties with the tides of the Peloponnesian War, to Muhammad bin Tughluq, whose restless experiments disoriented a realm, power has often leaned on brilliance unmoored from consistency. Nero turned rule into spectacle, while Napoleon Bonaparte, Emperor of France, revealed how immense will, unchecked, could both forge and fracture order.

In the modern age, this has been refined. Richard Nixon of the United States harnessed unpredictability as a deliberate stratagem; Silvio Berlusconi of Italy recast politics as personal theatre; Juan Perón of Argentina blurred ideology to sustain mass appeal. Each, in different measure, bent institutions without entirely discarding their necessity.

In this cavalcade, Donald Trump must be seen not as an aberration, but as rawness acquiring even greater abrasion. His unpredictability no longer merely serves power; it begins to define it. History shows that while power may thrive on surprise, order depends on trust.

YUGAL KISHORE SHARMA | FARIDABAD

Protecting lives on national highways

The Supreme Court's decision on safer highways is both timely and commendable. The Right to Life under Article 21 is not merely protection against unlawful death but also a mandate to ensure safe living conditions, including road safety. Recognising commuter safety as integral to this right, the Court has issued crucial interim directions.

The ban on parking heavy or commercial vehicles on National Highway carriageways is a decisive step. Stationary vehicles have long been a major cause of fatal accidents, exposing gaps in enforcement. The Court has rightly directed that such vehicles must only stop at designated bays or lay-bys.

It is alarming that National Highways, though only about 2 per cent of total road length, account for nearly 30 per cent of road fatalities.

This reflects serious infrastructural and administrative shortcomings. Strict implementation of the Court's order is essential to prevent avoidable loss of life.

The judiciary has rightly emphasised that no administrative or financial constraint can outweigh human life. This directive must now be enforced in both letter and spirit.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

Save Earth, secure our future

Earth is the most precious treasure shared by humanity. Yet, people behave as though another planet exists.

The pressure on natural resources has doubled over the past half-century, while these resources have declined significantly. This imbalance threatens the harmony between humans and nature.

Deforestation, wildlife destruction, air pollution, and chemical waste have severely damaged the environment. Such degradation leads to serious health risks and ecological instability. It is imperative that people recognise their responsibility towards protecting nature.

Sustainable practices such as waste recycling, water treatment, rainwater harvesting, and the use of solar and wind energy must be widely adopted. These measures can help restore balance and ensure long-term sustainability.

Earth is not meant to be conquered but respected and preserved. A shift in attitude, along with collective effort, is essential to safeguard the planet. The actions we take today will determine the well-being of future generations. Truly, it is "our power, our planet."

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

How US-Iran tensions threaten the global food – energy – water balance

Any disruption in the Strait of Hormuz does more than drive up fuel prices; it triggers a chain reaction across agriculture, water systems, and global supply chains. This can rapidly escalate into a systemic crisis – tightening food supplies, straining water resources, and impacting an already fragile food – energy – water balance

PREM KUMAR KALRA
RUPALI SATSANGI AND
JYOTI KUMAR VERMA

The conflict between the United States and Iran is not merely a focal point of geopolitical tension; rather, it is a major issue that can trigger a cascading series of crises within the food-energy-water (FEW) nexus. The centrepiece of this turmoil is the Strait of Hormuz, through which a significant portion of the world's oil passes. Any disruption there causes a sharp surge in crude oil prices, triggering a chain reaction throughout global supply systems.

The nexus of water, food, and energy is fundamental to sustainable development. Agriculture accounts for the largest share of the world's freshwater resources, while water plays a pivotal role in the production of various forms of energy. The demand for these three resources is rising rapidly. To address current and future challenges, governments must ensure the integrated and sustainable management of water, food, and energy in order to strike a balance among the needs of humanity, nature, and the economy.

Sudden increases in energy prices directly raise the cost of fertiliser production, especially nitrogen-based fertilisers that rely on natural gas, thereby reducing profits for farmers around the world. As a result, farmers are turning to lower-cost crops, a shift that could lead to a decline in agricultural productivity and increase pressure on global food supplies. Moreover, rising fuel prices increase transportation and logistics costs, disrupting the movement of goods and leading to food wastage, as evidenced by delays in Indian basmati rice exports and the spoilage of stranded perishable goods in Gulf countries, depriving them of “dum biryani”, as reported.

The extent of the crisis is not evenly distributed across countries but is deeply interconnected. Countries like Brazil are grappling with variations in the ethanol-sugar equation, driving up prices of staple foods, whereas Sri Lanka's export disruptions are affecting tea farmers' incomes. Australia-type developed economies are not immune to internal distributional constraints, highlighting the vulnerability of food systems to energy crises.

Most significantly, this conflict reveals structural weaknesses in global supply chains that depend excessively on a single route, have limited diversity in sourcing, and rely on weak logistics infrastructure. Import-dependent regions of West Asia have highlighted the urgent need for multi-source locating strategies, robust food corridors, and decentralised storage systems.

The demand for water, food, and energy is constantly rising. Pressure on this interdependent system has been further intensified by a growing global population, rapid urbanisation, shifting dietary preferences, and economic expansion. A significant global shift is currently underway: as incomes rise in many countries, people are transitioning away from primarily starch-based diets towards meat and dairy products, the production of which requires substantial amounts of water.

Both food production and energy consumption are heavily dependent on water resources. The agricultural sector accounts for the largest share of the world's freshwater use; furthermore, more than a quarter of global energy consumption is expended on food production and distribution. Most energy production processes are also water-intensive, including those utilised in coal-fired power plants, nuclear reactors, and the cultivation of biofuel crops.

The pressure on the water-food-energy nexus poses a significant threat to the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). As water resources become increasingly scarce and strained due to overexploitation, their capacity to advance various SDGs-particularly those related to poverty eradication, hunger reduction, sustainability, and environmental protection-is diminishing. Governments need to further boost their renewable energy initiatives.

There is an urgent need for greater support for the development of renewable energy sources that are less dependent on water, such as hydropower and wind energy. Geothermal energy holds immense potential as



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THE CONFLICT
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UNITED STATES
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INSTABILITY, AND
WATER SCARCITY.

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a long-term and climate-friendly resource; it emits very few, if any, greenhouse gases and requires little to no water usage.

A Fragile Nexus: Food, Energy, and Water Interdependence
The crisis also highlights the deep interdependence of the FEW nexus. Disruptions in energy supply constrain water extraction and irrigation systems, while water scarcity impacts agricultural production. Together, these factors create feedback loops that could escalate into a major humanitarian crisis.

Excessive reliance on global fertiliser supply chains further exacerbates this vulnerability. Supply disruptions can reduce the availability of essential inputs, limit crop yields, and fuel global food inflation, disproportionately and most severely affecting low-income, import-dependent nations.

Policy imperatives: Building resilience in a volatile world

Policy responses must extend beyond short-term crisis management. Institutions such as the Food and Agriculture Organization advocate mechanisms like food import financing facilities to stabilise vulnerable economies, while the World Trade Organization's frameworks prioritise food trade as a global public good.

Coordinated global and regional action is required to address such systemic risks. The Food and Agriculture Organization has proposed a Food Import Financing Facility (FIFF) to assist vulnerable nations during times of crisis, while the World Trade Organization emphasises that food trade constitutes a critical moral obligation for global stability.

Policy box: Pathways to resilience

- Diversified sourcing: Develop procurement strategies across multiple locations in South Asia, Africa, Europe, and Latin America.
- Food corridors: Invest in alternative trade routes, inland logistics, and port connectivity.
- Climate-resilient agriculture: Promote bio-fertilisers, regenerative farming, and precision agriculture to reduce chemical dependency.
- Supply chain infrastructure: Strengthen storage, warehousing, and cold-chain networks to minimise post-harvest losses.
- Digital integration: Utilise real-time tracking and demand forecasting to stabilise markets.
- Risk management: Expand commodity market instruments to mitigate volatility and prevent panic selling.

Conclusion: The transition from geopolitics to human security

The conflict between the United States and Iran extends beyond regional boundaries and represents a global systemic threat. In the absence of proactive interventions, localised military conflicts could escalate into a broader crisis characterised by food shortages, energy instability, and water scarcity.

In our interconnected world, resilience must be fostered not in isolation but through collaborative efforts. Safeguarding the nexus of food, energy, and water (FEW) is no longer merely an economic concern; it has become a moral and strategic imperative for ensuring global stability.

The Iran model of warfighting: Should India adopt It?



GAURAV M
TRIPATHI

Unfortunately, most analyses have been somewhat simplistic and have tended to link desired outcomes in the Indian scenario with recommendations cherry-picked from the Iranian experience, but without context. This has led to a flawed narrative gaining ground-that drones and missiles can replace expensive fighters, and that if Iran can take on a superpower, then that is the path India must follow.

This narrative is based on certain notions whose correctness is questionable. These are, firstly, that a drone/missile-based approach is more cost-effective than one based on fighters; secondly, that drones and missiles will be effective in creating the required effects at the military/operational level; and lastly, that they can generate the strategic impact needed to achieve the desired political outcome.

However, direct transplantation to the Indian scenario may not work. It begins with the difference in the notion of victory. For Iran, faced with a vastly superior grouping of adversaries, matching them was never an option. It therefore adopted an ultra-defensive strategy of resilience based on force protection and counter-attacks using drones and missiles.

It invested heavily in subterranean storage, reportedly going as deep as 500 m. This was key to its success, as it ensured survival and enabled retaliation. This infrastructure did not come cheap.

Estimates for tunnels at 50 m depth in Tehran range from \$150-188 million for a 5 km stretch. Deeper tunnels in remote mountains would cost more. Most estimates suggest 30 or more such 'cities', while some even mention 'hundreds'. Were India to adopt a similar posture, the investment required would be at least two to three times higher. The notion of drones and missiles offering a cost advantage therefore falls flat. Secondly, US forces in the Gulf region are based at a limited number of locations and within specified areas of shared bases, as per relevant intergovernmental agreements. These factors severely constrained the US ability to disperse assets or move them frequently, and offered Iran a set of fixed, discrete, well-defined targets. Launching missiles and drones in large numbers against such targets provides a reasonable chance of success. However, Pakistan would be able to disperse rapidly across its territory. China presents an even greater challenge and already possesses extensive subterranean protective infrastructure, along with a dense air defence ecosystem. Creating the same operational impact with drones and missiles would therefore be far more difficult for India than it was for Iran.

Thirdly, Iran operated under a unique set of conditions: a superpower adversary with a maximalist notion of victory (regime change); a hardline, faith-based polity for which direct conflict with the US and Israel was seen as an opportunity rather than a threat; a dominant position with respect to a major choke point; and numerous significant economic and strategic targets within range. It adopted a counter-value targeting approach, including against neutral third-party maritime traffic, effectively closing the Strait of Hormuz and delivering a major economic shock globally. Amplified by social media-and contrasted with perceived US overconfidence and questionable legality-this created a strategic impact disproportionate to the actual military effects. It is difficult to identify any parallel between such a setting and the Indian context. Kamikaze drones and missiles also cannot perform reconnaissance (ISR), visual interception, signalling, air policing, or be switched 'wave to wave' between domains (land to sea), or between roles within the same sortie, with extended range through refuelling. The economics also favour reusable platforms (such as fighters or UAVs) over single-use systems like kamikaze drones or missiles. There is a reason why reusable launch systems, such as those pioneered by SpaceX, are widely pursued. Furthermore, Iran's approach effectively ceded control of its sovereign airspace to the US and Israel, allowing their air forces to conduct largely unrestricted operations. If India were to adopt a similar approach, it could result in the decimation of its land and sea offensive capabilities, severely undermining deterrence.

In sum, the cost argument does not hold, as a successful ultra-defensive posture requires substantial investment in protective infrastructure. The operational effects achieved by Iran cannot be reliably replicated in the Indian context. Finally, the strategic impact of those effects cannot be achieved by India due to fundamentally different targeting philosophies, domestic political considerations, and relative power equations with its adversaries.

That said, drones and missiles do have a significant role to play. They enable scale, expand the threat spectrum, and can overwhelm adversaries. They can shape the battlefield and support more precise and heavier ordnance delivery by reusable platforms, whether manned or unmanned. The Indian Air Force anticipated this and supported several start-ups in developing indigenous swarm capabilities under its Mehar Baba initiative (2019-2021). It also has multiple ongoing programmes for both kamikaze drones and missiles.

The optimal approach lies in a nuanced mix of capabilities, rather than simplistic doctrines that could commit the country to an ultra-defensive strategy with little prospect of victory and a limited ability to avoid defeat.



The writer, Air
Commodore Gaurav M
Tripathi, VSM retired
from the Indian Air Force
in 2025

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Stalled promise: Why the Nari Shakti Vandan Vidheyak failed in Parliament



ASHWANI
MAHAJAN

the context of the GST Act, when the numbers in the Rajya Sabha were not in the government's favour, the government still succeeded in getting the Bill passed after initial hiccups. The question that arises is: why did the Nari Shakti Vandan Vidheyak fail to pass this time, compelling the government to withdraw two other associated Bills as well?

To comprehend this situation, we must examine this legislation within its historical context. In 2023, the 'Women's Reservation Act' was passed, providing for 33 per cent reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies. Although this legislation was enacted into law, it could not be implemented immediately. The reason was that the Act explicitly stipulated that it would come into effect only after the completion of a new Census and the subsequent delimitation process (the redrawing of electoral con-

stituency boundaries). The Census, scheduled for 2021, was postponed due to the COVID-19 pandemic. The Census process is currently underway but is unlikely to be completed before 2028. As for delimitation, it can only be undertaken once the Census is complete, as the demarcation of parliamentary and legislative assembly constituencies is feasible only after the Census data has been compiled. Evidently, this entire process could not realistically be accomplished in time for the 2029 general elections.

In this context, with a view to expediting the implementation of the women's reservation law, the government introduced a new Women's Reservation Bill (Nari Shakti Vandan Vidheyak). It stipulated that delimitation of constituencies for the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies be carried out on the basis of the 2011 Census. However, the Bill was defeated in the Lok Sabha on 17 April 2026 due to the lack of a two-thirds majority, thereby freezing the possibility of providing reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies in the near future.

There is intense resentment within the ruling coalition regarding this issue, as well as among women at large. In this context, it is necessary to ascertain whether the Opposition possesses any substantive grounds for voting against this Bill, or whether their opposition is merely politically motivated. What arguments do Opposition parties put forward in this regard? Is it possible to arrive at a resolution on women's reservation by amending or clarifying the Bill that was rejected by Parliament?



The Opposition has presented several arguments regarding this Bill, both within and outside Parliament, and the relevance of these arguments warrants examination. The 230 members of the Lok Sabha who voted against the Bill included members from the Congress, DMK, Samajwadi Party, and Trinamool Congress, among others. Opposition members-particularly those from the DMK-contend that if this Bill is passed, then in the delimitation exercise, southern states such as Tamil Nadu will lose their proportional share of seats and, therefore, representation in the Lok Sabha. This is because they have successfully controlled population growth, whereas northern states such as Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, which have experienced rapid population expansion, would gain.

To address these concerns, the government proposed a '50 per cent formula' in Parliament, under which the total number of Lok Sabha seats would increase from 543 to 850, while southern states would be allocated an additional 50 per cent of seats each, proportionate to their current strength. Under this formula, Karnataka would receive 42 seats instead of 28; Tamil Nadu, 59 instead of 39; Andhra Pradesh, 38 instead of 25; Telangana, 26 instead of 17; and Kerala, 30 instead of 20. Previously, under the chairmanship of N.K. Singh, the 15th Finance Commission had accorded weightage to parameters other than population for the allocation of financial resources, enabling these states to receive a substantial share despite smaller populations. In light of this, opposition to the Act on such grounds appears unjustified.

The Congress and other Opposition parties assert that, although they are not opposed in principle to women's reservation, linking it to delimitation and the Census is inappropriate. They argue that the Bill has inextricably tied women's reservation to a nationwide delimitation exercise-a process that, in their view, is unrelated to women's empowerment-and that this constitutes an attempt to fundamentally alter India's electoral map. However, this argument does not hold, given that the 2023 Act also explicitly linked the implementation of reservations to the Census and delimitation. The defeated Bill of 17 April 2026 merely proposed using the 2011 Census to fast-track this process. This is not the first instance of delimitation. Since 1951, delimitation has been a routine administrative exercise conducted after each

Census until 1971. In 1976, the process was frozen until 2001 and later extended to 2026 through constitutional amendments. Although a limited delimitation exercise took place between 2002 and 2008, it did not change the total number of Lok Sabha seats. With the freeze ending in 2026, a fresh delimitation exercise is now due.

Therefore, the Congress party's claim that women's reservation is being arbitrarily linked to delimitation appears untenable. Delimitation is a constitutionally mandated process, not a discretionary measure. It is a necessary procedural step; without it, effective implementation of women's reservation and broader political empowerment is difficult. The argument that the government is using this as a political pretext is also unconvincing, as delimitation would occur after the next Census regardless of this Bill.

By opposing the Bill, the Congress has only delayed the redrawing of constituencies, not prevented it. Delimitation will inevitably take place after the Census, likely by 2028. Moreover, concerns regarding changes to OBC, Dalit, and Adivasi representation lack strong grounding, as these are constitutionally protected.

Overall, the Opposition's objections appear misleading, contributing to delays in implementing women's reservation.

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BLASÉ CAPITAL

DON'T WISH TO WORK

Sometimes it is good for a nation where people do not wish to work. It is the easiest, and possibly the best way to reduce unemployment. Goad most of the people that it is not worthwhile to search for a job, and opt out of the race. Bingo! Joblessness will be down in a jiffy. In India, the jobs market is supported by the fact that a majority of women, and a sizable number of men do not want to work. They stay out and, hence, they are not included among the jobless. Only those who seek jobs actively, and do not get them, are technically and economically unemployed. If you tune out, the figures turn out better. But before you think that this is a typical emerging nation's boon, or curse, however you may see it, this happens even in the developed world. In the UK, for example, the unemployment rate was down below five per cent, "partly due to fewer students looking for work while they study."

Most experts predicted the figure to be over five per cent in the three months to February 2026. But this was not so, partly because of the reason cited earlier. More importantly, wages rose at an annual pace of 3.6 per cent, according to a media report, in the three months. On the flip side, despite the positive that the increase was higher than the inflation figure, this (wage hike) was the "weakest rate since late 2020." There seems to be a paradox. The number of job-seekers is down, and so is unemployment. Yet, the wage increases are low. This may indicate a double-blow to the economy. People are not looking for jobs because they possibly do not expect to get one, or do not get what they want or like. Yet, there are enough seekers that allow the employers to give low increments, partly due to lower inflation. Low prospects for jobs coupled with lower chances of good salaries is a killer syndrome.

Indeed, if one looks at the figures closely, the increase in the percentage of people who are not looking for work, from 20.7 per cent to 21 per cent, or 0.3 per cent, is exactly the same as the difference between the actual joblessness, 4.9 per cent, and prediction, 5.2 per cent. Experts point that these are figures until February 2026, or before the Iran war. The subsequent rise in energy prices, as also other commodities, may impact jobs in the coming months, even if the ongoing talks between the US and Iran result in a ceasefire, or extension of temporary peace. Early estimates reveal that thanks to business disruptions, 11,000 jobs were lost in the UK in March 2026. The number of job vacancies fell to their lowest levels in five years, according to a media report, "dropping to 7,11,000 for the January to March (2026) period." This may imply that employers are not looking for people, or the jobs are getting filled up quite fast. Those who are desperate are willing to pick up any jobs. Those who have a cushion, like students, do not want to work.

However, one needs to add that the UK unemployment rate, which was below four per cent in 2020, rose above five per cent in 2021, obviously due to the impact of the pandemic and business closures. It dipped again below four per cent but has picked up steadily since 2022-23 to go over five per cent, before a small dip in the December 2025-February 2026 period. More importantly, some experts feel that the current situation when the youngsters are not looking for jobs does not stem from a feeling of not needing one, but more from a state of under-confidence. It is the lack of confidence that is holding them back, which is the most important reason, followed by mental health, anxiety, and nerves. "Job searching is demoralizing," says one. The same is true with the Indian youth. Tired of not getting a job, frustrated with the jibes at homes, and from relatives and friends, the youngster simply announces that she will focus on studies, and not work. In some cases, she may say that she is not interested in work right now. There may be cases where the individuals take strategic breaks, or enter into personal tie-ups.

There is trouble brewing on the horizon. Recently, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) predicted that the UK would be hardest hit among the advanced economies due to the Iran war and oil shock. It cut the estimates for annual GDP growth from 1.3 per cent to 0.8 per cent. This is a bumper since growth had picked up before the conflict, and was faster-than-expected 0.5 per cent in February 2026. Even the lower unemployment rate was "consistent with survey evidence suggesting hiring activity was recovering before the conflict in the Middle East." The decisions by students not to seek work helped. But as is the case with growth, the trends in joblessness may be in for a reversal. Firms may scale down hiring in response to higher costs, and lower growths. Weak demand will translate into lower corporate profits. The first cuts during such times are on the jobs, and future hirings.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | WEDNESDAY | APRIL 22, 2026

BUSINESS

10

New cook takes bytes of Apple@50

Will Ternus use ingredients like innovation, vision, and design?

It is official. Three weeks after Apple turned 50, a new CEO is in place. He is not a visionary like Steve Jobs, although the outgoing Tim Cook, who will be executive chairman, describes him as one. He is not a supply chain expert like Cook. John Ternus, the new CEO-cook at Apple, who is likely to come with new recipes for apple phones (no pies), is someone with a "mind of an engineer, soul of an innovator, and heart to lead with integrity and honour." This is how Cook describes Ternus. Coming from a product-design background, the latter hopes to help Apple to "escape the iPhone's gravitational pill."

Despite Cook's success as the chief chef for 15 years, experts highlight his limits. Ternus needs to turn the firm on its head, as opposed to how Cook consolidated the empire, and bring back the excitement, awe, and experiment of the past that once defined Apple. According to a former executive, Jobs was a "visionary," and Cook was an "operations guy." But now, the firm needs a brilliant scientist, who can not only design new products, and go beyond the iPhone, but successfully embed software with hardware in the fast-changing AI world. Apple needs someone who can take risks, who can experiment without fear.

According to AI-generated search, one of the biggest challenges before Ternus is to gather speed, stop playing the catch-up game in the AI race, and race ahead of the others. Until now, critics labelled Apple as "lazy" or too cautious, relying on on-device processing while others built massive generative AI capabilities." If this strategy needs to be successful, the new CEO must "prove that its on-device AI... is superior to

cloud-based solutions." Ergo, Apple needs an integration between hardware and software, which requires someone adept in product development and design, rather than an ops-logistics-supply chain guy.

One cannot negate Cook's culinary achievements at Apple, especially what he did with money, wealth, and financial power. In 2018, the firm became the first public firm to be valued at \$1 trillion, which increased four-fold in eight years. The annual profits were up four times, even as the iPhone family captured the hearts, minds, and pockets of millions across the world, from America to Asia. He built a robust global supply chain, with a nerve nucleus in China, and then rebuilt it after the pandemic, with a dual-op structure, or India as a counter to China.

Yet, the taste of success felt a bit stale at the end of 15 years. The ingredients worked but something was amiss. Gone was the excitement, and spirit of experimentation. The designs were incremental, though each iPhone model had buyers queue up overnight. It was as if the zest was gone, as people developed and delivered variations after variations. As one expert comments, Cook could not do what Jobs did, i.e., deliver another iPhone-like product that "would give Ternus another 20 years of success." So, Ternus must start afresh, maybe with entirely new ingredients, even as he continues with the existing recipes.

Possibly, there is some sense in leaving aside the temptation to be incremental, without giving it up as it carries a momentum, and search

for the next, new growth engine. It cannot merely be rooted in a product, or design, which is what Jobs did. But Ternus has to create a new imagination, a new way of thinking, which Jobs did, but through combined and collective breakthroughs in hardware, software, and design. Apple needs new products like foldable phones and wearables. Apple needs to up the AI tempo, instead of relying on Google and OpenAI, which are integrated into the former's operating systems.

Rapid innovation is how Apple started. The strengths of discipline, polish, and control helped Cook to expand the geographical and volume reach of the recipes. Ternus possibly,

says an analyst, needs to return to the innovation space, but in a broader context. He needs to become an explorer in an uncertain world, like Jobs was. But for the latter, the world was his oyster, as there were too many spaces to fill on the tech plate. In Ternus' case, the plate is full, and overcrowded. Anything new tends to topple over, unless it displaces the existing offerings.

Maybe Ternus is the right man for the right job. As a hardware engineer, he has worked on most of the firm's products such as iPhone, iPad, Mac, AirPods, and Apple watch. His team was responsible for iPhone Air, and MacBook Neo. "While Tim Cook's tenure was defined by operational excellence, and supply chain dominance, Ternus' represents a shift-back to a product-centric leadership style," states an AI search. This is crucial as the new CEO is known for his hands-on engineering-first approach. The flip side: he cannot dump the existing ingredients, as he introduces new ones. He cannot give up on existing customers.

Once the change in CEO was announced, Apple shares went up for four dollars, and settled down by a dollar. In effect, it was up one per cent. However, the expectations are of a dip of a dollar or two in the next trading session. The fact remains that this is not an ordinary change of guards. It is not a continuation, or a seamless transition. Ternus is the new shock, a large dose of adrenaline that is being injected into Apple. This is not a small bite, or byte, as you see on the logo. It represents a big byte, which will take away a large chunk of what Apple is.

There is no evidence for it but it seems logical to assume that once several veterans felt that they were out of the CEO race, they opted out of the firm. The recent past witnessed the departure of several senior executives, which included the former COO, Jeff Williams, who was widely tipped as Cook's successor, and others who headed the AI and legal teams. Indeed, these are the teams that will prove crucial and critical for Ternus. Hence, he needs to get appropriate people, or find them within the firm. Without the right people, the products will be bereft of innovations, and software will seem soulless.

Let us not forget about the regulatory hurdles and barriers in this 100-metre sprint, and dash for the tape. In India, there is the possibility of a \$38-billion fine. In China, there are competitors propped up by the State. In the US, there is an antitrust trial.

A Contrarian Investor

Inside White House for a year

Did officials start insider trading on Trump's policy a year ago?

market platform, and they placed various bets on the possibility of a US strike on Iran by February 28, 2026. When the war was confirmed by Trump in the early hours of that day, the accounts won a combined \$1.2 million. "Five of those six users have placed no more bets since, but one of the account's recent activities showed it has subsequently made \$1,63,000 by correctly betting on a US-Iran ceasefire by April 7, 2026, which was announced by Washington and Teheran on that day," adds the report.

Let us roll back a month. Nine days after the war started, on March 9, 2026, Trump told a TV news channel that the conflict was "very complete, pretty much." In effect, he maintained that the war was over. Less than an hour before the TV channel released the comment, the number of future contracts on oil betting on lower

prices spiked by more than four times, fell again, and rose again minutes after the official announcement. Between the two spikes, oil prices slumped from \$100 a barrel to \$85, before they recovered to \$90. "The traders who placed those bets will have made millions of dollars," states the report.

Yet again, on March 23, 2026, "just two days after threatening to 'obliterate' Iran's power plants, Trump posted... that Washington had held 'very good and productive conversations' with Teheran over a 'complete and total resolution' to 'hostilities.'" In this case too, the number of futures contracts betting on lower-priced oil jumped several times minutes before the actual post, fell, and rose even more after the official post was uploaded. The futures price dropped from under \$113 to below \$100, before rising to \$104. According to an analyst,

who spoke to bbc.com, the trades appeared "abnormal for sure."

Now comes the real sting in the tail. "President Trump's son, Donald Trump Jr, is an investor in Polymarket (one of the prediction market platforms used for some of these trades), and sits on its advisory board. He also acts as a strategic advisor to Kalshi (another renowned platform for these trades)," states the news report. To cite an example, the six accounts that correctly bet on the war in Iran by February 28, 2026, were created on Polymarket. Publicly, Polymarket stated that it "sets, maintains, and enforces the highest standards of market integrity," and "proactively works with regulators."

Yet another problem area relates to prosecution. Ever since the 1980s, as financial, stocks, and derivative markets became complex, it is difficult, if not impossible to prove insider-trading charges. In most cases of conviction, evidence from insiders, whistle-blowers, and some collected through surveillance helped. In many cases, out-of-court settlement is the preferred choice. As an expert told the bbc.com, "You can have massive trades... that clearly show that someone was privy to what Donald Trump was about to declare. Yet there is a strong chance that no one will be prosecuted" for the crimes. In the US, for example, while there is a set of people that believes that these are cases of insider trading, others contend that some traders have possibly become more "adept at anticipating the president's interventions."

This explains why some senators have introduced bipartisan bills to specifically target the abuses on prediction market platforms. In addition, they wish to implicate the elected members, their families, and employees to dissuade insider-trading from within the White House, or the administration. One is not sure about the fate of these bills. However, the concrete and immediate steps taken by the US, apart from verbal and textual warnings via memos, will determine how the other nations may tackle the menace of prediction markets. In India, although they are illegal, the users easily bypass the bans. The same is true in other nations. Hopefully, the lead may be taken by Europe, which is generally forthcoming to tackle financial excesses.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

Stock markets climb nearly 1% amid hopes of Iran-US talks

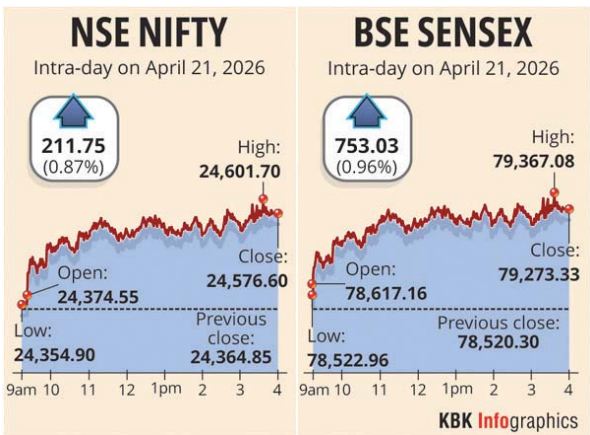
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Stock markets advanced for the third consecutive day on Tuesday, with Sensex jumping by 753 points and broader Nifty closing above 24,550 following a drop in crude oil prices and hopes for progress on peace talks between Iran and the US.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 753.03 points or 0.96 per cent to settle at 79,273.33. During the day, it surged 846.78 points or 1.07 per cent to 79,367.08.

The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 211.75 points or 0.87 per cent to end at 24,576.60.

From the 30-Sensex firms, Trent, Hindustan Unilever, ICI Bank, Bajaj Finance, HDFC Bank and Axis Bank were among the major



winners. Bharat Electronics, Titan, Reliance Industries and NTPC were among the laggards. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, traded 0.75 per cent lower at \$94.76 per barrel.

“Indian equity markets

traded on a positive note, as investors positioned for a potential near-term de-escalation in the Middle East. Energy markets remained in a consolidation phase, as traders balanced hopes of a near-term resolution and a

potential reopening of the Strait of Hormuz against ongoing uncertainty around ceasefire negotiations,” Ponnudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

In Asian markets, South Korea's benchmark Kospi, Japan's Nikkei 225 index, Shanghai's SSE Composite index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index ended higher.

Markets in Europe were trading in positive territory. US markets ended marginally lower on Monday.

The bullish momentum was largely driven by a combination of macro and market-specific triggers. Easing geopolitical concerns, particularly around the US-Iran situation, played a central role in improving risk appetite.

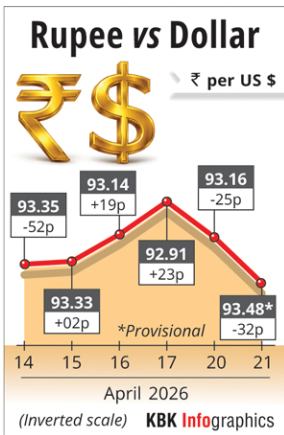
Rupee plunges 32 paise to settle at 93.48 against US dollar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The rupee declined 32 paise to close at 93.48 (provisional) against the US dollar on Tuesday, weighed down by a steady American currency and volatile crude oil prices amid uncertainties over the progress of West Asia peace negotiations.

Positive domestic equity markets failed to boost local currency, which also had some impact of the Reserve Bank's latest move to ease curbs on speculative bets in non-deliverable forward markets, forex analysts said. The Reserve Bank on Monday partially withdrew directives taken on April 1 to curb excessive speculation in the rupee.

The banking regulator had capped the net open positions in non-deliverable forward markets at \$100 million, mandating banks to comply by April 10.



Under revised directives, authorised dealers or banks can resume offering non-deliverable derivative contracts involving INR to resident or non-resident users, but must comply with certain restrictions on related-party transactions. Also, the \$100-million cap in net open position is still effective.

At the interbank foreign

exchange market, the rupee opened at 93.25 and fell to an intra-day low of 93.63 before ending the session 32 paise lower at 93.48 (provisional) against the greenback.

On Monday, the rupee settled with a loss of 25 paise at 93.16 against the US dollar. The currency had gained 47 paise in the preceding two sessions.

Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst at Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said the rupee fell on uncertainty over US-Iran talks and a surge in crude oil prices. A strong dollar also pressured the rupee; however, positive global markets cushioned the downside.

“Traders may take cues from retail sales and ADP employment change data from the US. USD-INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of ₹93.30 to ₹93.90,” Choudhary said.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the

greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, rose 0.19 per cent to 98.09. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading 0.70 per cent down at \$94.81 per barrel in futures trade.

Analysts attributed the volatility in crude prices to persistent worries over disruptions of supplies of oil from the Strait of Hormuz. Also, the ceasefire agreement between the United States and Iran is scheduled to expire on Wednesday.

In a latest development, Iran's chief negotiator on Tuesday said Tehran would not negotiate in the face of threats, while US President Donald Trump hinted that he was in no rush to end the conflict with Iran.

In the domestic equity markets the 30-share Sensex rose 753.03 points, or 0.96 per cent, to settle at 79,273.33, while the Nifty rose 211.75 points, or 0.87 per cent, to 24,576.60.

India should aim to achieve 100% ethanol blending: Nitin Gadkari

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari on Tuesday said India should aspire to achieve 100 per cent ethanol blending in the near future, as vulnerabilities in oil exports amid the West Asia crisis have made it necessary for the country to become self-reliant in the energy sector.

Gadkari further said the Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency III standards, which will be implemented from April 1 next year, will have little impact on electric and flex-fuel vehicles. “In the near future, India should aspire to achieve 100 per cent ethanol

blending... Today, we are facing an energy crisis due to the war in West Asia, so it is necessary for us to become self-reliant in the energy sector,” he said, while addressing the Indian Federation of Green Energy's Green Transport Conclave.

In 2023, Prime Minister Narendra Modi launched petrol blended with 20 per cent ethanol.

Currently, Indian vehicles can run on E20 petrol with minor changes to the engine to prevent corrosion and other issues. Countries like Brazil have 100 per cent ethanol blending.

Gadkari said India relies on imports to meet 87 per cent of its oil requirement. “We import fossil fuels worth ₹22 lakh crore, which is also causing



pollution... so we need to work on increasing production of alternative fuel and bio-fuel,” he said.

Noting that green hydrogen is the

fuel of the future, Gadkari said there is a need to reduce the cost of running a hydrogen fuel station to make it financially viable.

“Transport of hydrogen fuel is a problem. Also, we need to produce 1 kg of hydrogen at \$1 dollar, to make India an exporter of energy,” he said. The minister said that there is a need to produce hydrogen from waste.

He also pointed out that by focusing on the circular economy, India can create more employment opportunities. While observing that there is a need to discourage the use of petrol and diesel vehicles, Gadkari said, “But we can not force people to stop buying petrol and diesel vehicles.”

High foreign ownership positive for Indian financial institutions: Fitch

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Fitch Ratings on Tuesday said significant ownership by foreign shareholders can be positive for Indian financial institutions' credit profiles through long-term capital, as well as lifting of governance standards in some cases.

However, foreign interest is not in itself a reliable signal of stronger credit fundamentals.

Transactions that strengthen internal controls, risk management and leadership accountability can be more credit-relevant than those purely for financial gains, it noted.

Fitch said recent greater interest from foreign investors indicates their rising confidence in India's long-term growth prospects, the financial sector's regulations and oversight, and improved risk governance.

Fitch believes investors will seek platforms with scalable distribution and local expertise.

“Acquirors with experience in developed markets may introduce enhancements in risk controls and board oversight,” it said, adding that the presence of reputable strategic shareholders can potentially ease its cost of capital.

These factors can contribute towards strength-



ening the financial's institutions' standalone credit profile.

“Significant ownership by foreign shareholders can be positive for Indian financial institutions' credit profiles through long-term capital and funding flexibility, business franchise enhancement, as well as lifting of governance standards in some cases,” Fitch said in a statement.

Bain Capital's partial acquisition of Manappuram Finance in 2026 gives it joint control and the right to nominate two board directors and key management personnel, which could support Manappuram's management, governance and business profile.

However, any impact on the credit profile will take time to materialise and be subject to execution risk, Fitch said.

Fitch believes there is more scope for foreign shareholders to gain control of non-bank financial institutions (NBFIs) than banks, as regulations allow up to full foreign ownership of NBFIs.

BEML secures ₹590 crore order from defence ministry

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

State-owned BEML on Tuesday announced securing a new order worth ₹590 crore for the supply of trawl assemblies to the Indian Army. In this regard, a formal contract agreement was signed between senior officials of the Ministry of Defence and BEML Ltd in the national capital on Tuesday, the company said in a statement.

“In a significant boost to India's defence preparedness and indigenous manufacturing capabilities, the Ministry of Defence, Government of India, has awarded a ₹590 crore contract to BEML Limited for the supply of trawl assemblies for deployment on the Indian Army's T-72 and T-90 tanks,” the statement said.

Equipped with multi-layered clearing



mechanisms, these trawl systems will significantly enhance the operational effectiveness of the armed forces in combat zones by creating safe passage, thereby enhancing the mobility, survivability, and operational momentum of mechanised forces and offering a decisive advantage in modern battlefield environments, BEML said.

Oil Ministry team probes Rajasthan refinery fire

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A four-member team constituted by India's oil ministry is in Rajasthan to investigate a fire at a refinery, even as HPCL said the incident is not expected to have a material financial or operational impact, and that all units are structurally safe with no effect on other sections.

The fire broke out on April 20 at the refinery of HPCL Rajasthan Refinery Limited, a day before it was to be inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The fire in the crude distillation unit — the main unit of a refinery — was likely caused by a hydrocarbon leak from a valve or flange in a heat

exchanger circuit, Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) said.

The blaze was confined to the heat exchanger stack and was quickly brought under control by the site's emergency response team. There were no casualties or injuries.

The crude distillation unit, vacuum distillation unit and associated sections were isolated as a precaution.

The scheduled April 21 dedication of the refinery has been postponed, with a revised date to be announced.

Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, said the team led by former MRPL managing director M



Venkatesh has been tasked to investigate the cause of the incident.

“The team has reached Barmer,” she told reporters, adding that the delays, if any, in the commissioning timelines will be known once the investigating team completes its probe.

“An unfortunate accident occurred (on Monday) at around 1.55 pm at HPCL Rajasthan Refinery Ltd (HRRL) at Pachpadra, Balotra. There was a fire in the Crude Distillation Unit (CDU) section of the refinery complex. Prima facie, it appears that leakage of

hydrocarbons through one of the valves/flanges in the heat exchanger circuit caused the fire,” HPCL said.

The fire was promptly brought under control by the emergency response team of HRRL with support from the local administration.

There is no loss of life or injury to any personnel, it said, adding the fire was localised in the heat exchangers stack.

Crude Distillation Unit (CDU), Vacuum Distillation Unit (VDU), and all other units of the CDU section were quickly isolated. All are structurally safe and unaffected. “No other section of the refinery has suffered any impact.”

South Korean steel major Posco set to return to Odisha after two decades: Government

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bhubaneswar

Over two decades after leaving a mega project in Odisha following large-scale unrest by local people, South Korean steel major Posco is all set to return to the state and set up a greenfield plant in collaboration with JSW Group.

This was announced by Additional Chief Secretary, Industries, Hemant Sharma, here.

“We are very happy to announce that Posco is returning to Odisha. An agreement in this regard was signed on Monday during the South Korean President's visit to India,” Sharma told reporters here.

Posco, which had planned to set up a mega steel mill of 12mtpa at an investment of ₹51,000 near Paradip in Jagatsinghpur district in early 2000, had



to abandon it in the face of stiff opposition by local people during the land acquisition process.

Apart from this, the company also failed to get a raw material linkage following a change of mineral policy in the country. Sharma said they have shown interest in setting up two major Greenfield projects in Odisha, one a 6 mtpa plant in Keonjhar district and

another a 5 mtpa capacity steel mill in Dhenkanal district.

“Though the state government has 1,000 acres of land for the purpose, it may arrange more if required. The state will provide all logistics to Posco to set up its proposed plants in Odisha,” Sharma said. In a major boost to Odisha's industrial landscape, JSW Group has announced a significant investment in the state in partnership with the South Korean steel giant.

The two companies have signed a joint venture agreement to establish a mega steel plant in Dhenkanal district.

Sources said the agreement in this regard was signed at the India-Korea Business Summit held in New Delhi on Monday, in the presence of Union Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal, JSW Group Chairman Sajjan Jindal, and Posco Chairman Chang In-hwa.

Surat tops India in active investors

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Gujarat continues to strengthen its reputation as a powerhouse of trade and equity market participation, with cities like Surat and Ahmedabad leading the surge in retail investing activity across India.

According to the latest report by the National Stock Exchange (NSE), Surat has secured the top position nationwide in terms of growth in active equity investors as well as their turnover. Ahmedabad follows closely, ranking second in active investor count and third in overall retail trading turnover, behind Mumbai Suburban and Bengaluru.

The report highlights a



remarkable expansion in Gujarat's retail investor base over the past decade. The number of active equity investors in the state has increased nearly eightfold from 6.1 lakh at the end of FY2016 to 46.1 lakh by FY2026.

During the same period, equity turnover surged almost six times, rising from ₹3.5 lakh crore to ₹18.5 lakh

crore, reflecting a sharp rise in retail trading participation.

Ahmedabad has emerged as a major retail trading centre, with turnover growing from ₹1.3 lakh crore in FY2016 to ₹6.1 lakh crore in FY2026, making it the third-largest in the country. Meanwhile, Surat has recorded the fastest growth in stock trading activity, with turnover crossing ₹3.3 lakh crore in FY2026. The city also witnessed an 11-fold jump in active investors, reaching 7.6 lakh during the fiscal year.

The findings underscore Gujarat's growing dominance in India's retail equity market, driven by increasing investor awareness, digital access, and a strong culture of financial participation.



at that level until early February 2026.

On February 20, the US Supreme Court ruling invalidated the entire framework of Trump tariffs, making the tariffs legally void and triggering refunds, it said.

About 53 per cent of India's exports to the US, mainly textiles and apparel, faced these high tariffs, making them the biggest contributors to refunds.

“Of the estimated \$12 billion linked to India, textiles and apparel may account for about \$4 billion, engineering goods another \$4 billion, and chemicals about \$2 billion, with smaller shares from other sectors,” GTRI Founder Ajay Srivastava said.

He said Indian exporters will not get refunds automatically and payments go only to US importers, and exporters have no legal right

to claim them. “Any recovery will depend on commercial negotiation. For this, Indian exporters should proactively engage US buyers to seek a share of refunded duties, especially where earlier contracts were priced on a duty-paid basis,” he said.

To benefit, Indian exporters must negotiate with US buyers, Srivastava said, adding they should seek a share of refunds where earlier prices included tariff costs.

“This can be done by reopening contracts, adding rebate-sharing clauses, asking for price revisions or credit notes, and using invoices and tariff data to show how costs were absorbed. Exporters with stronger bargaining power, especially in textiles and engineering goods, may secure better terms in future orders,” he added.

CERC proposes Grid India as market coupling operator



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Power regulator CERC has proposed that Grid Controller of India Ltd (Grid India) function as market coupling operator (MCO), in a bid to establish uniform price discovery across all power exchanges.

As a Market Coupling Operator, Grid India will be responsible for aggregating bids for each market segment received across all Power Exchanges and ensuring an efficient price discovery.

CERC brought out the draft Central Electricity Regulatory Commission (Power Market) (Second Amendment) Regulations, 2026, earlier this month.

For the implementation of Market Coupling, Grid India will form a separate cell for discharging the functions of MCO.

Market Coupling shall apply to the Day-Ahead Market (DAM), Real-Time Market (RTM) and other market segments, as proposed in the draft.

It proposed that all power Exchanges shall collect bids in a uniform bid format from market participants in accordance with the procedure and format stipulated in the Power Market Coupling Procedure (PMCP).

Mandelson’s US envoy approval faced political push: Ex-official

JILL LAWLESS
■ London

The ex-civil servant behind the decision to approve Peter Mandelson's appointment as British ambassador to Washington says he felt political pressure to rush through the appointment despite security concerns.

Olly Robbins, former head of the Foreign Office, said those concerns did not relate to Mandelson's relationship with the sex offender Jeffrey Epstein. He declined to say when questioned by lawmakers what led the government's vetting agency to flag Mandelson as a potential security risk.

Robbins said the vetting agency considered Mandelson a "borderline case" and was "leaning toward recommending against" giving him security clearance.

The Foreign Office decided to clear him anyway. Robbins was fired by Prime Minister Keir Starmer last week over the decision. Starmer is facing questions about his own judgment, and calls to resign, over the appointment.

Robbins told the House of Commons Foreign Affairs Committee on Tuesday that there was an "atmosphere of pressure" coming from Starmer's office.

He said there was "a very, very strong expectation" that



Mandelson "needed to be in post and in America as quickly as possible."

Robbins said there was "a generally dismissive attitude" to the security vetting in January 2025, before Mandelson went to Washington. Starmer acknowledged on Monday that he made the wrong judgment when he picked Mandelson for the job.

But he said he would have withdrawn the appointment if he'd known about the security vetting. Starmer has placed blame squarely on Foreign Office officials, who he said failed to tell him about the security concerns and approved Mandelson's appointment despite them.

He called it "frankly staggering" that officials didn't tell him about the failed vetting, which took place in January

2025. Starmer says he only found out last week.

Starmer fired Mandelson in September, nine months into the job, when new details emerged about his friendship with Epstein, a convicted sex offender who died in prison in 2019. He has ordered a review into any security concerns arising from Mandelson's access to sensitive information while ambassador. Critics say the Mandelson appointment is more evidence of bad judgment by a prime minister who has made repeated missteps since he led Labour to a landslide election victory in July 2024. He picked Mandelson as ambassador despite being warned by his staff that Mandelson's friendship with Epstein exposed the Government to "reputational risk." Mandelson's business links to Russia and China also

set off alarm bells. But his expertise as a former European Union trade chief and contacts among global elites were considered assets in dealing with U.S. President Donald Trump's administration. The scandal has caused gloom among lawmakers in Starmer's center-left Labour Party, already anxious about its dire poll ratings. Starmer already defused one potential crisis in February, when some Labour lawmakers urged him to resign over the Mandelson appointment.

Mandelson is under police investigation for suspected misconduct in public office after a trove of Epstein-related documents released by the US Department of Justice in January included emails suggesting Mandelson had passed on sensitive — and potentially market-moving Government information to Epstein in 2009, after the global financial crisis. British police launched a criminal probe and arrested Mandelson in February.

Mandelson has previously denied wrongdoing and hasn't been charged. He does not face allegations of sexual misconduct. (AP)

New Zealand PM survives leadership vote

CHARLOTTE GRAHAM-MCLAY
■ Wellington

New Zealand Prime Minister Christopher Luxon said Tuesday that he had survived a vote on his leadership among his own party's lawmakers, after recent slumps in the polls prompted speculation he might be ousted.

The vote was held behind closed doors during a routine meeting of Luxon's centre-right National Party lawmakers and was sought by the Prime Minister himself. Luxon emerged afterwards to read a brief statement announcing the vote and departed without taking questions from reporters. "Last week, there has been intense media speculation about my leadership," Luxon said, adding that he had called for a confidence vote "to put that media speculation to rest."

His party caucus had "answered clearly and decisively," the Prime Minister said. "It has backed my leadership." He did not say that the vote had been unanimous. Nicola Willis, the party's deputy leader, said



New Zealand Prime Minister Christopher Luxon speaking to reporters at Parliament in Wellington, New Zealand AP

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Gunman shoots tourists at pyramids in Mexico; 1 killed

FABIOLA SANCHEZ/
MEGAN JANETSKY
■ Mexico City

An armed man standing atop one of the historic Teotihuacan pyramids opened fire on tourists, killing one Canadian and leaving at least 13 people injured at the archaeological site north of Mexico's capital, authorities said.

The shooter later died from a self-inflicted gunshot wound, authorities said, and security officials found a gun, a knife and ammunition. The local Government said seven people were wounded by gunshots on Monday. How the other people were injured was not disclosed, but those taken to hospitals for treatment were six Americans, three Colombians, one Russian, two Brazilians and one Canadian, the local Government said.



Video and photos published by local media showed a man standing with a gun on top of a pyramid while people ducked for cover. A number of gunshots rang out in the videos. The shooting took place shortly after 11.30 am when dozens of tourists were at the top of the Pyramid of the Moon.

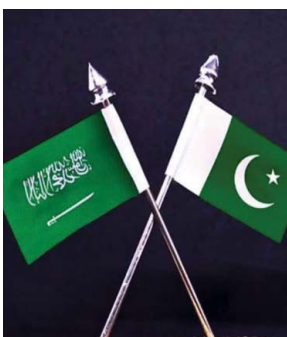
A man standing on the tourists' platform began firing upward, according to a tour guide who was at the

scene and spoke to The Associated Press on condition of anonymity for safety reasons. "Some people, because they were scared ... threw themselves face down on the ground, and the rest of us started to go down," the guide said, recounting how the shooter, upon seeing the tourists descending the pyramid's steps, began firing. Another group of visitors lay motionless on the pyramid's platform to avoid being targeted by the shooter, who authorities have not yet identified. Brenda Lee, of Vancouver, British Columbia, said she was waiting to buy a souvenir when she and others in her group thought they heard firecrackers. (AP)

later Tuesday that the vote had been a secret ballot with only scrutineers knowing the final tally, but that Luxon must have received a majority. The confidence vote happened months ahead of New Zealand's next national election, scheduled for November 7. Recent drops in the polls for National had prompted speculation from analysts that he would face a leadership challenge.

That was seen by party lawmakers as an unwelcome distraction in an election year for National, which has governed New Zealand in a right-wing coalition Government since the 2023 vote. Luxon, a former airline executive who entered Parliament in 2000, has led the party since 2021. (AP)

Pak receives second tranche of \$1 billion loan from Saudi



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Karachi

Pakistan has received the second and final tranche of \$1 billion from Saudi Arabia, as part of a \$3 billion aid package aimed at boosting its foreign reserves, the state bank said on Tuesday.

Last week, Saudi Arabia pledged \$3 billion in deposits for Pakistan and extended its existing \$5 billion facility for a further three years. The State Bank of Pakistan (SBP) confirmed through a social media post that it has received the second tranche from Saudi Arabia, completing the \$3 billion transaction after it received \$2 billion last week. "State Bank of Pakistan has received funds of \$1 billion from Ministry of Finance, Kingdom of Saudi Arabia in the value date of 20 April 2026," the bank said.

ARMY PUBLIC SCHOOL, SRINAGAR BB, CANTT, BATWARA (J&K)- 190004 Website: www.apssrinagar.co.in

TENDER NOTICE

- Chairman APS, Srinagar invites sealed quotations from experienced vendors for supplying of Exam Cell stationery and other items to APS, Srinagar.
- Interested parties may visit the school website to check the list of stationery and other items required to school.
- Please submit your quotations by or before 28 Apr 2026. For any query contact during all working days between 10.00 A.M. to 03.00 P.M at 0194-2468224.

Sd/- Principal

	INDRAPRASTHA POWER GENERATION CO. LTD. & PRAGATI POWER CORPORATION LIMITED (Govt. of NCT of Delhi Undertakings) Corporate Identity No. (CIN)-IPGCL-U40103DL20001SGC111530 Corporate Identity No. (CIN)-PPCL-U74899DL20001SGC109135 (ISO 9001-2008. 14001- 2007,18001-2007 Certified Stations) ED(C&M), Pragati Power Station-I, I.P. Estate, Ring Road, New Delhi-110002. TEL: 011-23370541, FAX NO. 011 23379164
	NIT No. 08/2025-26 TENDERING FOR ONLINE BIDDING Date: 02/03/2026

Offers are invited in two parts system on e-tendering on the portal of Delhi Govt, at <https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in> , for the below items with tender closing time at 11.00 hrs. on bid submission date: -

	Tender ID & Description	T-Value (Rs.)
01	2026_IPGCL_286058 Urgent Comprehensive Civil Repair and Rehabilitation of Cooling Tower at PPS-III, Bawana based on NCCBM Report and BOQ	8,10,28,499.70
02	2025_IPGCL_275695_2 Annual contract for maintenance of water retaining structure and cooling tower#2 at PPS- III Bawana	49,08,888.14
03	2026_IPGCL_286891 Maintenance contract for horticulture works at Pragati Power Station-III, CISF colony & nursery maintenance works at PPS-III Bawana	48,03,936 .45
04	2026_IPGCL_287386 Paving work at different location of unpaved area at PPS-III .	1,20,72,261.33

Corrigendum / Retender

01	2025_IPGCL_281659_1 Implementation "Automatic Generation Control" on 4 Gas Turbine Generators of 1500MW PPS-III Bawana	3,44,00,000.00
02	2025_IPGCL_281613_1 Rate contract for C & I maintenance at PPS-I for a period of 2 Years	72,84,755.04

Note: 1) Tender Issue Date & EMD details: - Please visit IPGCL-PPCL website (www.ipgcl-ppcl.gov.in)
2) Bid Submission End Date & Bid Opening Date : As per IPGCL-PPCL website and Delhi Govt e-portal
3) No Corrigendum/addendum/modification for tender value up to Rs 50.00 Lacs will be advertised in newspaper and bidders are requested to regularly visit IPGCL-PPCL website as well as Delhi Government E-procurement site for getting themselves updated.

DIP/Shabdarth/Classified/0029/2627

AXIS BANK LTD. Retail Asset Centre, Axis Bank Lt. Axis House, Tower T-2, 2nd Floor, I-14, Sector-128, Noida Expressway, Jaypee Greens Wishtown, Noida (U.P.)-201301.	
Retail asset Centre, Axis Bank Ltd. BF 1A, 2 3 First Floor, Aditya City Centre, Vaibhav Khand-3, Indraprastha, Gurgaon, Haryana - 122007, 2. Axis Bank Limited, Upper Ground Floor and first floor, Kasturba Gandhi Marg, Connaught Place, New Delhi - 110001 Corporate Office: Block-B, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhakar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400 025, Registered Office: "Triumph", 3rd floor, opposite Samartheswar Temple, Law Garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006	
DEMAND NOTICE Whereas the borrowers/co-borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors mentioned hereunder had availed the financial assistance from Axis Bank Ltd. We state that despite having availed the financial assistance the borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors have committed various defaults in repayment of interest and principal amounts as per due dates. The account has been classified as Non Performing Asset on the respective dates mentioned hereunder in accordance with the directives/guidelines issued by Reserve Bank of India, consequent to the Authorized Officer of the said borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors in the Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 & in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued Demand Notices on respective dates mentioned herein below under Section 13(2) of SARFAESI Act, 2002, calling upon the following borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors to repay the amount mentioned in the notices together with further interest at the contractual rate of interest mentioned in the notices and incidental expenses, cost, charges etc until the date of payment within 60 days from the date of receipt of notices. The notices issued to them on their last known addresses and they are also hereby informed by way of public notice about the same.	
Sr. No.	Name Of The Borrower / Address / Co-Borrower And Guarantor Name
1	1. M/s. Krafters Telecomservices Pvt. Ltd., G-44, Sec-14, Old DLF Colony, Gurgaon, Haryana - 122007; 2. Mrs. Sangeta Sahni, W/o Mr. Jagpreet Singh Sahni, H. No. 752, Sec-15, Part-2, Gurgaon, Haryana - 122001; 3. Mr. Jagpreet Singh Sahni, S/O Dr. I.S. Sahni, H. No. 752, Sec-15, Part-2, Gurgaon, Haryana - 122001; 4. Mr. Kabir Jai-Preet Sahni, H. No. 752, Sec-15, Part-2, Gurgaon, Haryana - 122001
Property Address Of Secured Assets: -All That Piece And Parcel Of Built-Up Property Bearing Plot No. 752, Situated In The Residential Colony Known As Sector-15, Part-II, Urban Estate Gurgaon, Haryana And Bounded As Under: East - As Per Title Deed; West - As Per Title Deed; North - As Per Title Deed; South - As Per Title Deed	
2	1. Mr. Vinod Kumar, S/o Mr. Chandan Lal, A-5, H. No. 43, Pocket-5, Sector-15, Rohini, Delhi - 110089; 2. Mr. Vinod Kumar, S/O Mr. AVM Services, 304, 3rd Floor, Harsha House Commercial Complex, Karampura, New Delhi - 110015
Property Address Of Secured Assets: -MIG Flat Bearing No. 48, P.K.T.GH-14/G-17, On Third Floor With Roof/Terrace Rights, Situated At Paschim Vihar, New Delhi And Bounded As Under: East - As Per Title Deed; West - As Per Title Deed; North - As Per Title Deed; South - As Per Title Deed	
3	1. Mr. Jag Mohan, R/o 4193, Gali Barna, Pahari Dhira, Sadar Bazar, Delhi - 110006; Also At - Mr. Jag Mohan, R/o 5443, New Market, Sadar Bazar, Delhi - 110006; Also At - Mr. Jag Mohan, Property No. 7, Ground Floor, Sainik Vihar, Pitampura, Delhi - 110084
Property Address Of Secured Assets: -Property Bearing No. 7, Ground Floor, Shown In The Layout Plan Delhi Sainik Co-Op Housing Building Society Ltd., Presently Known As Sainik Vihar, Pitam Vihar, Delhi And Bounded As Under: East - As Per Title Deed; West - As Per Title Deed; North - As Per Title Deed; South - As Per Title Deed	
4	1. Mr. Surinder Singh Thakur, S/o Mr. Balam Singh Thakur, R/o H. No. 113, Anand Vihar, Pitampura, Saraswati Vihar, Delhi - 110034; Also At - Mr. Surinder Singh Thakur, Vijay Laxmi Associates, 522, Aggarwal Prestige Mall, Plot No. 2, Road-44, Pitampura, Delhi - 110034; 2. Mrs. Renu Thakur, W/o Mr. Surinder Singh Thakur, R/o H. No. 113, Anand Vihar, Pitampura, Saraswati Vihar, Delhi - 110034
Property Address Of Secured Assets: -H. No. 113, Anand Vihar, Pitampura, Delhi - 110034 And Bounded As Under: East - As Per Title Deed; West - As Per Title Deed; North - As Per Title Deed; South - As Per Title Deed	
5	1. M/s. Hinde Plast Pvt. Ltd., C-112, Okhla Industrial Area, Phase-1, Delhi - 110020 (Applicant); 2. Mr. Rajdeep Singh Tuteja, S/o Mr. Balbir Singh Tuteja, H. No. 7/20, South Patel Nagar, Delhi - 110008 (Co-Applicant); 3. Mr. Balbir Singh, H. No. 7/20, South Patel Nagar, Delhi - 110008 (Co-Applicant)
Property Address Of Secured Assets: -Plot: 20, Basement, Ground Floor, 1st Floor And 3rd Floor, Block-7, South Patel Nagar, New Delhi - 110008, And Bounded As Under: East - As Per Title Deed; West - As Per Title Deed; North - As Per Title Deed; South - As Per Title Deed	
6	1. Mrs. Kulsom Siddiqui, W/o Mr. Shabbir Salam, Flat No. A3/1901, Tower 8, 19th Floor, Purvanchal Royal Park, Opposite World One Sector-137, Noida, Asdullapur, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh - 201305; Also At - Mrs. Kulsom Siddiqui, Heads Globe Pvt. Ltd., B-152, Trinity Tower, DLF Phase-V, Gurgaon, Haryana - 122002; 2. Mrs. Kulsom Siddiqui, W/o Late Mr. Abdus Salam, Flat No. A3/1901, Tower 8, 19th Floor, Purvanchal Royal Park, Sector-137, Noida, Asdullapur, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh - 201305; Also At - Mrs. Kulsom Siddiqui, D-17, Okhla Vihar, Jamiya Nagar, New Delhi - 110025
Property Address Of Secured Assets: -Property Bearing Flat No. A3/1901 On 19th Floor, In Tower-08, Purvanchal Royal Park, At Plot No. GH-04, Sector-137, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh - 201305 And Bounded As Under: East - As Per Title Deed; West - As Per Title Deed; North - As Per Title Deed; South - As Per Title Deed	
In the circumstances as aforesaid, the notice is hereby given to the above borrowers, co-borrowers and/or their guarantors (wherever applicable) to pay the outstanding dues as mentioned above along with future interest and applicable charges within 60 days from the date of the publication of this notice failing which further steps will be taken after the expiry of 60 days of the date of this notice against the secured assets including taking possession of the secured assets of the borrowers and the mortgagors under Section 13(4) of Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and the applicable rules thereunder. Kind attention is invited to provisions of sub-Section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act, 2002 where under you can tender the entire amount of outstanding dues together with all costs, charges and expenses incurred by the Bank only till the date of publication of the notice for sale of the secured asset(s) by public auction, by inviting quotations, tender from public or by private treaty. Please also note that if the entire amount of outstanding dues together with the costs, charges and expenses incurred by the Bank is not tendered before publication of notice for sale of the secured assets by public auction, by inviting quotations, tender from public or by private treaty, you may not be entitled to redeem the secured asset(s). Please note that under Section 13 (13) of the said Act, no borrower shall, transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise any of his secured assets referred to in the notice, without prior written consent of the secured creditor.	
Date: 22.04.2026, Place: Noida U.P	
Sd/-, Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.	

The Pioneer Classified CHANGE OF NAME

I, Laxmi Kant Agarwal S/O Rama Shankar Agrawal R/O 7-ORH, Officers rest House, State Entry Road,Connaught Palace, New Delhi, have changed my name to Laxmi Kant Bansal for future.

PD(924)C
I, hitherto known as Dhirendra Kumar Mishra S/o Subodh Kumar Mishra R/o A-180, Kirari Village, Suleman Nagar, North West Delhi-110086 have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Swtantra Mishra.

PD(925)C
I, Animireddi Vasanthi, W/o No.14852159X Hav Animireddi Siva, R/o-Vill-Sudivalasa, Post- Pathavalasa, Teh- K. Kotapad, Dist-Visakhapatnam, A.P- 535183, have changed my name from Animireddi Vasanthi to Sabbavarapu Vasanthi, vide affidavit dated 21/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(926)C
I, Rashmita Parida, W/o-Army No.14852406A Hav/Clk (SD) Pitambar Mahanty, R/o-Vill- Gunasagar, Post- J.B. Pur, PS- Pattapur, Teh-Sanakhemundi, Dist-Ganjam, Odisha- 761013, have changed my name from Rashmita Parida to Rashmita Mahanty, vide affidavit dated 21/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(927)C
I, No.15439764P NK/NA Kiriti Prakash Bajpai, R/o- Vill-Kanta Karundi, PO- Meerkh Nagar, Teh- Mohanlalganj Dist- Lucknow, U.P.- 226302, declare that my mother's name is wrongly mentioned in my service record as Pushpa Bajpai whereas her correct name is Pushpa Devi which may be amended accordingly.

PD(928)C
I, No.170372723L Nk Bulu Pradhan, R/o- Brahman Chhai, Pital, PS- Hinjilji, Dist-Ganjam, Odisha- 761103, have changed my Daughter's name from Baishnavi to Baishnavi Bulu Pradhan, vide affidavit dated 21/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(929)C

NEW OKHLA INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY noida Main Administrative Building, Sector-6, Noida, G.B. Nagar (U.P.) Website : www.noidaauthorityonline.in

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tenders are invited from firms/contractors registered with UPLC Lucknow for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <https://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/ amendments & corrigendum etc.

(A)	
(1)	01/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27, SITC of Transformer and Street Light pole Newly Developed Shopping Complex at Express view Apartment Sector-93, Noida. Cost Rs. 36.82 Lacs.
(2)	02/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27, Providing Street Light arrangement in Newly Developed Park in Sector- 93 SK-I, & 93 SK-II Noida. Cost Rs. 44.42 Lacs.
(3)	03/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27, Shifting of 2 Nos Transformer with LT Line from in Sector-110 market & strengthening of street light poles around Market. Cost Rs. 81.40 Lacs.
(4)	02/GM/AO/Sr. M.(E&M)-II/2026-27/ET, Strengthening of Street Lights, Height mast lights & Park lights in Sector-11, 12 & Vill-Jhundpura, Noida. Cost Rs. 96.19 Lacs.
(5)	03/GM (E&M)/S.M./E/M-III/26-27, Annual Operation, Maintenance & Repairing of fountain in sector-28, 29, 31, 37 (05 Nos.), Noida. Cost Rs. 35.73 Lacs.
(6)	11/GM(E&M)/S.M./E/M-III/26-27, Strengthening of Street Light in Dhawalgiri (B- 5) Apartment Sector 34 & D-1 Arawali Apartment Sector 52, Noida. Cost Rs. 76.04 Lacs.
(7)	12/GM(E&M)/S.M./E/M-III/26-27, Providing Light arrangement around Medanta Hospital F-Block, Sector-50 & Strengthening of Street Light arrangement in Central Market, Sector-50, Noida. Cost Rs. 73.59 Lacs.

Which can be uploaded by date:- 05.05.2026 upto 5.00 PM. Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on date:- 06.05.2026 at 11.00 AM.

(B)	
(1)	25/GM/AO/Sr.M.(E&M)-II/2025-26/ET, Strengthening of Traffic Signals (05 Nos) at 4-Way Junction in various Locations, Noida. Cost Rs. 48.25 Lacs.
(2)	19/GM (E&M)/S.M./E/M- III/25-26, M/o Authority Building (AMC of different type of Air Conditioner installed in different offices in Main Administrative Building, Sector-6, Noida. Cost Rs. 50.62 Lacs.
(3)	33/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2025-26, Annual operation and maintenance of 3-D projection mapping of Gautam Buddha Statue at Noida Gate Sec 14 A, Noida. Cost Rs.31.61 Lacs.

Which can be uploaded by date:- 28.04.2026 upto 5.00 PM. Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on date:- 29.04.2026 at 11.00 AM.

General Manager (E&M)
NOIDA

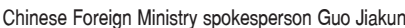
CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA

Queen Elizabeth I

Pope Leo pays tribute to Francis

Pope Leo XIV paid tribute to Pope Francis on Tuesday on the first anniversary of his death, recalling his preaching about God's mercy and his gestures of solidarity with poor people. "We thank the Lord for the great gift of the life of Francis, to the church and the world," Leo said. The American pope delivered the tribute in Italian while speaking with reporters aboard the papal plane heading from Angola to Equatorial Guinea. Francis died on Easter on Monday last year after suffering a stroke. He had been at the Vatican recovering from a five-week hospital stay for double pneumonia. His death, at 88, set the stage for the conclave that elected Leo a few weeks later. It was an outcome for which Francis had laid the groundwork by promoting the former missionary priest, Robert Prevost, whom he considered "a saint."

"The 'aggressor United States,' by violating the ceasefire and engaging in maritime highway robbery, attacked an Iranian commercial vessel in the waters of the Sea of Oman," *CNN* quoted Iran's military as saying. The Iranian military said that the



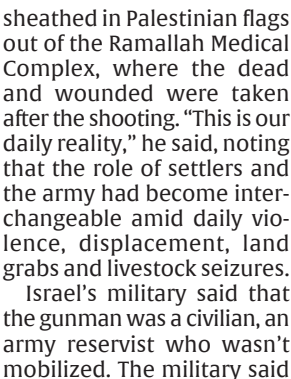
Also, a CNN report earlier

announcement comes hours ahead of the expiration of an already tenuous ceasefire between the US and Iran, and as Pakistan attempts to broker talks between Washington and Tehran. Ship-tracking data showed the Tifani was carrying oil in the Indian Ocean on Tuesday between Sri Lanka and Indonesia. The Pentagon described the Tifani as "stateless" despite it being a Botswana-flagged vessel. The announcement did not say precisely where or what time on Tuesday the ship was boarded.

this month said US intelligence indicates that China is preparing to deliver new air defence systems to Iran, including shoulder-fired anti-air missile systems known as MANPADs. (PTI)

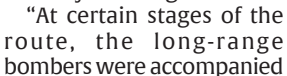
SAM METZ ■ Al-Mughayyir

He and other mourners
carried the two bodies



It said that troops had responded to reports of rock-throwing toward an Israeli civilian vehicle. The village, 15 miles (15 kilometres) north-east of Ramallah, has been an epicentre of clashes between Palestinians and Israeli settlers, with Palestinians reporting dozens of attacks in 2025, including lethal shootings, arson and vandalism. (AP)

■ Siauliai Air Base



All flights of Russian Aerospace Forces aircraft are carried out in strict compliance with international rules for the use of airspace." The ministry did not immediately respond to a request for

Many of the Russian flights that NATO monitors with its Baltic air policing mission, in place since Lithuania, Latvia and Estonia joined the alliance in 2004, are to and from the Russian enclave of Kaliningrad. Even before the war in Ukraine, NATO was intercepting Russian planes around 300 times each year, mostly over waters around northern Europe. (AP)

■ Singapore

The roadmap is part of a

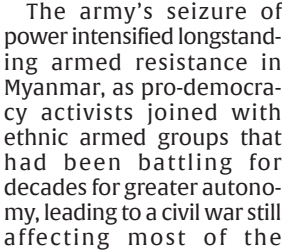
larger collaboration between the two countries in line with global decarbonisation initiatives as the world's maritime industries seek to become environment friendly, said Vijay Kumar, Secretary of the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways. "A roadmap

The MoU follows up on upgrading work based on a Letter of Intent signed on

maritime digitalisation (digital corridor collaboration) and decarbonisation (green shipping) at the same time. He also showed last year by Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, Sarbananda Sonowal. Kumar said details such as investment, storage tank capacity, pipelines,

He said both nations complement each other – India for its cheaper green energy and resources, among others, and Singapore for being a global shipping and maritime hub. (PTI)

■ Bangkok



"We all already understood that the military's fake invitations are aimed at prolonging people's subjugation under military rule," Nay Phone Latt said.

**MADHYA PRADESH RURAL ROAD
DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY**
(An Agency of Panchayat & Rural Development
Department, Govt. of M.P.)
3rd Floor, Vikas Bhawan, Arera Hills, Bhopal (M.P.)
No./4107/D-12/MPRRDA/2026 Bhopal, Dated : 21.04.2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Chief General Manager, on behalf of M.P. Rural Road Development Authority invites online **item rate** tenders on e-procurement portal <https://www.mptenders.gov.in> from Contractors registered with MPPWD or Contractors registered in appropriate class with Central Government/Madhya Pradesh Government departments, institutions, undertakings and authorities with experience in providing similar services in administrative building, hostel building, guest house and institutes under Government/Non-Government organizations/ Public Sector.

Name of Work – Providing Housekeeping Services, Security Arrangement and Comprehensive maintenance of civil works in Administrative Building, Hostel, Guest house and Academy Premises round the clock in Madhya Pradesh Rural Road Academy Bhopal.

Probable Amount of Contract - Rs. 5832000.00 (Rs. Fifty Eight Lakh, Thirty Two Thousand only)

Completion Period (In Months) – 12 Months

1. Bid document may be purchase online from **24.04.2026 (17.30 hrs.)** and last date for online bid submission is **11.05.2026 (17.00 hrs.)**.
2. Other critical dates and details can be viewed in the detailed N.I.T. and tender document on the above-mentioned portal and MPRRA, Bhopal.

**CHIEF GENERAL MANAGER
(TENDER)**

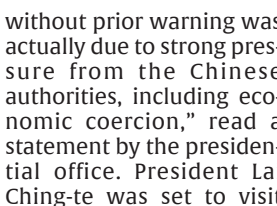
M.P. Madhyam/125427/2026

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

“Both sides emphasised enhancing cooperation in Cyber, Intelligence and Space domains, including information resilience and specialised exchanges. The exchange reaffirmed a shared commitment to



■ Taipei



“According to our understanding, the cancellation of flight permits by Seychelles, Mauritius, and Madagascar

Over the past few years, Beijing has intensified a campaign of poaching Taiwan's diplomatic allies.

STATE BANK OF INDIA

E-AUCTION
SALE NOTICE

HOME LOAN CENTRE GURUGRAM-1, PLOT NO.79, SECTOR-18, GURUGRAM - 122015, HARYANA

NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION SALE ON 24.04.2026 FOR MOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Movable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8 (g) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated /charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer State Bank of India, the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is Where is", As is What is" and Whatever there is" on 24.04.2026, for recovery of bank due to the secured creditor as under :-

Interested bidder may deposit Pre-Bid EMD with BAAANKNET before the close of e-Auction. Credit of Pre-Bid EMD shall be given to the bidder only after receipt of payment in BAAANKNET's Bank Account and up-dation of such information in the e-auction website. This may take some time as per banking process and hence bidders, in their own interest, are advised to submit the pre-bid EMD amount well in advance to avoid any last minute problem.

Date / Time of E-Auction on 24.04.2026 for 6 Hours from 10:00 AM to 04:00 PM with unlimited extn. of 10 minute each.

S. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s)	Outstanding Dues for Recovery of which Property /ies is/ are being Sold	Vehicle Description	Reserve Price (Rs.) (below which property could not be sold) Earnest Money (EMD) 10% of the Reserve Price Bid Increment Amount	Name of the Authorised (Signatory)
1.	Mr. PREM PAL S/o MR. TUKI RAM Car Loan A/c.: 44329455530	Rs.19,56,123.00 Plus Interest w.e.f. 29.11.2025 with further interest and incidental expenses, costs, charges etc. thereon	Make & Model: MAHINDRA SCORPIO - N D AT 2WD 28 S TS Regn. No.: HR72K6130 Engine No.: YGS4G78905 Chassis No.: MA1TJ2YGS6G66474 Date of Regn: 26/ 08/2025	₹ 17,82,000.00 ₹ 1,78,200.00 ₹ 10,000.00 *GST as applicable	(Chief Manager) Home Loan Centre Gurugram-1 Mr. Sudhanshu Sharma Mobile: 9199842069

Last Date of EMD Deposit on or before 23.04.2026 upto 4:00 PM
 Account/ Wallet in which EMD to be remitted : Bidder's own wallet Registered with **BAAANKNET** on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT/RTGS. EMD of Reserve Price to be transferred by bidders by means of challan generated on his/her/bidder account maintained with **BAAANKNET** on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT from his/her/bidder bank. For any assistance, please call [918291220220](tel:918291220220), support BAAANKNET@psballiance.com and/or Authorized Officer.

TERMS AND CONDITIONS OF THE E-AUCTION ARE AS UNDER:

- (1) E-Auction is being held on "As is where is", "as is what is basis" and "whatever there is basis" and will be conducted "On Line". The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider **BAAANKNET** at their web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing>
- (2) Bank shall reserve the right to cancel/postpone the auction.
- (3) The Vehicle is available for inspection during banking hours on 23.04.2026 From 10:00 AM to 04:00 PM., **Contact Person: Mr. Sudhanshu Sharma, Mob: 9199842069 (Resolution Agent) & Mr. Anuj, Mob: 8248099060 (SBI, Deputy Manager)**
- (4) *Successful bidder to pay GST as applicable on the successful bid amount, viz sale value.
- (5) To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized Officer there is no encumbrance on the property/ies. However the intending bidder should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of the property/ies put on auction and claims/rights/dues/affecting the property prior to submitting their bid.
 The E-Auction Advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of the Bank. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to the bank. The Authorized Officer shall not be responsible in any way for any third party claims/rights/ dues.
- (6) The Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of the successful bidder shall be retained towards part sale consideration and the EMD of the unsuccessful bidders shall be refunded. The Earnest Money Deposit shall not bear any Interest. The successful bidder shall have to deposit 25% of the sale price, immediately on acceptance of bid price by the Authorized Officer and the balance of the sale price on or before 15th day of the sale. Default in deposit of amount by the successful bidder would entail forfeiture of the whole money already deposited and property shall be put to the e-auction and the defaulting bidder shall have no claim/right in respect of property/amount.
- (7) For detailed terms and conditions of the sale please refer to the link at the Bank's Service Provider's web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> & e-auction website: <https://BAAANKNET.com>

Date: 21.04.2026 Place: Gurugram
Authorized Officer, State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre Gurugram-1

PROSPECT

Archana Kochhar Awarded by CM Devendra Fadnavis at Nari Shakti Vandan Event

At the recent Nari Shakti Vandan event in Mumbai, designer Archana Kochhar was awarded by Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, recognising her presence and contribution at an evening dedicated to women's empowerment. The event, also attended by MLA Ameet Satam and actor Raveena Tandon, brought together leaders and voices from across fields to celebrate the vision of the Nari Shakti Vandan initiative. During the event, Kochhar addressed the audience with a strong and relevant message, highlighting how governance in India is evolving. She spoke about the shift from merely passing bills to actively implementing them, emphasising that real empowerment comes from execution and visible change on the ground. Her words resonated with the core theme of the evening, which focused on strengthening women's participation and creating tangible impact through policy and action. The award was presented in the presence of key dignitaries, marking a significant moment within the event's larger celebration of women achievers. The evening reflected a shared vision—where policy, leadership, and voices from different industries come together to shape a more empowered future for women in India.



Dish TV's New Mantra: Kuch Chhota Sa Karne Par, Life Hogi Behtar

Dish TV, one of India's leading content distribution companies, has launched its latest campaign built on the thought, '*Kuch chhota sa karne par, life hogi behtar*'. The 'Always-On' campaign is rooted in a simple insight—that small, everyday decisions can significantly improve daily life, especially television viewing. The campaign addresses a key consumer reality where many households rely on free-to-air channels but also seek flexibility for enhanced content, often leading to inconsistent viewing experiences. Dish TV positions itself as a reliable alternative, offering a seamless and uninterrupted TV experience. Through Dish TV, users can access over 190+ channels along with a service designed to remain active even if recharge timelines are missed. This ensures flexibility and eliminates disruptions, providing a hassle-free entertainment experience. Additionally, the Freedom Pack, starting at ₹99, allows users to access enhanced content during key occasions such as cricket seasons, school holidays, and festive periods. Conceptualised by Enormous, the campaign features two master films and short edits showcasing relatable, slice-of-life moments with a light, humorous tone. These narratives reinforce the idea that small steps can make life better. Manoj Dobhal, CEO & Executive Director, Dish TV India Ltd, said, "Dish TV has always been a customer-first brand... Our 'Always-On' service and the Freedom Pack are designed to offer uninterrupted access, greater flexibility, and control, while staying true to the trust we have built over the years."

SC asks NCLAT to decide on projects of indebted Supertech

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday asked the NCLAT to take an expeditious decision on the amalgamation of the remaining 14 housing projects of debt-ridden realty firm Supertech under a court-monitored framework to ensure completion and end the woes of homebuyers.

Earlier, the top court, on February 5, upheld an NCLAT (National Company Law Appellate Tribunal) order asking the State-owned NBCC to complete 16 housing projects, out of a total 30, of Supertech Limited. The NCLAT is likely to take up the matter on April 24.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi took note of the apprehension of homebuyers over uncertainty on the completion of the stalled projects, which are still in limbo and being dealt by the debt-ridden firm unlike 16 other projects that were earlier handed over to the PSU NBCC.



The CJI requested the NCLAT to take up the pleas on an urgent basis and hear all the stakeholders, including land-owning agencies such as Greater Noida as well as farmers.

It noted that the judicial order was necessitated by the fact that the insolvency resolution professional of Supertech Ltd has been suspended due to alleged misconduct.

Earlier, the bench had opined that "the issues relating to the remaining projects also ought to be administered within the same court-monitored framework".

"Accordingly, the underlying policy with respect to all the projects, whether fully completed, substantially or partially completed, or which are lying incomplete and inactive, including those which have been handed over to

NBCC, shall be determined by a common authority that may be set up by this Court," it had said.

Now, the bench has asked the NCLAT to take a decision on the remaining projects as to whether they can also be handed over to another agency for completion under the court-monitoring framework.

The bench had earlier come to the rescue of thousands of hassled homebuyers waiting for the delivery of their houses for almost two decades and upheld an NCLAT order asking the NBCC to complete 16 projects.

It had also restrained all the tribunals and high courts from passing any order that could lead to the stalling of the construction work to be completed by the National Buildings Construction Corporation (NBCC) Limited.

The top court exercised its extraordinary power under Article 142 of the Constitution to uphold the December 12, 2024 order of the NCLAT, asking the NBCC to take over the projects in the interest of

homebuyers.

The bench noted that Supertech, according to many homebuyers, had booked around 51,000 houses for delivery during 2010-12.

The bench had directed the NBCC to undertake the projects and complete those expeditiously as envisaged by an expert committee set up by the NCLAT. It also directed the committee to provide support to the NBCC in the completion of the projects.

The NCLAT, on December 12, 2024, asked the NBCC, a public sector undertaking (PSU) under the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, to complete the 16 housing projects, comprising 49,748 homes in Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Haryana and Karnataka.

Around 27,000 homebuyers await receiving houses in these projects. The NCLAT judgment came after the October 1, 2014 order of the top court that allowed the insolvency appellate tribunal to examine and decide a proposal of the NBCC seeking to complete the stalled projects.

Indian Army celebrates World Heritage Day with tribal cultural programme



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

In a vibrant celebration of cultural diversity and heritage, the Spearhead Division of Spearcorps organised a Tribal Cultural Programme at Solung Ground, Tuting, on the occasion of World Heritage Day.

The event showcased the rich traditions of Arunachal Pradesh, with captivating performances by members of the Adi, Mema – Khamba and Idu Mishmi tribes. Participants across all age groups, from young children to elders, took part enthusiastically, adorned in their colourful traditional attire. Their performances highlighted the unique customs, music and dance forms that

have been preserved through generations. The programme was conducted under the aegis of Operation Sadbhavna, reinforcing the Indian Army's commitment towards fostering cultural awareness, strengthening bonds with local communities, and preserving the region's invaluable heritage.

The event witnessed an overwhelming response from the local populace and served as a platform to celebrate unity in diversity, while encouraging the younger generation to take pride in their cultural roots.

Through such initiatives, the Spearhead Gunners continue to promote community engagement, cultural preservation and social harmony in the region.

Assam Administrative Staff College observes National Civil Services Day

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The National Civil Services Day 2026 was observed on Tuesday at the Assam Administrative Staff College. The programme was organised by the Government of Assam's Personnel Department and the Administrative Reforms, Training, Pensions and Public Grievances Department (ARTP&PG). Dr Ravi Kota, Chief Secretary, Assam attended the programme as the keynote speaker.

In his address, the Chief Secretary highlighted the significance of Civil Services Day as an occasion for reflection on the role of civil servants in governance.

He stated that the civil services were envisaged by the



Chief Secretary Assam Dr Ravi Kota

framers of the Constitution as an institution to ensure unity, integrity and continuity in governance.

Referring to the constitutional framework relating to civil services, he emphasised that the system is based on the principles of merit, neutrality, institutional integrity and accountability. He referred to the views of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel on the

importance of an independent and impartial civil service for maintaining national unity. He also referred to the contributions of BR Ambedkar in establishing a rule-based and merit-oriented system through institutions such as the Public Service Commissions.

He further stated that civil services function as an integrated system in which all roles are interdependent. Special Chief Secretary MK Yadava, Additional Chief Secretary to the Government of Assam Mukesh Sahu, Principal Secretary to the Government of Assam GD Tripathi, Commissioner & Secretary to the Government of Assam MS Manivannan, along with a host of senior officials were present.

IIM Sirmaur chief Ajay S Shriram stresses resilience, ethical leadership for business success

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chairman of the Board of Governors of Indian Institute of Management, Sirmaur, Ajay S Shriram on Sunday underscored the importance of resilience, adaptability, and values-driven leadership amid the evolving business environment.

Shriram outlined key principles for building successful organisations and meaningful careers — remaining a lifelong learner, building and sustaining relationships based on trust and transparency, recognising that people are at the heart of every organisation, and upholding a strong value system that must be consistently practiced and lived. He also stressed that enduring success is anchored not just in competence but in character.

Addressing the 10th convocation of IIM, Sirmaur, CEO of Tata Trusts, Siddharth Sharma highlighted the broader role of

business in society, noting that enterprise is deeply rooted in philanthropy and ethics. He also exhorted the students to never waver from their moral compass irrespective of circumstances.

Encouraging them to embrace uncertainty, Sharma advised them not to shy away from unfamiliar situations, but to view them as opportunities for growth and dream big.

Director, IIM Sirmaur, Dr Prafulla Y Agnihotri highlighted the strong placement performance despite a challenging economic climate with 220 companies participating in final placements, extending over 250 offers, with an average CTC of ₹15.9 lakh per annum and a highest annual package of ₹30 lakh. Prominent recruiters included MG Motors, Dabur, EY, Tech Mahindra, Taj Hotels, and Amul, he said.

Agnihotri also presented the institute's annual report for the academic year 2025–26, highlighting key achievements

across academic programmes, research, global collaborations, placements, and institutional development. He noted that the Institute currently offers a comprehensive portfolio of programmes, including the flagship MBA, MBA in Tourism Management, MBA in Tourism, Travel and Hospitality Management (TTHM), PhD in Management, Bachelor of Management Studies, and specialized executive programmes such as the Executive MBA and Executive MBA in Digital Transformation and Analytics.

A key highlight of the year was the continued progress of the Post Graduate Programme for Executives in Leadership in Smart Manufacturing (PGPEX-LSM), offered in collaboration with RWTH Aachen University, Germany. The graduation of its first batch this year reflects the Institute's commitment to aligning management education with national priorities such as "Make in India" and the vision of "Viksit Bharat 2047."

Patna boys shine in 2nd online round, Pune comes 3rd in crossword contest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Playing solo, Dhairya Pandey of Don Bosco Academy, Patna, on Sunday clinched the top national ranking at the end of the second online round in Phase I of the national inter-school CCCC Cryptic Crossword Contest 2026. The team from DPS Patna, comprising NanyaDev Singh and Hemang Chandra took the 2nd position. The 3rd rank went to the team of Avani Fiske and Mudraa Paidarkar of SES Gurukul, Pune.

The 14th edition of this annual contest, known popularly as CCCC, is being hosted on www.crypticsingh.com. The last remaining online round in Phase I will be played on April 26. Participants have the option of representing their schools as a

two-member team or solo, according to a Press release.

The 2026 edition of this championship is being supported by the Rural Electrification Corporation (REC), a PSU Maharatna at the forefront of building India's energy infrastructure.

Among state toppers are

the teams, comprising Harsh Raj and Pratyush Kumar of Darbhanga Public School for Bihar; Rohan Maheshwari and Mehransh Singh Saluja of DPS Neelbad, Bhopal, for Madhya Pradesh; and Roshini Vallabhaneni and CN Harsitha of Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan's Public School (Vidyashram) for Telangana.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

No SS2119 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

SOLUTION (21.04.26)

4	2	1	7	5	9	8	3	6
3	7	5	2	6	8	1	4	9
8	6	9	3	4	1	7	5	2
5	3	8	4	7	6	2	9	1
7	9	4	5	1	2	6	8	3
2	1	6	8	9	3	4	7	5
6	5	7	1	3	4	9	2	8
1	8	3	9	2	7	5	6	4
9	4	2	6	8	5	3	1	7

No SS2118 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
WEDNESDAY | APRIL 22, 2026

ACROSS

3 Container of riches, treasure, perhaps (5)
8 Word of warning about crime, initially, from the police (5)
10 Has tasteful associations, but can be shaky in use (5)
11 Hill in a pastoral area (3)
12 Moira confused an islander (5)
13 Nude in an exotic act or show (7)
15 Fabulous Greek author (5)
18 One said to have been successful (3)
19 Irregular stripe in computer graphics (6)
21 When a New York father, being obliging, will help (3,4)
22 Depend merely on me being away (4)

DOWN

1 Germanic deity who gave woman new heart (5)
2 Thin, bony, but not exactly scraggy? (7)
4 Race of theatre goers (4)
5 Treat the new potatoes with jam? (6)
6 One determined to be an essayist? (5)
7 Only a serf, but he had plenty! (5)
9 Opprobrious thing to do (3)
12 Just say the word (7)
14 A novel name for "9" (3)
16 Examines what may be fit for consumption by saints! (5)

15, Genie
16, Ta-Ken
18, Angel
19, Be-Sid-es
21, Heckle
22, Twin-ge
23, Res-is-t
25, Barts
26, Vest
28, And

SOLUTION (21.04.26)

ACROSS

19, Being
20, C-hives
22, Tire
24, Hen
25, Bet-wee-n
26, V-it-al
27, Ski-E-d
28, Angie
29, Seating
30, Beats
31, Death

DOWN

2, Rear-Ed
3, Stream
4, Try
5, A-void
6, Sacking
7, Play
8, R-ache-L
12, Me-Des
13, Ran-ch
14, Lat-i-n

15, Genie
16, Ta-Ken
18, Angel
19, Be-Sid-es
21, Heckle
22, Twin-ge
23, Res-is-t
25, Barts
26, Vest
28, And

BRIEFLY

Chelsea Clinton completes Boston Marathon



Former first daughter Chelsea Clinton finished the Boston Marathon on Monday and her parents were waiting at the finish line to congratulate her.

The 46-year-old author and the vice chair of the Clinton Foundation ran the 26.2-mile (42.195-kilometre) race in 3 hours, 40 minutes, 52 seconds. Joining former President Bill Clinton and former Secretary of State Hillary Clinton to meet her at the finish line was 2014 champion Meb Keflezghi – the last American man to win the race.

According to athlinks.com, Chelsea Clinton has run six other marathons, including New York four times, and Monday's run was a personal best.

Other notable participants who ran in Monday's record-setting race included astronaut Suni Williams, who finished in 5:52:49; hockey Hall of Famer Zdeno Chara, who ran it in 3:18:00; 2018 Boston winner Des Linden, who finished second in the women's masters division in 2:35:49; and 1968 men's winner Amby Burfoot, who finished in 5:11:29.

2027 women's Tour de France to debut team's time trial



The 2027 women's Tour de France will debut a team's time trial on the streets of London.

Details of the other first two stages in England were revealed by organisers on Monday.

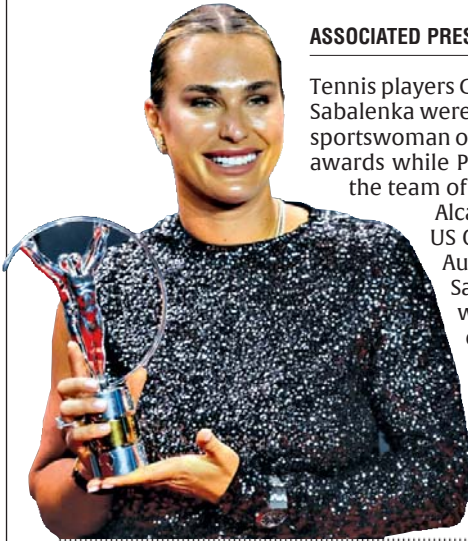
The race will start in Leeds on July 30, 2027, with the peloton heading towards Manchester. The next day they go from Manchester to Sheffield. The riders have two days of racing through Yorkshire and the Peak District.

The third stage in London features riders in teams of seven on an 18-kilometer circuit with a finish on The Mall.

"The team time trial has always been one of the most exciting and spectacular formats in cycling," race director Marion Rousse said. "The United Kingdom has already shown its passion for the Tour, and these stages will once again showcase the energy of the crowds, the beauty of the landscapes and the growing importance of women's cycling on the world stage."

The 2027 men's Tour begins in the Scottish city of Edinburgh on July 2. The opening stage passes through Midlothian and the Scottish borders and ends in Carlisle, outside the city's medieval castle.

Alcaraz and Sabalenka win Laureus awards



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Madrid

Tennis players Carlos Alcaraz and Aryna Sabalenka were named sportsman and sportswoman of the year at the Laureus awards while Paris Saint-Germain was the team of the year.

Alcaraz won the French and US Opens last year plus the Australian Open in January. Sabalenka, the top-ranked woman, won her second consecutive US Open last year. PSG broke through with its first Champions League title in 2025.

Rory McIlroy, who successfully defended the Masters title this month, received the

comeback of the year award. Barcelona and Spain star Lamine Yamal, aged 18, won the young sportsperson of the year prize. Formula One champion Lando Norris received the world breakthrough of the year award.

German soccer great Toni Kroos won the world sporting inspiration award, and retired gymnast Nadia Comaneci got the lifetime achievement prize. The world action sportsperson award went to American snowboarder Chloe Kim. Brazilian Gabriel Araujo was the world sportsperson of the year with a disability.

The awards ceremony in the Spanish capital was hosted by tennis great Novak Djokovic and freestyle skier Eileen Gu.



Injured Alcaraz awaits wrist tests



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Madrid

Defending two-time champion Carlos Alcaraz has put his participation at the French Open in doubt because of a right wrist injury.

Medical tests in the next few days will determine whether Alcaraz will be able to play in the Grand Slam tournament in a month, he said on Monday.

"We'll see," he said when asked whether he'll play. The Spaniard was at the Laureus Awards in Madrid with his right wrist immobilized. He pulled out of the Madrid Open last week.

"The next (medical) test will be crucial," the seven-time Grand Slam champion told Spanish television channel TVE.

"We've been trying to do everything we can do to make sure that this test goes well. I'm trying to be very patient. But we are good, we are just waiting a little bit. We have a few tests in the next few days and then we will see how the injury is, and what the next steps will be."

No. 2-ranked Alcaraz withdrew in Barcelona a day after he had his wrist treated during his opening match, a 6-4, 6-2 victory over Otto Virtanen. The next tournament after Madrid is the Italian Open, which he won last year.

Al-Ahli rally into AFC Champions League Elite final

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Jeddah (Saudi Arabia)

Defending champion Al-Ahli reached the final of the AFC Champions League Elite after Ivan Toney's second-half goal beat Vissel Kobe of Japan 2-1 on Monday.

In Saturday's final in Jeddah, Al-Ahli will face Shabab Al-Ahli of the United Arab Emirates or Machida Zelvia of Japan, who meet on Tuesday.

Al-Ahli came from behind after Vissel Kobe took the lead in the 32nd minute. Yuya Osako headed a free kick into the path of Yushinori



Muto, who finished from close range.

Al-Ahli came close to equalising just before half-time when Rayad Hamad

hit the post with a header, and England striker Toney backheeled narrowly wide moments later.

Toney had the ball in the

net five minutes after the restart, running clear to fire low from just inside the area, but the effort was ruled out for offside.

Kobe nearly doubled its lead soon after, only for Daiju Sasaki's shot to rebound off the crossbar.

Al-Ahli equalized in the 62nd when Brazilian winger Galeno curled a shot into the top corner from 25 meters.

The Saudi side went ahead eight minutes later when the Kobe goalkeeper's parry fell to Toney, whose first-time shot went in through a crowded six-yard box.

Riyad Mahrez thought he had added a third with 15 minutes remaining but the effort from the former Manchester City star was disallowed for offside.

Wolves relegated after Crystal Palace, West Ham draw

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

West Ham drew at Crystal Palace 0-0, gaining an important point in its fight to avoid relegation and ensuring the demise of the Premier League's bottom club Wolverhampton Wanderers.

Wolves cannot amass enough points in its last five games to avoid the drop and will return to the Championship for the first time since 2018.

Relegation looked inevitable for the Midlands club for most of a woeful season but even a string of more encouraging performances over the last couple of months could not save it.

The end came far from home in a list-



less match in south London.

West Ham had the better of the opening exchanges but the scoreline remained goalless at

half-time. Although Palace perked up in the second half it did not create many chances and neither goalkeeper was very busy.

The point was nevertheless welcomed by the Hammers, who moved two clear of Tottenham Hotspur in 18th place.

"A point at the end of the

day isn't the worst thing in the world," captain Jarrod Bowen said.

"We're trying to keep West Ham in the Premier League. We can't rely on anyone else, we need to look at ourselves and keep fighting to stay in the Premier League."

Palace, which has won only three of its last 26 Monday night games in the Premier League, remained in 13th. Goalkeeper Dean Henderson's shutout was Palace's 12th clean sheet of the season, a record bettered only by the top two Arsenal and Manchester City.

"(That record) is an unbelievable return for our league position," Henderson said. "The defensive unit is so good, anyone who steps in has been excellent. That's the foundations we've built and hopefully add some goals at the other end."

CM Bhagwant Mann meets hockey legend Bovelander



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Chandigarh

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Tuesday reached out to celebrated Dutch hockey legend Floris Jan Bovelander, offering to tap into his expertise to further strengthen hockey in the state, especially in the lead-up to the prestigious Asian Champions Trophy.

During a detailed meeting, Mann, who is currently on a visit to the Netherlands, discussed the broader ecosystem of hockey and sports in Punjab, emphasising the government's commitment to restoring the pristine glory of the national game.

He lauded 60-year-old Bovelander's exceptional skills and immense contribution to hockey, noting that his remarkable journey continues to inspire young players across the globe.

Last month, Mann had said that the upcoming Asian Champions Trophy will be

hosted by Punjab in October this year.

The ACT will also be the first international hockey tournament to be held in Punjab under the aegis of the International Hockey Federation (FIH) and the Asian Hockey Federation (AHF).

Mann invited the legendary Dutch drag-flicker Bovelander to Punjab, saying the state is keen to facilitate his engagement with athletes to sharpen their skills and exposure.

Mann said Bovelander has graciously accepted the invitation and added that he will be engaging with Punjab athletes and motivating them ahead of the upcoming ACT.

Mann on Saturday embarked on a visit to the Netherlands to strengthen bilateral partnerships and attract investments across key sectors including food processing, logistics, alloys and steels, pharmaceuticals and information technology, officials had said.

Dos Santos signs pro deal after surviving fatal bar fire in Switzerland

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Metz (France)

After surviving a fatal bar fire in Switzerland on New Year's Day, French soccer player Tahiry Dos Santos has signed his first professional contract with Metz.

The Ligue 1 club announced the one-year contract signing late Monday, nine days after the 19-year-old defender returned to play for its reserves team.

Dos Santos was severely burned in the fire at a bar in ski resort Crans-Montana in the early hours of Jan. 1 that killed 41 people and

injured more than 100.

"This moment has an even more special meaning after the difficult months I went through in the hospital," Dos Santos said in a club statement. "This test made me stronger and taught me to never give up."

The French teenager, who has family ties to Cape Verde, joined his local club Metz at age eight. His return to action on April 11 was in the French fifth-tier division.

Metz is last in



Ligue 1 and will be relegated to play in the second tier next season.

A product of Metz' youth academy, Dos Santos is described by the club as "a tireless worker and exemplary both on and off the field."

After being named captain of the reserve team at the start of the season, he began training with the first team and earned his first call-up at the end of December for a French Cup

match. "I am very happy and proud to sign my first professional contract with my training club. It's the culmination of many years of work, sacrifice, and determination to achieve my childhood dream," he said.

That dream could have come to an abrupt end in Crans-Montana. But Dos Santos managed to survive the inferno.

While he could have escaped before the fire spread, he turned back to rescue his girlfriend Coline from the restroom.

"We had been in the bar for thirty or forty minutes, the atmosphere

was good," he told L'Equipe newspaper earlier this year. <

"Coline wanted to go to the restroom, so I went with her. I came out before she did and headed toward the exit. That's when I saw the flames. I immediately understood we were in danger. I didn't think - I turned back to get her. I shouted her name, and she immediately saw in my eyes that something was wrong. She followed me right away."

Dos Santos recalled that he was separated from his girlfriend after they both slipped in a staircase as panic spread.

Hagi returns for second stint as Romania coach

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Bucharest (Romania)

Romania great Gheorghe Hagi has been hired as national team coach for the second time. He was appointed to replace Mircea Lucescu, who died two weeks ago.

The 61-year-old Hagi is widely regarded as Romania's greatest ever soccer player, having led the country to the World Cup quarterfinals in 1994. He also played for Barcelona and Real Madrid as a creative attacking midfielder.

His first stint as Romania coach was in 2001 and lasted three months, ending after failing to get the team through the playoffs for the 2002 World Cup.

Hagi has since coached clubs in Romania and Turkey — including Galatasaray and Steaua Bucharest — but is



back in charge of the No. 56-ranked national team, which will not be at the World Cup in the United States, Canada and Mexico.

The Romanians lost to Turkey in the playoffs, after which Lucescu fell ill and stepped down as coach. He

died April 7, at the age of 80.

"It is an honor and a great responsibility to represent Romania once again, as I did as a player," Hagi said in a statement released by Romania's soccer federation.

"I am convinced," he added, "that we can achieve

beautiful things. I hope that the performances I had as a player, I will also have as a coach. I am convinced that we can become the best."

Romania last played at the World Cup in 1998. It reached the round of 16 at the European Championship in 2024, losing to the Netherlands. Hagi's first games in charge will be friendlies against Georgia and Wales in June. Romania is in a Nations League group with Sweden, Bosnia and Herzegovina, and Poland starting in September.

He has signed a contract through to the 2030 World Cup, with the task of "bringing the national team back into the elite of world football," the federation said.

Federation president Razvan Burleanu said his organisation has made "several attempts over time" to get Hagi to become coach again.

Tushar, Mannat share lead at AM Green IGPL

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lubumbashi (Congo)

Young golfers Tushar Pannu and Mannat Brar turned in a matching six-under 67 to share the lead after the opening day of the AM Green IGPL Invitational Congo here.

Pannu, 21, who turned pro last year and came through the Qualifying School, had five birdies, an eagle, and one bogey in his superb round, while Brar, 19, the newly minted Women's Golf Association pro, was bogey free for the day.

The AM green IGPL Invitational Congo is the fourth leg of the Tour and this week is the third event in African Swing.

After the opening leg in Chandigarh, the AM Green IGPL travelled to Mauritius and Joburg, South Africa.

As Pannu and Mannat shared the top spot, rookie



pro, Sukhman Singh, son of former top amateur Simarjeet Singh, shot 5-under 68, to lie sole third at the Par-73 Golf Club Lubumbashi.

Aman Raj, a multiple AM Green IGPL winner in 2025, shared the fourth place with Harendra Gupta, as they all



shot 4-under 69. Hot on their heels was last week's winner, Udayan Mane, the in-form Indo-American Manav Shah and Syed Saqib Ahmed — all of who shot 3-under 70 and were tied-sixth.

Seven players, including Saarthak Chhibber, Sunhit

Bishnoi, rookie pros Danish Verma and Kanav Chauhan, Digraj Singh Gill, IL Aalaap and Aryan Roopa Anand were all tied for the ninth place with scores of 2-under 71 each.

Mannat is attempting to become only the second Indian woman golfer to win a mixed gender pro event. Last year Pranavi Urs became the first one to do so at AM Green IGPL Mumbai.

In the team competition, Atri Mumbai, who did well last week, were once again in great form as Pannu (67) and Aman Raj (69) carried them to the first day's lead at 10-under and two ahead of Leander Paes' team, Flying Man Kolkata, for whom the stars were Sukhman Singh (68) and Syed Saqib Ahmed (70). Green Fuels Vizag powered by Manav Shah (70), who was third last week, and young Danish Verma (71) were third at 5-under.

SRH beat DC by 47 runs in Hyderabad

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Hyderabad

Sunrisers Hyderabad defeated Delhi Capitals by 47 runs in their Indian Premier League match here on Tuesday.

Invited to bat, Abhishek Sharma blazed away to an unbeaten 35 off 68 balls to steer SRH to a mammoth 242 for 2.

The SRH bowlers, led by Eshan Malinga (4/32), then stopped DC for 195 for 9.

Earlier in the game, Abhishek Sharma scythed through a hapless Delhi Capitals bowling attack with a scintillating unbeaten century as Sunrisers Hyderabad posted an imposing 242 for 2 on a placid track in an IPL match here on Tuesday.

Abhishek (135 not out off 68 balls) was at his imperious best as neither Nitish Rana's (0/55 in 4 overs) off-breaks bothered him nor did Lungi Ngidi's (0/41 in 4

overs) dipping slower ones had any effect on his strokeplay as he smashed 10 sixes along with an equal number of boundaries.

Even with a relatively off-colour Travis Head (37 off 26 balls), he added 97 for the opening stand. Then skipper Ishan Kishan (25 off 13 balls) joined the party, adding another 79 runs for the second wicket in just 5.5 overs to create a beautiful launchpad for the final assault.

Towards the end as Abhishek seemed a bit tired, Heinrich Klaasen chanced his arms to hit a quickfire 37 not out off 13 balls.

Delhi Capitals' ploy of starting with an off-spinner, that too a mediocre part-timer like Nitish Rana (0/55 in 4 overs), backfired badly as he was given four overs in which he was hit for half a dozen sixes -- all off left-handed batters.



The DC coaching staff headlined by Director of Cricket Venugopal Rao and head coach Hemang Badani have not exactly been at their tactical best throughout the tournament and Tuesday was one such occasion.

Rana bowled a tidy first over but then the second went for 20 and after strategic time-out, he was again given two more overs out of which one went for 23.

Even skipper Axar Patel (1/23 in 2 overs) will have some answering to do as to why he as a frontline spinner didn't complete his quota and why Kuldeep Yadav (0/30 in 2 overs) was not trusted after one bad over (22 runs) but someone like Rana was persisted with.

In all, the two and half spinners (half being Rana) that DC bowled with went for 108 runs in their cumulative eight overs.

The Powerplay overs yielded 67 but where DC completely lost the plot was during the middle phase between overs 7 to 15 in which 116 runs came, which is unacceptable.

The hallmark of Abhishek's innings was how he adjusted the downswing of his bat depending on the bowlers -- especially Ngidi, whom he played late and in-front. It seemed like Abhishek was in a mood to exhibit his range-hitting skills as most of his sixes were hit in-front of the wicket.

It was a slightly slower century by his standards. Even then, Abhishek managed a strike-rate northwards of 200 by completing his century of 47 balls. But he didn't stop there as Sunrisers Hyderabad reached a score for which a chase looks quite improbable with the kind of batting depth that DC have.



Parag's poor form, middle order woes worry RR

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lucknow

The form of the middle order, particularly that of skipper Riyan Parag, will be a key concern as Rajasthan Royals look to arrest a slide after back-to-back defeats when they take on a struggling Lucknow Super Giants in an IPL match, on Wednesday.

Placed third in the points table, the inaugural edition champions began their campaign with four successive wins but have since faltered in their last two outings.

They suffered a 57-run defeat to Sunrisers Hyderabad after collapsing dramatically, losing five wickets for nine runs against pace. In their previous match against Kolkata Knight Riders, RR let a strong position slip as Rinku Singh engineered a stunning turnaround to hand KKR their first win in seven matches this season.

As for Parag, a surprise choice as their skipper after Sanju Samon's exit, has endured a pathetic run with the bat, registering three single-digit scores in six innings with a highest of just 20 so far. The top-three, in Yashasvi Jaiswal, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi and Dhruv Jurel, has been RR's main force with the bat this season, but the side has often struggled when they fail. While Parag is

woefully out of touch, veteran Ravindra Jadeja has looked a shadow of his past self, while Guyanese big-hitter Shimron Hetmyer (39 runs from four innings) is yet to fire. However, batting coach Vikram Rathour has backed his skipper to come good.

"As far as I am concerned, it is just a matter of time. Not everyone makes runs every time," Rathour had said of Parag's poor run, after their defeat to Kolkata Knight Riders at Eden Gardens.

"Teams run in such a way that some stay in form, some stay out of form. There is no doubt that he will come back and win us a few games on his own as a batter."

Fielding has also been a concern for RR. Nandre Burger dropped Rinku on 8, a lapse that proved costly as he, along with Anukul Roy, turned the game in the death overs. However, despite the setbacks, RR appear a stronger unit than LSG, who are languishing in ninth place after three consecutive losses.

RR boast one of the most effective opening pairs this season, with Sooryavanshi in fine form and Jaiswal providing consistent starts. LSG bowlers will need early breakthroughs to stay competitive. However, that may not be easy as LSG's bowling attack is reeling after being taken apart by Punjab Kings.

Ayush Mhatre ruled out of remainder of IPL 2026



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Chennai Super Kings batter Ayush Mhatre has been ruled out of the remainder of the ongoing IPL season due to a hamstring injury, dealing a major blow to the five-time champions.

The franchise said Mhatre, who sustained the injury during CSK's previous game against Sunrisers Hyderabad on April 18, will require a rehabilitation period of six to 12 weeks.

"Ayush Mhatre has been ruled out of the remainder of IPL 2026 due to a left hamstring injury sustained while batting during the match against Sunrisers Hyderabad on April 18.

"Ayush's injury will require a rehabilitation period of 6-12 weeks," CSK announced on its social media on Tuesday.

The 18-year-old, who came in as an impact substitute, was seen in visible discomfort and clutched his hamstring while attempting a run during CSK's 10-run loss to SRH in Hyderabad.

He required on-field treatment and, although he continued briefly, was dismissed soon after.

"It looks pretty bad, unfortunately. And he's going to be a big, big loss because he's been in really nice touch for us," CSK's batting coach Mike Hussey had said at the post-match press conference.

Mhatre has been CSK's standout batter this season. He led collecting 201 runs from six matches at a strike-rate of 177.87.

Chennai Super Kings have endured a poor start to the 2026 season, losing four of their six matches to languish in eighth place.

We can be unstoppable: Tilak Varma

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Tilak Varma credited his match-winning century to "adapting to conditions" and expressed confidence that Mumbai Indians can be "unstoppable" from now on if they execute well, given the number of World Cup winners in their squad.

Tilak's explosive 101 not out powered MI to a commanding 99-run win over Gujarat Titans in Ahmedabad, ending their four-match losing streak in IPL 2026.

"It was very important for the team and for me," Tilak, who has been struggling for form in this season, told JioHotstar.

"Over the last four or five games, the one thing constantly running through my head was that I hadn't spent much time in the middle and hadn't faced many balls, so my aim was to spend some time at the wicket and then adapt according to the team's situation."

Speaking about his approach, Tilak said he assessed the pitch early and focused on straight hitting.

"Whenever MI comes to Ahmedabad, they usually give us a black-soil wicket, which is a bit slow in nature. It's not that our batters cannot adapt, but we know what we can do if there is more bounce," he said.

"Since it was slow and low, we had to adjust and try to hit straight. There wasn't much

bounce, so playing across the line to deliveries in line with the stumps was risky.

"I decided to hit straighter, and I read the conditions well; thankfully, I was able to score some runs."

On his preferred batting position, Tilak said he enjoys batting at No. 3 but remains flexible.

"Personally, I like batting at number three a lot. However, I am happy to bat wherever the team needs me, because since childhood, I have practised in a way that allows me to play confidently in any position.

"But if someone asks me, I would always say number three."

With the win lifting Mumbai Indians to seventh in the table, Tilak remains optimistic about a turnaround.

"I am grateful that it worked out that way. However, we shouldn't look too far ahead and should take one match at a time. Every game is almost like a knockout for us.

"We know what we are capable of, having several World Cup winners in the side, experienced players, and the skills we possess.



Shafali climbs two spots to sixth in ICC rankings

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

India opener Shafali Verma climbed two places to sixth in the ICC Women's T20I Batting Rankings after her half-century against South Africa in the ongoing five-match T20I series.

Shafali struck a 57 off 38 balls in the second T20I in Durban last Sunday, but India lost to the hosts by eight wickets, slipping to 0-2 in the series. India had also been defeated in the opening T20I at the same venue by six wickets, with Shafali contributing 34 runs.



India vice-captain and Shafali's opening partner, Smriti Mandhana, has slipped one spot to fourth after an underwhelming showing in the two matches so far, scoring 13 and 12. She has been

overtaken at Number 3 by West Indies' Hayley Matthews.

India captain Harmanpreet Kaur has climbed two places and is now on the brink of the top 10, currently ranked 11th. She scored

an unbeaten 47 in the first T20I.

Women's World Cup hero Jemimah Rodrigues has suffered a notable drop of four places and is now ranked 14th among batters following a subdued run of form.

The series serves as crucial preparation for both teams ahead of the upcoming T20 World Cup, scheduled to begin in June in England and Wales. South Africa captain Laura Wolvaardt has retained her fifth position among T20I batters, sitting behind Australia's Georgia Voll, following a fine half-century in the second match against India.



Sony acquires broadcasting rights for Asian Games 2026 in India

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Sony Pictures Networks India has secured the exclusive broadcast rights for the 20th Asian Games Aichi-Nagoya 2026, scheduled to be held in Japan from September 19-October 4.

As per the deal, the continental showpiece will be telecast on Sony Sports Network channels and streamed on Sony LIV across India and the subcontinent.



India will head into the Games on the back of a historic campaign in the previous edition, where it secured a record 107 medals.

"We are proud to bring this continental multi-sport event back to Sony Pictures Networks for the third time," Rajesh Kaul, Chief Revenue Officer and Business Head— Sports and International, SPNI said in a release.

The Asian Games, one of the biggest multi-sport events globally, will feature 41 disciplines,

including 32 Olympic sports, with new additions such as mixed martial arts and surfing. Traditional events like cricket, tennis, esports, kabaddi, sepak takraw and kurash will also be part of the programme.

Cricket is expected to be a major attraction for Indian audiences, with both men's and women's teams in contention for top honours.

"India's historic performance at the last edition, where the nation crossed the 100-medal

milestone for the first time, has ignited unprecedented interest in multi-sport events," he said.

"The stage is set for another unforgettable chapter with the inclusion of cricket along with a formidable Indian contingent ready to chase new milestones.

"We are committed to delivering immersive coverage that celebrates every medal and inspires millions across the country as our athletes strive for greatness once again."

PCB in talks with Saudi board to build cricket stadium in Jeddah

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lahore

The Pakistan Cricket Board is in talks with the Saudi Arabia Cricket Federation to build a stadium in Jeddah, a proposal that has already received approval from the PCB's Governing Board.

Sources within the PCB revealed that chairman Mohsin Naqvi is leading discussions with Saudi cricket officials, and an expression of interest for the stadium's construction has already been submitted.

"The PCB wants to promote cricket in the Saudi Kingdom and also hold some Pakistan



Super League matches there, but a final document is yet to be signed for starting work on the new stadium," the source said. He added that discussions are underway to identify a suitable site for the stadium, which will feature

floodlights and a seating capacity sufficient for top-level matches, including the potential to host PSL games.

The source added that Saudi cricket officials had approached the PCB for the project, noting that the oil-rich kingdom has recently shown a growing interest in promoting cricket and has even explored the possibility of launching its own T20 league.

"Talks are in the initial stages but PCB has made it clear it is on board with the Saudi body because of the brotherly ties between the two countries," the source added.

Holder calls selection chatter unnecessary energy

TAPAN MOHANTA ■ Kolkata

Fretting about selection "consumes a lot of unnecessary energy" for West Indies' seasoned pace-bowling all-rounder Jason Holder, who insists he has moved on from expecting things to "fall into my lap" as he waits for his opportunity with Gujarat Titans.

The 34-year-old, returning to the IPL after two seasons following a ₹7-crore deal, has so far been overlooked with the franchise persisting with an overseas combination of Jos Buttler, Rashid Khan, Glenn Phillips and Kagiso Rabada.

But following GT's 99-run shellacking by Mumbai Indians at their home in Ahmedabad on Monday could prompt a rethink with Holder providing option of bowling both inside the power play and at the death, and also donning a finisher's hat with the bat.

In an exclusive interview

with PTI, the tall Bajan spoke about remaining focused on staying ready for a call-up rather than get distracted by the outside noise pertaining to selection.

"For us, getting consumed with when to play, or who's to play, or if not to play, or if this person should be playing or not... to me, it just consumes a lot of unnecessary energy," Holder said.

"Your job as an individual player is to be ready — just come in and do a job for the team when called upon. The rest of it is in our hands. "So I wouldn't even get sucked into who should play, or where we should be working, or who should bat or bowl.

It's just more or less about what is required for us as a team to win." Asked about his ideal batting position, he said: "Look, whatever position I'm needed in is ideal for me.

